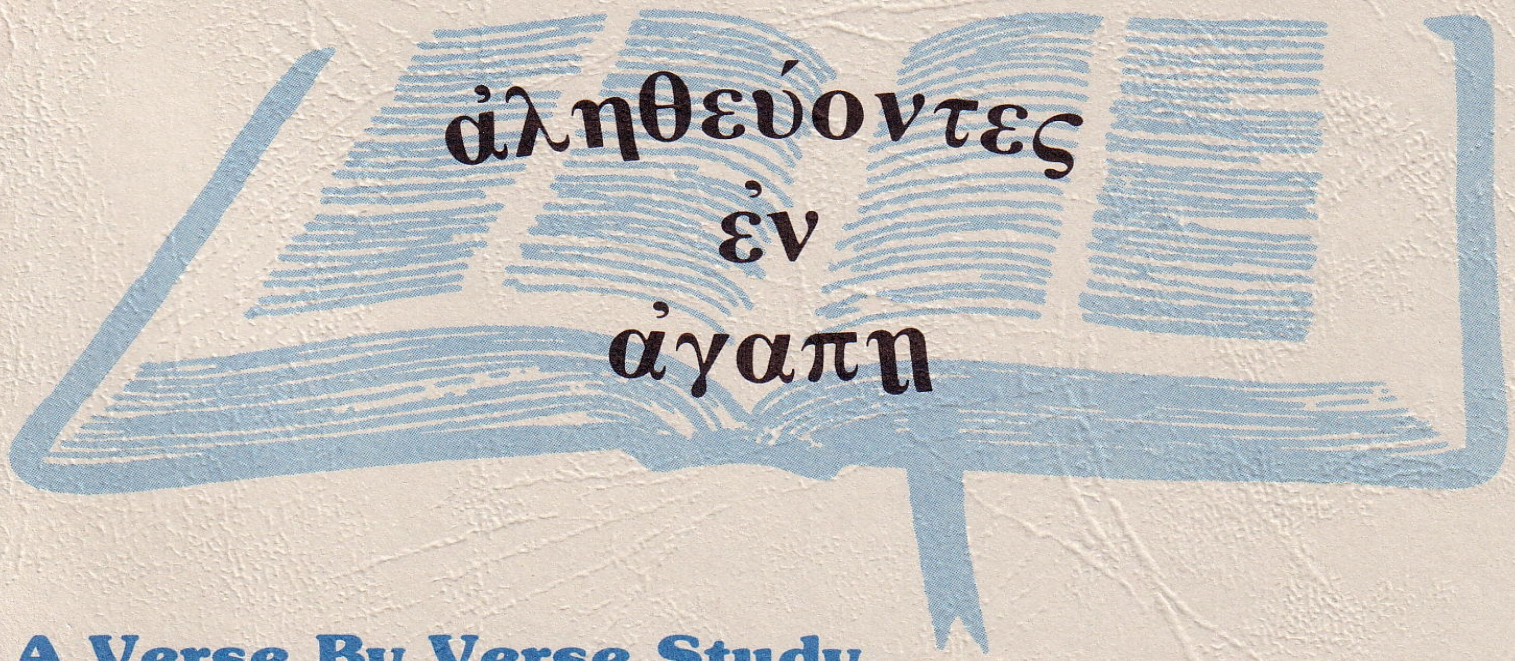
A Commentary Of

ROMANS

Chapters 9 - 16

Volume 2

Based On The Greek New Testament



A Verse By Verse Study

By

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ROMANS
Volume 2

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ernest R. Campbell was born at Michigan, North Dakota, in 1915. His farm environment instilled in him the importance of hard work, gave a breadth of experience, and encourage independent thinking and initiative. He moved to Oregon in 1933. For four years he worked in the electrical and radio broadcasting fields.

He received his B. A. degree from the University of Oregon. His major was in English literature, which has strengthened his ability in Biblical interpretation. His B. A. also included a major (hours beyond B. A.) in psychology and two years of classical Greek. He earned his B. D. and Th. D. degrees from Northern Baptist Theological Seminary. His major Greek New Testament was under the renowned Greek scholar, Dr. Julius R. Mantey.

He has taught New Testament Greek at North Park College. He was Dean of the faculty at the Detroit Bible Institute where he taught beginner through advanced New Testament Greek. He has been the pastor of the Salem Bible Church for thirty years during which time his ministry has been based entirely on the Greek New Testament. Simultaneous with this he had taught private Greek classes prior to the beginning of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary.

The author was one of the founders of an evening school in 1973, which became the forerunner of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary. At this time he introduced a new natural method of teaching New Testament Greek, which is now enabling Canyonview students to teach directly from their Greek New Testaments.

As the president of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary the author's supreme burden is to equip students to literally teach the books of the Bible in a verse by verse manner. He is convinced that the ability to teach from the Greek New Testament is the most important single factor in accomplishing this end in an interesting and authoritative manner.

The author realistically recognizes that it is not possible for all Bible teachers to acquire competency in New Testament Greek. This is why he has written this commentary, the Second in a series on Paul's epistles, that the English reader may more fully share in the treasures of the Greek text!

EDITOR'S PREFACE

to Romans

To enable you to more fully enjoy this commentary on Romans, we would like to preface it with an explanation of some of the features.

First, you will see all verse quotations set in ***bold italic***. If the quotation is from the Old Testament it will be set in **regular bold.**

Second, the verse translation is that of Dr. Campbell. Any difference with the accepted translations is not an attempt to be different or add to confusion, but to clarify the Greek meaning. Any similarity with other translations is a matter of coincidence.

Third, whenever cross references are noted and the book reference does not appear, the chapter and verse refers to Romans.

Fourth, at times you will notice the word "grace" capitalized. We have chosen to do this whenever "grace" refers to the dispensation of *Grace*. Just as we capitalize "Law of Moses" when referring to the dispensation of the Law, we will capitalize "Grace" and any synonyms (mystery, church, or body of Christ) when they refer to the particular dispensation.

Fifth, you will see some unusual, hyphenated word combinations. This is the author's attempt to convey the meaning of one Greek word and its tense in a literal way, with one English, hyphenated word.

Sixth, it must be remembered that in the original manuscripts all the letters were upper case; no words were capitalized because all the letters were capitals. Therefore, in this commentary, pronouns which refer to Deity are not capitalized in the translation, even when the relationship to Deity may seem obvious. At times the connection between the pronoun and its antecedent are not obvious and capitalization becomes a matter of interpretation rather than translation. Therefore, in order to avoid interpretation in our translation, none of the pronouns will be capitalized. The author will deal with the pronouns in the body of the commentary.

INTRODUCTION

In the preface contained in volume one we emphasized the importance of studying and teaching the Books of the Bible in an expository, verse by verse manner. Since volume two is a sequel to one, the same preface also applies to it.

In this introduction we will consider the purpose for which chapters 9-16 were written. In order to grasp most accurately Paul's purpose, through that which he has written, we will give a synoptical resume of each paragraph in each chapter.

Since details regarding the date Romans was written are included in the introduction of the first volume, we will merely state the conclusion here - approximately A.D. 56 in Corinth.

PURPOSE

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER NINE is to verify his anguish for his kinsmen, the Israelites, whom God made custodians of His word, and the progenitors of Christ's fleshbody (1-5). He explains that God's word has not failed because many Israelites lack faith, for only those of the promise are children of God, those called according to His elective purpose (6-13). He affirms that God does not act unrighteously, but bestows mercy selectively, and leaves whom he will in stubbornness (14-18). He attests that God has the sovereign right, via mercy, to create one sinner for his honor and glory, and leave another sinner, void of mercy, unto dishonor and the displaying of His wrath and power unto destruction (19-26). He quotes Isaiah to prove that only a remnant out of Israel will be saved (27-29). He explains that the Gentiles obtained the righteousness out of faith, which Israel missed while pursuing law-righteousness out of works (30-33).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER TEN was to let them know that he was petitioning God for the Jews, who were zealous but ignorant of the righteousness of God, the summation of which is Christ to everyone believing (1-4). Law-righteousness was acquired by perfectly keeping the Mosaic Law, whereas faith-righteousness is freely given to both Jews and Gentiles who believe that Jesus is Lord (5-13). Paul explains three steps in evangelizing: a preacher must be sent, his message must be heard and it must be believed. Consequently, faith in the Lord results from hearing the Word of Christ (14-17). According to Isaiah and Moses, Israel heard God's Law but disobeyed it; likewise, the Jews have heard but disobeyed the gospel (18-21).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER ELEVEN is to inform them that God has not cast off His people whom He foreknew. He himself, a saved Jew, is evidence, as well as the fact that there is a remnant as in Elijah's time, an elect group, a status obtained by election via grace (1-10). He says that if the fall of Israel has resulted in the salvation and riches of the Gentiles, how much more the fulness of Israel will enrich them (11-12). He directs his message to the Gentiles to provoke some Jews to be saved. If their rejection achieved the reconciliation of the world, their reception will be life out from the dead (13-16). The Jews, the branches of the good olive tree, were broken off due to unbelief, and the Gentiles, the branches of the wild olive tree, were grafted in by faith. If the Jews do not remain in

unbelief, how much more God will graft them into their own olive tree (17-24). He wants them to know about the secret of Israel's partial hardening, which will continue until the fulness of the Gentiles, that they may not esteem themselves wise (25-27). He informs the Gentiles that the Jews are enemies of the gospel because of them. Regarding election, the Jews are beloved ones because of the fathers, and their present disobedience is so that God might have mercy on all, i.e., all depend upon the mercy of God for salvation (28-32). He expresses amazement at the unsearchable riches, wisdom and knowledge of God which the Spirit has revealed to him in these chapters. He marvels because all things are out of God (the source), through God (the agent) and have their end in God (His glory; 33-36).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER TWELVE is to encourage believers to present their bodies a living, holy and well-pleasing sacrifice to God, and to be transformed by the renewing of the mind so as to prove God's will (1-2). He tells each believer to recognize his God-given ability, a requirement for the smooth functioning of the Body of Christ, constituted of many members with different gifts (3-8). He explains to them that believers are to refrain from hypocrisy, evil and slothfulness; instead they are to live aggressively for the Lord and for the benefit of others (9-13). They are to bless those persecuting them, share the joys and sorrows of others, and associate with the lowly (14-16). They are not to return evil for evil nor avenge themselves, but to conquer evil with good (17-21).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER THIRTEEN is to instruct believers to be subject to civil authorities, for they have been arranged by God to punish evil and promote good. Since the functions of government require money, believers are to pay taxes (1-7). Believers are not to owe one another anything except love, which is the fulfillment of the precepts of the law, for love does no evil to a person (8-10). Paul endeavors to arouse them out of their spiritual sleep, to put off the works of darkness and put on the armor of light, i.e., to put on Jesus Christ and make no provision for the lusts of the flesh (11-14).

INTRODUCTION

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER FOURTEEN is to inform them that fellow-believers have no right to despise and judge one another on the basis of what they eat or what days they observe - each one is free to follow his own convictions (1-6). He explains that whether we live or die, as those who are the Lord's, we do it to the Lord. We are not to despise or judge our brother, for we all shall stand before the judgment seat of God, and each one shall give account concerning himself (7-12). Instead of judging one another, believers should walk in love; avoid eating food which grieves and destroys; recognize that God's present kingdom is not physical, but righteousness, peace and joy in the Spirit; and that the one serving Christ in these pleases God. Everything should be avoided which causes a brother to stumble (13-21). The believer must have faith (be persuaded) that he is right before God, not judging himself by approving wrongdoing. He is condemned when he eats with doubts (22-23).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER FIFTEEN is that strong believers, like Christ, might not please themselves but rather edify the weak. The fact that Christ bore the reproaches against God was written for our teaching, that we might have endurance, encouragement and the same mind as Christ, resulting in unified glorification of God (1-6). Believers are to receive one another unto God's glory. Christ has been made a minister of the Jews on behalf of the truth of God, to confirm the promises given to them, and to the Gentiles on behalf of the mercy of God, to glorify God. Paul desires that they may have joy and peace as they believe (7-13). He wants them to know that he is confident that they are full of goodness, knowledge and the ability to admonish one another. Since the Gentile ministry had been given to him, he wrote boldly to them, speaking only of that which Christ had effected through him from Jerusalem to Illyricum, being desirous not to preach where Christ had been named (14-21). Finally, after having been hindered many times, Paul is free to go to Rome. His plan is to visit them, and with their help, to continue on to Spain. First, however, he is going to Jerusalem with the offering from the churches in Macedonia and Achaia, which having completed, he will see them on his way to Spain (22-29). Paul asks them to pray that he might be delivered from unbelievers in Judea, that his offering may be acceptable to the saints, and that he might find rest with them when he arrives in Rome (30-33).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER SIXTEEN is to recommend that they receive and assist Phoebe (1-2). He sends salutations to several individuals, a church, and to all the saints (3-16). They are to note those who cause divisions contrary to his teaching and turn away from them, for they deceive the innocent; instead, they are to be wise in that which is good (17-20). Paul lists the names of those who send their personal greetings (21-24). Finally, he commits them to God who is able to establish them according to his gospel, even the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery (25-27).

Chapter 9

1. ***"I speak the truth in Christ, I do not lie, my conscience bearing witness with me in the Holy Spirit,"***

Paul's emphasis in this verse is on the fact that what he is about to say *is the truth*. The statement, "I speak the truth in Christ," affirms that he is speaking as one who has a relationship with Christ, which, in itself, verifies the truthfulness of what he will be saying. Also this statement conveys the idea that he is speaking as one *in the presence of Christ,* i.e., Christ is a witness of what he is saying (cf. 2 Tim. 4:1; 2 Cor. 11:10).

From the negative point of view, Paul says, "I do not lie." The Greek verb used for "lie" (ψευδομαι) means that *he did not speak falsely or deceitfully.* What he says about his burden and longing to see his Jewish brethren saved is true; it is no lie (1 Tim. 2:7). He is speaking about the depth of his subjective emotional anguish on behalf of his own people, something which was not overt, but nonetheless very real (Phil. 2:27; 2 Cor. 11:28-29).

As Paul attests to the genuineness of his feeling toward his fellow Jews, he adds, "my conscience bearing witness with me in the Holy Spirit." First, the Greek noun translated "conscience" (συνειδησεως) is a compound word and literally means *to know with* or the *place where internal knowledge intersects.* The conscience, generally speaking, is the sum total of that which *has and is being impinged upon the mind.* It is a reliable guide to the extent that the Holy Spirit feeds the Truth for the Body of Christ into it (1 Tim. 1:19; 3:9).

Now let us observe that Paul's conscience was bearing witness *together with what he was saying at that moment in time.* His conscience, formed according to the Truth revealed for the Church (Gal. 1:12), was testifying to the truthfulness of what he was currently writing to them. He speaks of his conscience *corroborating the greatness of the concern he expresses* for them in this epistle.

It is important to note that Paul's conscience is operating "in the Holy Spirit." This means that his mind was functioning *within the sphere of the Holy Spirit,* i.e., in accordance with the Mystery Truth given for this dispensation of Grace by the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 2:10; Eph. 3:2-3). God has spoken His final message for the Church through His Spirit. It contains everything which is needed for teaching, reproving, correcting, and disciplining that believers may be complete and equipped for every good work (2 Tim. 3:16-17).

2. ***"that I have great grief and unceasing pain in my heart."***

In this verse Paul gives us insight into his mental and emotional anguish for his brethren according to the flesh, the Jews. The Greek noun for "grief" (λυπη) may also be rendered *sorrow, distress*, and *heaviness*. He describes this grief as being "great" (μεγαλη), *large*, or *very much.* Even though the word "mind" (νους) is not specifically mentioned in conjunction with this great grief, it is feasible to

think that Paul primarily has in mind *mental grief and sorrow*. There is a precedent for this interpretation in both the Classical and New Testament Greek (John 16:20; 2 Cor. 7:10).

Furthermore, Paul says that I have "unceasing pain in my heart." The Greek noun translated "pain" (οδυνη) conveys the idea of *hurting* and *suffering*. The adjective rendered "unceasing" (αδιαλειπτος) means that he had *incessant, unintermittent,* and *constant pain* in his heart. This work, in its various forms, is often used to depict physical pain such as birth-pangs. Paul is obviously using the word "heart" (καρδια) with a meaning similar to that of the "mind" (νους); however, he is probably implying that he was anguishing and hurting both mentally and emotionally for his Jewish brethren.

3. ***"For I was wishing that I myself to be accursed from Christ for the sake of my brethren, my kinsmen according to the flesh,"***

As commonly translated this verse is seemingly self contradictory, and as a result has perplexed many believers. The answer to this puzzling enigma is relatively simple - the proper translation of a Greek tense. The main verb in this verse is in the *imperfect tense*. It depicts *continuous action* in *past time*. Its meaning is accurately conveyed by the English words "I was wishing" (ηυχομην), *I was beseeching,* and *I was praying.* This verb sets the stage for what Paul is saying in this verse *to the time when he was a religious Pharisee* under the Mosaic Law. It speaks about what Saul of Tarsus was doing before Jesus Christ confronted him on the Damascus Road.

Now let us examine what Paul is actually saying in this verse in its proper historical setting. He is affirming that there was a time in the past when it was his wish, desire, and prayer "to be" (ειναι), *to exist* as one "accursed" (αναθεμα), *devoted to evil,* and *anathema* from Christ. The evidence suggests that this was during the period subsequent to the Day of Pentecost when many of the Jews were believing on Jesus Christ as the Messiah (Acts 2:41, 47; 4:4; 5:14). It was a time when the very existence of Judaism was being threatened, for even a large number of the priests were obedient to the faith, i.e., believing that Jesus of Nazareth was the promised Messiah (Acts 6:7). These were difficult days for the zealous guardians of Judaism.

Now we must keep in mind that the *reason* Paul was wishing to exist accursed from Christ was for the sake of his brethren, his kinsmen according to the flesh. As a devout Pharisee he confidently believed in Judaism and adherence to the Mosaic Law according to its interpretation. As far as Jesus Christ was concerned he was wishing and praying to exist in an *accursed relation to Him, to be away* "from Christ" (απο του Χριστου). He probably knew some of the priests, some of his peers, who had defected from Judaism and accepted Jesus as the Messiah. As one who firmly believed that Judaism was the true religion for all Jews, his prayer was that he might *continue separated from Christ,* true to Judaism, "for the sake of" (υπερ), *on behalf of,* and for the furtherance of the spiritual welfare of his Jewish brethren. The fact that Paul was wishing and praying to continue

accursed from Christ suggests that even at that time he may have had some nagging thoughts that Jesus of Nazareth might be the Messiah.

4. ***"who are Israelites, to whom belongs the adoption and the glory and the covenants and the giving of the law and the Divine service and the promises,"***

This verse describes those who are Paul's brethren and kinsmen according to the flesh. First, they are "Israelites" (Ισραηλιται). This name was conferred on Jacob in Genesis 32:28. It was passed on to Jacob's descendants (Gen. 34:7; Deut. 4:1).

Second, Paul refers to his brethren as those "to whom belongs" (ων), *who possess* the "adoption" (υιοθεσια). This means that God has placed Israel in a sonship relation to Himself (Ex. 4:22; Hos. 11:1).

Third, to Israel belongs the "glory" (δοξα). As God's people, glory belonged to Israel and it will be fully expressed in the Messianic Kingdom (Matt. 19:28).

Fourth, the "covenants" (διαθηκαι) belonged to Israel. This means that God made *arrangements, dispositions,* and *wills* with Israel which confirmed her future relationship to Him (Isa. 55:3; Acts 3:25).

Fifth, the "giving of the law" (νομοθεσια) belonged to Israel. This means that God *placed, imposed upon*, and *enacted* the Law through angels by the hand of Moses (Ex. 20:1-17; Gal. 3:19). It was specifically *given to Israel* not the Gentiles.

Sixth, the "Divine service" (η λατρεια) belonged to Israel. This speaks of the *sacerdotal ministry of the Aaronic priests* as they served in the first sanctuary, that which involved sacrificing upon the altar (Heb. 9:1, 6).

Seventh, the "promises" (επαγγελιαι) belonged to Israel. These promises go back to Abraham. God promised to him *a land*, that He would make him *a great nation*, and that through him all the Gentiles would be blessed (Gen. 12:1-3). Christ has been made a minister "on behalf of the truth of God, unto the end to confirm the promises of the fathers" (15:8).

The foregoing gives us a brief resume regarding Paul's brethren according to the flesh. They were chosen in Abraham, made a very special people, and the Word of God was transmitted to and through them (3:2). As a zealot under Judaism, Paul fervently endeavored to get them to keep the Law, even to the extent of persecuting the opposition unto death (v. 3; Acts 7:58-60; 8:3; 1 Tim. 1:13). As the Apostle Paul, the dispenser of the Gospel of God's Grace, he had grief and pain in his heart for his Jewish brethren due to their lack of response to the Gospel (v. 2).

5. ***"to whom belong the fathers, and out of whom is Christ according to the flesh, the one being over all, God blessed forever, Amen."***

In this verse Paul adds two more things to the foregoing list. Eighth, the "fathers" (πατερες) belong to his kinsmen according to the flesh, Israel. The three most prominent fathers of Israel were Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Matt. 8:11, cf. Acts

3:13; 5:30). This name is also used with reference to later progenitors of Israel (Acts 7:11-12, 52).

Ninth, *out of the race* of the fathers Christ was born according to the flesh. This lineage is through Mary, His natural mother, and Joseph, His legal father (Matt. 1:16; Luke 3:23). The fact that God should choose the stock of Israel through which to give His Son a flesh and blood body is the greatest favor He could bestow upon Paul's kinsmen according to the flesh (Gal. 3:16; 4:4; 2 Cor. 9:15).

The statement translated "the one being over all" (ο ωϖ επι παντων) is generally referred back to Christ. Also, the nominative article, with which it begins, is commonly translated *who* as though it was a relative pronoun. We prefer to translate more accurately the nominative article and participle "ων" *the one being over all*. In the light of First Corinthians 15:28, Second Corinthians 11:31, Ephesians 4:6, and the grammatical construction in this verse, we prefer an alternative translation of the last part of this verse.

That we may pick up the flow of the context, the following is a feasible rendering of this entire verse: "to whom belong the fathers, and out of whom is Christ according to the flesh. God is the one being over all, blessed forever, Amen." The Greek preposition translated "over" (επι) may also convey the idea that God is the *basis, support,* or *the one upon whom all things depend.* As the one who is the basis for all things, God is certainly over all things. It is also significant to observe that the Greek word translated "blessed" (ευλογητος) is used eight times in the New Testament - always with reference to God the Father.

Summarizing, the thought seems to be that God is the basis, hence, the one over all things, particularly, all things which pertain to His relationship to His people Israel. Even though most of the Israelites are rejecting God's message of Grace, God still uses it to provoke the Gentiles unto salvation (11:11).

6. ***"But it is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all those out of Israel, these are Israel;"***

Paul is literally saying that it is *not the kind* or *sort of thing* (ουχ οιον) *that* (οτι) would indicate the Word of God has "failed" (εκπεπτωκεν). This is a compound Greek verb derived from the preposition "εκ" prefixed to the verb (πιπτω) and basically means *to fall out of* or *away from.* As used here it is saying that the Word of God *has not fallen away from its intended purpose;* i.e., *it has not become ineffectual and of no effect.*

Now can Paul affirm that the Word of God has not failed when the evidence indicates that it was reaching few Jews for Christ? His answer is that "not all those out of Israel, these are Israel." Looking *at all* those who were descendants of Abraham, the percentage of those who were believing on Jesus Christ was small. On the other hand, when one recognizes that all descendants of Abraham are not necessarily counted as Israel, then the percentage of those being saved is very high, and the Word of God has not failed.

The meaning of the statement "these are Israel" (ουτοι Ισραηλ) is defined in the subsequent context. True Israel consists of those who are called (v. 7) according to God's elective purpose (v. 11). Those who constitute genuine Israel are the descendants of Abraham via Isaac, via Jacob, who have been called according to God's sovereign purpose (2:28-29; 8:28-30; Gal. 6:16).

7. ***"neither because they are the seed of Abraham, are they all children, but,* In Isaac your seed shall be called,"**

The mere fact that they were descendants of Abraham does not make them children. Ishmael and Esau were descendants of Abraham, but neither they not their offspring have any part in the promises given to Abraham. Just because one is a physical progeny of Abraham does not mean that he will inherit the promises made to Abraham.

Having declared that all Abraham's flesh children are not his spiritual children, Paul emphatically says, "but" (αλλ'), the opposite is true, for "In Isaac your seed shall be called." As a result of Ishmael's mocking, Sarah told Abraham to put him and his mother, Hagar, out of the household (Gen. 21:10). God confirmed that Abraham should take this action, even though it was difficult for him, explaining to him that "In Isaac your seed shall be called" (Gen. 21:12). Isaac was Abraham's *miracle son* according to God's promise. Ishmael was Abraham's flesh son according to the will of the flesh, at Sarah's request (Gen. 16:1-6).

When Hagar fled from Sarah, the angel of the Lord appeared to her in the wilderness and told her to return and submit to Sarah (Gen. 16:7-9). At the same time, the angel told her to call her child Ishmael and predicted that "he shall be as a wild ass among men; his hand shall be against every man, and every man's hand against him; and he shall dwell over against all his brethren" (Gen. 16:12). This passage certainly gives us insight into the reason for the continuous struggle in the Middle East.

8. ***"That is, not the children of the flesh, these are the children of God, but the children of the promise are counted for a seed."***

The Greek phrase translated "that is" (τουτ' εστιν) suggests that this verse is primarily an explanation of what was said in the preceding verse. Some men, such as Ishmael and Esau, had merely a flesh relationship to Abraham; this in itself does not make them children of God. The Greek phrase rendered "children of God" (τεκνα του Θεου) speaks of *children who belong to God or children who are God's possession*. It is one thing to be a child of Abraham according to the flesh, but it is a great advancement over this to be a child of God according to both *promise* and *election*.

We must keep in mind that as Paul proceeds in this context he continues to limit those who are children of God. First, they are not all of Abraham's offspring. Ishmael, born according to the will of the flesh, is passed by and receives no spiritual inheritance. Second, as this context unfolds, we see Esau rejected; he receives no spiritual blessing. On the other hand, the children of the promise, the

promise that God would provide Abraham with a son through Sarah, are the true spiritual seed.

9. ***"For this is the word of promise,* At this time I will come and Sarah shall have a son."**

This promise is recorded in Genesis 18:14 (cf. v. 10). We must keep in mind that Abraham and Sarah, even when they were young and healthy, were not able to produce children. When the Lord made this promise to Abraham, Sarah was old and beyond the childbearing period. The thought of her giving birth to a son was so ridiculous that she laughed within herself. The Spirit of God has specifically recorded this incident to make it crystal clear that *Sarah, within herself, was totally incapable of giving birth to a child* (Gen. 18:11-15). There is no question about it. When the Lord told Abraham that Sarah would give birth to a son, He was literally declaring that He was going to *perform a miracle*, cause an aged barren woman to *conceive* and bring forth a *male child*. The *subject* of this sentence, the one who made this promise, was none other than the Lord Himself.

On the basis of God's sovereign calling of Abraham together with the miracle performed to effect Isaac's birth, it can unequivocally be affirmed that Israel is indeed *a miracle nation*. She is not merely a nation among nations, but a very special nation, a people who have a *key role* in God's purpose of the ages.

10. ***"And not only, but also Rebecca out of one conceived, even Isaac our father;"***

The thought here is that not only Sarah gave birth to a son according to the promise, but also Rebecca conceived sons (twins) by Isaac. It appears to me that a more literal translation of the Greek would be: "also Rebecca out of one, Isaac our father, by a conjugal act (κοιτην) was with child." The information given to us in this verse suggests that this was a very normal conception; however, prior to this Isaac had prayed for almost 20 years about his wife's barren condition. His prayers were abundantly answered; his wife conceived twins, who began struggling in her womb even before they were born (Gen. 25:22-24).

11. ***"for the children not yet having been born, neither having practiced anything good or bad, in order that the purpose of God might remain according to election,"***

Some Greek texts differ on where verse 11 ends and verse 12 begins. This is insignificant as long as we adhere to the meaning of the larger context. The setting of this verse is during the time when the twins, Esau and Jacob, were still in Rebecca's womb. It was before they had occasion to do anything good or bad. This provided an ideal situation for Paul to use to depict the difference between the *sovereignty of God* and *human works*. Two viable persons are encased in a womb in which they were isolated from doing either good or evil.

During this time when these two potential men were isolated in their mother's womb, totally apart from any works, the Lord said that "the elder shall serve the younger" (Gen. 25:23). Paul uses this genuine historical event as evidence proving that God's relation to men is *determined by His sovereign elective*

purpose. It is not determined by what men may or may not do a very important phrase in this verse is "the purpose of God" (προθεσις του Θεου). This means that God operates according to a *pre-placed, pre-designed,* and *predetermined plan.* Even though Esau was the firstborn, the one who normally would have inherited the promise, yet according to God's elective purpose it was reserved for Jacob (vv. 12-13; Gen. 25:23).

Now let us consider why God dealt with Esau and Jacob as He did. Paul says that it was "in order that the purpose of God might remain according to election." The verb translated "remain" (μενη) was to the end that the purpose of God *might continue, continue unchanged,* and *remain constant* according to election. The thought is that God's purpose had hitherto operated according to election, and this is evidence that it continues to operate in this way. Subsequent to the Adamic fall, all natural men have been spiritually dead, incapable of making any spiritual advances toward God, totally dependent upon God to sovereignly bring them into a relationship with Himself (8:28-30). Regardless of whether the issue is those who are true Israelites, or those who have been chosen from among the Gentiles, God is quietly but surely accomplishing His purpose by calling His elect unto Himself (2 Tim. 1:9-11; 2:10).

12. ***"not out of works but out of the one calling, it was said to her that the elder shall serve the younger."***

As we have already mentioned, some translations have the first part of this verse as the last part of the preceding verse. It obviously refers back to the statement "that the purpose of God might remain according to election." The thought is that Jacob did not inherit the promise "out of works" (εξ εργων), i.e., *works were not the source* from which his priority position came. In contrast to works, the strong adversative rendered "but" (αλλ') emphatically asserts that God, the one who called him, is the source from whom he received the right to be Abraham's true heir.

In the light of God's sovereign election of Jacob let us take a brief look at the birth and lives of Esau and Jacob. Esau was born first with Jacob a close second - "his hand had hold on Esau's heel" (Gen. 25:25). As a result of being born first, Esau had birthright privileges. Rebecca, the mother, knew that the Lord had called Jacob to be the heir (Gen. 25:23); therefore in Genesis 25:27-34 we have an account of how the birthright was transferred from Esau to Jacob.

Let us examine the statement, "it was said to her that the elder shall serve the younger" (Gen. 25:23). The Hebrew may be translated: "the chief shall serve the lad," hence, the chief, the older, shall serve the lad, the younger. Observe, this statement was directed to Rebecca. We assume that Isaac also knew it. Granting that he did, why did he intend to bless Esau instead of Jacob (Gen. 27:1-4)? This appears to be an act of disobedience in itself, hence, the reason Rebecca thwarted it (Gen. 27:5-23).

13. ***"Even as it has been written,* Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated."**

In speaking to the prophet Malachi, the Lord said, "I loved Jacob, but Esau I hated, and made his mountains a desolation, and gave his heritage to the jackals of the wilderness." The words *love* and *hate* are commonly used with a *comparative* rather than an absolute meaning. In comparison to God's love for Jacob, He hated Esau; i.e., *He loved him less* than Esau, which is seen in the fact that He gave him a lesser inheritance (Mα1. 1:2-4).

The statement "Even as it has been written" is commonly used by Paul in his early epistles. The perfect passive verb translated "it has been written" means that Paul continued to accept the Old Testament as the Word of God (2 Tim. 3:14-16).

14. ***"What shall we say then? Is there unrighteousness with God? May it never be!"***

As a consequence of the statements that the older shall serve the younger, and that God loved Jacob and hated Esau, Paul raises the question, *what therefore* or *then shall we say*? Since God made this choice between Jacob and Esau before they were born, apart from them doing anything, is He unrighteous for treating them differently? The Greek grammar used demands a negative answer - no, God is not unrighteous for favoring Jacob and withholding favor from Esau.

To reinforce the fact that God is not unrighteous, Paul adds the phrase, "May it never be" (μη γενοιτο), *let it never be*, commonly translated *God forbid*. The use of the optative mood, the prayer mood, lends some credence to the free translation God forbid. The important point to observe is that God treated Esau according to what he deserved as a sinner, but He treated Jacob according to His grace which He bestowed upon Abraham. God cannot be accused of being unrighteous when He treats men better than what they deserve.

15. ***"For he says to Moses,* I shall have mercy on whom I would have mercy, and I shall have compassion on whom I would have compassion."**

This verse makes it clear that God reserves the right to be selectively merciful and compassionate. Paul uses what God said to Moses to substantiate the principle that it is His prerogative to choose to do good to whom He might will. The Greek verb translated "I shall have mercy" (ελεησω) is in the future tense and means *I shall show favor* in a positive, helpful sense. The verb immediately following, translated "I would have mercy" (ελεω), is in the present tense and subjunctive mood. The thought is that God shall have mercy *on whom He would or might desire.* It is God's prerogative to select the recipients of His mercy, favor, and beneficence.

The Greek verb translated "I shall have compassion" (οικτιρησω) is also in the future tense. The basic meaning of this word in the classical Greek is pity, i.e., God shall have a feeling of *pity and grief, a passive negative feeling of sorrow.* The Greek verb translated "I would have compassion" (οικτισω) is in the present tense and subjunctive mood. Paul's point is that God shall have compassion *on whomever He would or might desire*. It is in the sphere of God's jurisdiction to express His feelings of compassion, pity and grief for whomever He pleases.

We perceive that the Greek word rendered "compassion" (οικτισω) portrays God's passive empathic feeling for the plight of sinners. On the other hand, the Greek word for "mercy" (ελεω) expresses that which follows compassion. Because God is compassionate, He unfolds His mercy and favor toward whomever He may desire. Compassion involves God *passively sympathizing* with the grief of sinners, whereas mercy involves God *actively working* on behalf of sinners (Eph. 2:4-5).

16. ***"Then therefore it is not of the one willing neither of the one running, but of the one showing mercy, God."***

In view of the preceding context Paul points out that which *causes God to energize* on behalf of depraved men. God is not impressed with the sinner's will power, determination, and intentions. Neither is He moved by the unsaved man's expenditure of human effort, for He evaluates it as *filthy rags* (Psa. 14:1-4). The sinner who thinks, by his own human willing and running, that he is in charge of his own destiny needs to consider carefully what this verse is saying. Sinners, engulfed in disobedience to God, *totally lack* the spiritual dynamic necessary to initiate a relationship with God, who is a Spirit (John 4:24).

Having rejected man's willing and running as that which effects a relationship with God, Paul emphatically says, but (αλλα) *it is of the one showing mercy, God.* In contrast to human mental and physical effort, Paul firmly answers *no; a relationship to God has its source in the mercy of God*. According to Ephesians 6:4 the love of God is the precursor of the mercy of God. God's love for the Adamic race, even though in a state of rebellion, has caused Him to extend His mercy toward it selectively. Apart from the extension of God's mercy, choosing individuals in Christ, *not one* of Adam's descendants would have a relationship with God (John 6:44; Eph. 1:4).

17. ***"For the scripture says to Pharaoh,* That unto this very end I raised you up that I might display in you my power and that my name might be published abroad in all the land."**

In this verse Paul personifies the Scripture, written by God the Spirit, as God speaking to Pharaoh. According to this verse God is the one who raised up Pharaoh to the position of authority which he occupied in Egypt. The implication is that God didn't raise up just another Pharaoh, but one who was peculiarly suited to fulfilling His twofold purpose.

First, it was God's purpose to "display" (ενδειξωμαι), manifest, and declare His power in the Pharaoh. of Moses' day. Apart from Pharaoh's unrelenting refusal to let the Children of Israel leave Egypt, God's miracle-working power would not have been manifested. Second, it was God's purpose to use Pharaoh to "publish abroad" (διαγγελη), *proclaim*, and *declare* His name in all the land. The Greek word for "land" (γη) may also be rendered *earth, region,* or *country*. Considering the limited historical setting, it appears that the translation earth may be too broad.

18. ***"Then therefore he has mercy on whom he will, and he hardens whom he will."***

As the Greek words "then" (αρα) and "therefore" (ουν) indicate, Paul's conclusion in this verse is the consequence of what he has said in the previous verses. As we have already observed, God selectively gives mercy, favor, and help to sinners according as He wills. On the other hand, in comparison to those who receive mercy, those devoid of it are referred to as ones He "hardens" (σκληρυνει), *makes obdurate,* and *stubborn*. All sinners by nature exist in a state of hardness and callousness against God. As those who refuse to acknowledge God, they have been given over to Satan (1:21, 24, 26, 28). As those totally depraved, there is no reason to think God would doubly condemn them (Acts 19:9).

19. ***"Therefore you will say to me, Why then does he still find fault? For who has resisted his will?"***

Having said that God gives mercy to whom He desires, and he leaves in a state of hardness whom He desires, Paul recognizes that some may misunderstand or pervert what he has said. In order to preclude them asking the question when he is not there to answer it, he asks it himself: if this is true, *why then does God still find fault*? If God takes the initiative in extending mercy to some and leaving some in their depraved condition, how can He "find fault" (μεμφεται), *blame*, or *be dissatisfied* with what they do? If God wills and determine whether men will be in the category of mercy and blessing or in the category of depravity and condemnation, then, with reference to where they are categorized, it is a Divine determination.

In dealing with the question Paul poses here, we need to go back to God's original purpose in Adam and Eve. Man was created in the image and likeness of God to exist in a cooperative relationship with God. This was God's purpose for Adam and Eve and *all* their progeny. The entire human race was to be in fellowship with the Creator.

Subsequent to Adam and Eve's rebellion against God, men have been *spiritually dead, doomed to physical death* (Gen. 3:3, 19). In spite of the Adamic curse, which lies heavily upon the human race, God has a secondary purpose to restore some men into fellowship with Himself. God's original purpose was *universal salvation* for all men, but sin, having entered into the world, changed that. *His present purpose is to save some*, those whom He has chosen (1 Cor. 9:22; Eph. 1:4).

The whole world lies totally depraved in the evil one (Rom. 3:9-19; 1 John 5:19); all men are sinners by nature (Eph. 2:1-3). In view of man's self-imposed sinful condition in Adam, which has left him spiritually dead, he is totally incapable of reaching out toward God. This is the dilemmatic plight of the human race; neither is it interested, not can it elevate itself into a relationship with God. Due to this terrible impotent condition of sinners, God, because of His magnanimous love, *has sovereignly shown mercy to some* (Eph. 2:4) and left the rest in their exceedingly sinful dilemma (7:13).

Now let us examine more closely the question, "For who has resisted his will?" If we limit our consideration to God's sovereign giving mercy to some, and leaving others in their hardened condition, then, on the surface, it appears that no one has resisted His will. If our perspective focuses on the sinners left in their sin, then we must recognize that all have "resisted" (ανθεστηκεν), *stood against,* and *opposed* the will of God.

20. ***"Yes rather, o man, who are you replying against God? Shall the thing formed say to the one who formed it, Why have you made me thus?"***

In this verse Paul chides the man, whom he was warding off, by asking questions in the preceding verse. Instead of him questioning God's right to find fault, Paul turns the tables on him, saying, who do you think you are, you who are replying against God? The Greek participle rendered "replying against" (ανταποκρινομενος) is derived from "αντι" and "κρινομαι" and literally means *judgment from that is against, an against-answer,* or *an answer which rejects what God has said.* The issue at stake here is God's sovereignty, His modus operandi involved in bringing men into a relationship with Himself. Those who reject God's sovereign electing, giving mercy, and calling out of a people today should take Paul's chiding seriously - it is also directed to them.

Paul goes on to say, "Shall the thing formed say to the one who formed it, Why have you made me thus?" The use of the negative "μη" in the first part of this question indicates that *such a question is illegitimate;* the thing made has no right to question the wisdom of its maker. The implication is that those receiving the mercy and those left to continue in their hardness have no right to question what God has done. God is the one who establishes and determines that which is right and wrong. He is infinite and omniscient, we are finite and ignorant.

21. ***"Or does not the potter of the clay have authority from the same lump to make one vessel unto honor, and another unto dishonor?"***

This verse paints a picture for us of a potter who has *absolute authority* over the clay, the raw material, with which he works. The potter represents God who has absolute authority, whereas the clay represents men in their dead-in-trespasses-and-sins state. Out of this clay, on the basis of mercy, God makes some vessels to be used in His presence. These are vessels of "honor" (τιμην), *great worth, valuable,* and *precious.* On the other hand, God makes out of this clay vessels of "dishonor" (ατιμιαν), comparatively speaking, *without worth and value,* for menial and servile use (2 Tim. 2:20-21).

As we gaze at this picture of the potter fashioning clay, our attention is drawn to the fact that he has *complete power over the clay*, to make out of it anything he pleases. Furthermore, we observe that he only has *one lump of clay*, which constitutes the raw material used to make vessels fit for a king. Without adding or deleting any ingredients from this lump, it is also used to make vessels for the most menial uses. This picture *does not suggest* that God makes some men, who represent His lump, worse than what they were as progeny of Adam. The basic ingredients of God's clay remain the same.

22. ***"And if God, willing to manifest the wrath and to make known His power, endured with much longsuffering vessels of wrath having been fitted unto destruction;"***

Since it is very important that we accurately interpret this verse, we have translated it as literally as possible. This verse speaks of that which God was *willing to put up with* to show wrath against sin and His power. The thought is that God was willing, in order to "manifest" (ενδειξασθαι), *point out,* and *display* the wrath and to make known His power, to patiently endure vessels of wrath. The phrase translated "the wrath" (την οργην) is not rendered *His wrath*, for it does not have the possessive pronoun *His* (αυτου) associated with it. The emphasis is on *wrath* and *anger against sin*, a requisite in a moral universe, and not on the one who expressed this wrath. Other passages make it clear that the source of this wrath is God (1:18; 3:5; Eph. 5:6).

The second thing God willed to make known is "His power" (το δυνατον αυτου), *might,* and *ability*. The revealing of wrath and His power is seen against a background of sinful vessels destined for destruction. The key verb in this verse is translated "endured" (ηνεγκεν), and means *He bore with* and *put up with* vessels of wrath with much longsuffering, i.e., it required much patience on God's part to endure the insults and blasphemy of Adam's depraved offspring. Paul describes them as "vessels of wrath" (σκευη οργης), vessels who *belong to wrath*, "fitted" (κατηρτισμενα), a perfect participle, who had been *fitted, mortised together*, and *knit together* unto the end of "destruction" (απωλειαν), *perishing*, and *death* at the time of the Adamic fall.

23. ***"and that he might make known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy, which he prepared beforehand unto glory."***

The key verb in verse 22 was endured (ηνεγκεν). This same verb plays a key role in verse 23, which ties together the thoughts in both verses. God patiently enduring vessels of wrath, in the process of pointing out wrath and His power, is basic to making known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy. If we are going to grasp the greatness of the riches of God's glory, we first must understand *the wrath which rested upon the sinful human race.* This wrath and anger doomed all sinners unto destruction and death (6:23).

As God's mercy, motivated by His love, is extended to a vessel of wrath, the greatness of God's power is seen in His ability to deliver one from so great a wrath. The greater our appreciation of the wrath against man's sin, the greater will be our appreciation of the power of God which is able to extricate him, and the riches of His glory will become more fully known to us. In order to measure God's power we must begin with the *depth of man's depravity* and extend to the *height of God's glory.* Failure to see man as he is presented in the Word of God, as one utterly undone and totally depraved, will result in failure to understand the greatness of God's power.

Having observed that even vessels of wrath play a role in magnifying the power of God, Now let us look at what is said about the vessels of mercy. First, Paul

says that God was willing to endure patiently the awful effrontery of vessels of wrath, in order that He might make known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy. The phrase translated "the riches of His glory" (τον πλουτον της δοξης αυτου) conveys the idea of *the wealth and rich benefits* which belong to His glory, to the *weightiness of* the Person of God.

These vessels of mercy were "prepared beforehand unto glory." The Greek verb translated "prepared beforehand" is derived from "προ" and "ετοιμαζω" and literally means *in prior time* or *previously to make ready or prepare*. The only other time this verb is used in the New Testament is in Ephesians 2:10, where we note that in prior-time God prepared good works for believers to do. The thought here is that in prior-time God prepared certain individuals to become vessels of mercy, to become the recipients of God's elective mercy. They are persons who have been predestined unto ultimate glorification with Christ (8:17; Phil. 3:21).

24. ***"even us, whom he called, not only out of the Jews but also out of the Gentiles."***

Keeping the context intact, Paul says regarding the vessels of mercy, "which he prepared beforehand unto glory, even us, whom he called" out of both Jews and Gentiles. Here Paul identifies us believers as the vessels of mercy, as those who were prepared beforehand, and as those whom God had called. The same thought is presented in the eighth chapter, where Paul says, "and whom he predestined, these he also called." The pronoun "us" (ημας) is used with reference to *all believers* in this verse. We point this out because often Paul limits its meaning to himself and Jewish believers.

In such passages as this, the verb translated "called" (εκαλεσεν) represents a given stage in God's leading of men into a relationship with Himself. It speaks of *the Holy Spirit's calling and wooing* those who have previously been prepared and predestined to receive mercy. As a part of God's sovereign soteriological program, it is naturally irresistible. It is that which the Holy Spirit does as the emissary of God the Father (John 6:44).

As Paul deals with the issue of God sovereignly calling individuals to be vessels of mercy, he never speaks of those whom God is going to call, but always points to those *whom God has called*. As he reflected on those who had responded to the Gospel of God's Grace, the evidence was unmistakable; God *had called* believers "not only out of the Jews but also out of the Gentiles." It was not surprising that God had called some Jews into fellowship with Himself, for they were His special people, having been set apart in Abraham (Gen. 12:1-3). What was hard for some of the more exclusive Jews to accept was that God *had also called Gentiles*.

To speculate futuristically about whom God may or may not call is entirely foreign to what the Apostle Paul says. Truth regarding the sovereignty of God solidifies those already called; it explains *how* God has graciously brought them into a relationship with Himself. An understanding of God's sovereign soteriological

program rescues one from the debilitative thought of having merely a happenstance salvation.

25. ***"As he also says in Hosea,* I will call those who are not my people, my people, and her who is not beloved, beloved."**

Confirming the fact that God had also called Gentiles to be the recipients of His mercy, Paul cites what Hosea has said on the issue (Hosea 2:23). a very meticulous translation would be, *I will call the not-people-of-mine, my people, and the-not-having-been-beloved, beloved.* This was a predictive statement made by the Holy Spirit through the prophet Hosea. Its primary reference was obviously to the extension of the Messianic Kingdom to include the Gentiles (Gen. 12:3). Paul does not use it here to teach new Church Truth, which is not found in the Old Testament, but *merely to corroborate*, in a secondary sense, that which the Spirit had revealed unto him. In general, Paul uses the Old Testament *to confirm like* principles, and as such, often apart from contextual considerations.

26. ***"And it shall be in the place where it was said to them, you are not my people, there they shall be called sons of the living God."***

This quotation is also taken from Hosea, but from an earlier and different context (Hosea 1:10). The main point is concerning those who are not the Lord's people, that the time is coming when they will be called sons of the living God. In a secondary sense, Paul uses this to confirm what was taking place in his day, namely, that Gentiles had been called into a sonship relation with God (8:14-16).

27. ***"And Isaiah cries out on behalf of Israel*, If the number of the sons of Israel may be as the sand of the sea, the remnant shall be saved."**

The previous quotations from Hosea were cited to confirm what Paul saw actually taking place - Gentiles had been called and made vessels of mercy. Now he cites quotations from Isaiah to confirm what is taking place among the Jews - they were also being called and receiving mercy. Paul seems to have had no illusions about great numbers of Jews being called. In fact, the passage he cites speaks of only a *remnant* being saved. The Greek noun translated "remnant" (υπολειμμα) is derived from the preposition "υπο" and the verb "λειπω" and means that which is *left behind, that is remaining,* or *the survivors.*

The thought Isaiah is presenting in this context is that even though the number of the children of Israel may be as innumerable as the sand of the sea, a very great number, yet out of these a remnant, a few remaining ones, an insignificant number will be saved. This is exactly what was taking place when Paul wrote this epistle, not many, but *some were being called* (v. 6).

28. **"For the Lord will execute a consummating and cutting short [of His] word upon the earth."**

This is a difficult verse to translate due to the possible variety of meaning for some of the Greek words used in it. Since the reason Paul quotes this verse is not obvious, for in itself it does not appear to confirm what he is saying, we feel

that it is the tail end of the quotation in the preceding verse. It possibly has an elusive significance in relation to the remnant mentioned above.

29. ***"And even as Isaiah has previously said,* Except the Lord of the Sabaoth had left us a seed, we would have become as Sodom, and we would be even like Gomorrah."**

According to the Hebrew text, a better translation would be, "Except the Lord of the Sabaoth had left us a very small remnant, we would have become as Sodom . . ." (Isa. 1:9). Again, observe the fact that God has called a few Jews to be recipients of His mercy in this Church age. This is confirmed as being typical of the Jews, and adds credence to the fact that *only those called are the true seed of Abraham* (vv. 7-8).

The clear implication of this verse is that apart from God's mercy, preserving a small remnant of Israelites, Israel would have become just as bad as the worst of the Gentiles. This is a reaffirmation of the fact that all men, including the Jews, are totally depraved and devoid of that which is right and good in God's sight (3:9; Eph. 2:1-3). Failure to accept what the Bible says about man's depravity predisposes one to fail to comprehend the sovereignty of God in the sphere of soteriology.

30. ***"What shall we say then? that the Gentiles who were not pursuing righteousness obtained righteousness, the righteousness which is out of faith;"***

In view of the fact that only a small number of Jews were accepting the Gospel of God's Grace when Paul wrote this epistle, the question was raised regarding the Word of God - has it failed? The number of Jews being saved, when compared to the total number, was a very 1oω percentage. Paul refuses, however, to concede that the Word of God has failed. Instead he deals with the issue from the standpoint of God, the dispenser of mercy. The number saved does not depend upon human response to the Gospel, depicted by exercising the human will or running, but it depends upon how many receive mercy from God, are called by God, and are made new creatures by God (v. 24; 2 Cor. 5:17).

In the process of pointing out that God, in the final analysis, is the one who determines how many will respond to the Gospel call, Paul also brought the Gentiles into the picture in verse 24. Even as God had called a small percentage of all the Jews, He was also calling the Gentiles. In verses 25-29 he used the Old Testament - not to teach something new, but in a secondary sense - to show that this was feasible in view of what Hosea and Isaiah had said.

Now as we approach verses 30-33, *the emphasis is on faith*, the only way Divine righteousness can be obtained. The opening question in verse 30, "What shall we say then?" means that *as a consequence of* what he has said, what should he Now say or what should be his conclusion. Having just finished positively declaring and affirming that salvation is *totally of the Lord*, he Now switches to the faith aspect of it, clearly implying that *saving faith is from the Lord* (Eph. 2:8).

God's bestowal of mercy upon hell-bound sinners includes both the sacrificial death of Christ and the faith by which it is appropriated.

Paul goes on to say "that the Gentiles who were not pursuing righteousness obtained righteousness." The Greek participle translated "pursuing" (διωκοντα) means that the Gentiles were not *chasing after* and *earnestly endeavoring to acquire* righteousness. Their adherence to various pagan religions could not be interpreted as pursuing righteousness; in fact, it often involved pursuing immorality.

When the Gospel of God's Grace was proclaimed to these once pagan Gentiles, they "obtained" (κατελαβεν), *laid hold of*, and *attained unto* righteousness. Paul describes what they laid hold of as the-out-of-faith righteousness. This means that the *source* of this righteousness is the faith which God imparts to those He calls. It is an undaunted belief in God and all that He has provided for us in His Son, including righteousness (1 Cor. 1:30). The-out-of-faith righteousness involves God-given faith which fully depends upon the perfect faithfulness of Jesus Christ instead of on the works of the Law for righteousness (Gal. 2:16; Phil. 3:9).

31. ***"But Israel pursuing Law righteousness, did not come up to the Law."***

The Apostle Paul speaks of two kinds of righteousness, the-out-of-the-law righteousness (10:5), and the-out-of-faith righteousness. The first depends upon doing the works of the Law to gain righteousness, whereas the second involves faith depending upon the faithful Person of Jesus Christ for forgiveness and righteousness.

Paul says that Israel pursued law righteousness but did not "come up to" (εφθασε) *attain to,* or *arrive at* keeping the Law. Since all of those under the Law failed to fulfill the Law, they came under the curse of the Law rather than being made righteous by the Law (Gal. 3:10). The reason the Mosaic Law utterly failed to make men righteous was due to the weakness of the flesh of its depraved adherents (8:3).

32. ***"On account of what? Because they did not pursue it out of faith, but as out of works. They stumbled at the stone of stumbling,"***

This verse opens with the Greek phrase translated "on account of what" (δια τι), *because of what*, or *why*. The thought is - why did Israel fail to obtain righteousness? What was the reason for this failure? Paul's answer is that they tried to obtain it out of works, out of the source of works, by keeping the Law, rather than out of faith, i.e., out of the source of faith, or out of God-given faith. In other words, Israel failed to acquire a righteous standing with God because she was depending on her flesh to keep the Law, which doomed her to failure. As Paul says, "Those existing in the flesh are not able to please God" (8:8).

While Israel had her eyes fixed on the Law, she failed to see the Precious Stone God sent to her; hence, "They stumbled at the stone of stumbling." As we look ahead at the next verse, this "stone of stumbling" is clearly identified as being the

Person of Jesus Christ (Isa. 8:14-15; 1 Peter 2:6-8). One of the tragedies of works-program religions is that they keep their adherents so involved in so-called good works that they *blind them to the Majestic Person of Jesus Christ*. Most professed Christians today are bound by legalistic interpretations of the Scriptures which prevent them from enjoying the Wonderful Person of Christ and the freedom we have in Him (Gal. 5:1).

33. ***"Even as it has been written,*** **Behold I lay in Zion a stone of stumbling and a rock of offence, and the one believing on him shall not be put to shame."**

This quotation is similar to Isaiah 8:14 and 28:16. It implies that God the Father is the one who set forth Jesus Christ in Zion (Matt. 1:21). The person who believes "upon" (επ') Him shall not be put to shame. The Greek verb translated "put to shame" (καταισχυνθησεται) is in the passive voice and means that no one shall be put to shame, *disgraced* or *made sorry* for believing on Christ. The main punch of this verse is believing on Him, Jesus Christ, being identified with Him thru faith.

Chapter 10

1. ***"Brethren, my heart's desire and supplication to God is on behalf of them, unto salvation."***

Since the Majority text varies slightly from the United Bible Societies' text, the following is a M.T. translation: "Brethren, my heart's desire and supplication to God on behalf of Israel is unto salvation." Since the context makes it very clear that the antecedent of the pronoun "them" (αυτων) is Israel, both texts mean the same. Paul's "supplication" (δεησις), *entreaty*, and *petition* to God was *unto the end* (εις) that He might save Israelites (cf. 1 Cor. 9:19-22).

Now let us look at the fuller meaning of the phrase "my heart's desire." Paul often uses the Greek word for "heart" (καρδιας) to denote *rational* and *reasonable affection*, i.e., a feeling of affection conjoined with the intellect. The Greek word translated "desire" (ευδοκια) is from "ευ" and "δοκεω" and literally means *to think well, good pleasure,* and *good delight.* The thought is that uppermost in Paul's mind and heart, that which would please and delight him most, would be the salvation of his own people, Israel.

Having already observed the meaning of the Greek word for supplication, we need to consider the fact that it is *directed toward God* (προς τον Θεον). According to the Scriptures all prayer is addressed to God the Father (Matt. 6:6, 9; Rom. 8:15; Eph. 1:16-17; 3:14). It should be in the Holy Spirit (Rom. 8:26-27; Jude 20), *through* (δια) Jesus Christ (Col. 3:17), or *in the name of* Jesus Christ (Eph. 5:20). If Paul didn't believe that prayer makes a difference, that it was an important ingredient in the process of God saving his kinsmen according to the flesh, there would be no reason for him to say what he does in this verse. This is certainly strong evidence favoring the propriety of praying that lost men may be saved (cf. 1 Tim. 2:3).

Even though Paul knew that Israel had been hardened in part (11:7, 25) and had stumbled and fallen with reference to the Gospel of God's Grace, he still pled their case before God knowing that according to His elective mercy He was going to save a remnant out of them (11:5). It is exceedingly important that we keep in mind that Paul looked on *all men as potential candidates for salvation*, therefore bonafide subjects of prayer. He only refers to the sovereignty of God in soteriology to explain *how God saved them*. Paul applies God's sovereignty to those *who have been saved* and not to those who will be saved.

2. ***"For I bear witness to them that they have a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge."***

As a Jew, and one who had been a zealot of Judaism, Paul certainly knew the Jewish mindset. He was capable of bearing witness as formerly an insider, and now as an outsider (Acts 9:1-2; 20:22-23). He witnesses (μαρτυρω), *testifies*, and *declares* that "they have a zeal of God." The Greek word rendered "zeal" (ζηλον)

means that they are *fervently jealous* and *ardently aspiring* to do what they think God wants them to do. Paul calls this a *zeal of God* (ζηλον Θεου), i.e., a zeal which belongs to God, a zeal which should be associated with keeping the Mosaic Law. The terminology Paul is using here is *approbative*; that which would be very desirable in conjunction with adherence to the Law.

Note, Paul does not condemn their zeal as such, but he indicates that it is *misplaced*, a jealousy for the wrong thing at the wrong time. He uses the strong adversative to emphasize the fact that they are off-track - *but* their zeal is not according to knowledge. The Greek noun rendered "knowledge" (επιγνωσιν) is derived from the preposition "επι" prefixed to the verb "γινωσκω" and may literally be interpreted to mean *knowledge upon*, hence, added knowledge. This noun form is used exclusively by the Apostle Paul apart from four times by Peter. In general, we can confidently affirm that Paul, and probably Peter, uses this compound word to depict the *perfect, complete,* and *full knowledge revealed for the Church.*

The point Paul is making here is that these zealous Jews are missing the mark because they are not serving God according to and in keeping with the full knowledge of Mystery Truth given to the Church, the Body of Christ. They have a misconception regarding the Law and the zeal associated with it, thinking it was still God's program some thirty years after it was laid aside (Matt. 27:51; Gal. 3:24-25). They were passionately religious, but in vain, for they had missed the main reason for the giving of the Law, to impress the exceeding sinfulness of sin upon man's conscience (7:13).

3. ***"For being ignorant of the righteousness of God, and seeking to establish their own, they have not been subjected to the righteousness of God."***

The present participle translated "being ignorant" (αγνοουντες) means that they were *existing in ignorance ones* as *non-knowing and non-understanding ones.* This participle describes their state of being, the kind of people they were, not in a derogatory manner, but factual. Paul never excused ignorance, but over and over again expresses his desire that it may be replaced with knowledge (1:13; 11:25; 1 Cor. 10:1).

That which they were ignorant of was "the righteousness of God" (την του Θεου δικαιοσυνην), the righteousness which *belongs to God*. This is a righteousness which is totally owned, possessed, and of God's doing. This Divine righteousness is mentioned some eight times in this epistle. Jesus Christ is the embodiment of this righteousness. According to First Corinthians 1:30, He "was made wisdom for us from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption." In Philippians 3:9 Paul expresses his desire to have the righteousness which is "through the faithfulness of Christ, the out of God righteousness based upon faith" (cf. Gal. 2:16). Their willful ignorance of Jesus Christ is synonymous with their being ignorant of God's righteousness (v. 5).

In contrast to accepting God's righteousness as a free gift, these Jews were "seeking" (ζητουντες), *striving*, and *endeavoring to obtain* their own righteousness. Again, the present participle indicates that they were a seeking-your-own-righteousness people. The Greek phrase for "your own" (την ιδιαν) refers to that which is *private* and *peculiar* to them. It is a righteousness which they themselves are trying to generate through keeping the law (v. 6). Paul had this same kind of righteousness before he was saved, which he speaks of as "my righteousness" (εμην δικαιοσυνην), which he rejected when he received God's righteousness in Christ (Phil. 3:8-9).

Finally, Paul says, "they have not been subjected to the righteousness of God." The Greek verb translated "subjected" (υπεταγησαν) is in the *passive voice* and means that *they have not been arranged* or *placed under* nor *subordinated* to the righteousness of God. The literal and obvious meaning of this clause is that God had not extended His mercy to these; they had not been called by God (9:23-24). Consequently, they remained in their sin, seeking to keep the Law, insubordinate to God's righteousness and void of it.

4. ***"For Christ is the end of the Law unto righteousness to everyone believing."***

Having said that the Jews were seeking to establish their own righteousness by keeping the Law, and were not subject to the righteousness of God which is embodied in Christ, Paul Now affirms that "Christ is the end of the law unto righteousness." The Greek word translated "end" (τελος) means that Christ is the *consummation, fulfilment*, and the one who has *brought the Law to an end.*

Now let us examine the statement that it is "unto righteousness" (εις δικαιοσυνην) that Christ is the end of the Law. The Greek preposition "εις" used with the accusative case conveys the thought that the *object* of Christ's perfectly keeping the intended spirit of the Law was *unto the end of righteousness*. The Law had a definite place in God's eternal purpose, with reference to which Christ says, "I did not come to destroy it but to fulfill it" (Matt. 5:17). Christ fully met the requirements of the Law by perfectly fulfilling its stipulations in spirit and act. Whereas the Law was never perfectly kept by any sinner and, as a result, laid a curse on men rather than making them righteous, Christ's fulfillment of the Law *consummates its purpose* in God's plan, revealing the exceeding sinfulness of man's sin and the true righteousness found in Christ (Gal. 3:10, 24-25).

There is a limitation placed on the giving of this righteousness embodied in Christ; it is "to everyone believing." The Greek participle rendered believing is in the present tense and means that Christ is the perfect fulfillment of the Law *to every Jew believing, trusting,* and *having faith in Him.* We emphasize, Paul is saying this particularly to the Jewish believers in Rome, those who were once under the Law, and informing them that through their faith identification with Christ they have fulfilled the Law. Since the Law was originally given by God, its standards are in accordance with the righteousness of God, and as that which

was fulfilled by Christ, it could be thought of as included in the phrase "the righteousness of God" in the preceding verse.

5. ***"For Moses writes regarding the righteousness that is out of the law,* that the man who has done it shall live by it."**

The latter part of this verse is from Leviticus 18:5, which says, "You shall therefore keep my statutes, and my ordinances; which if a man do, he shall live by them." Paul makes it clear in his epistles that where there is righteousness there is life, and vice versa, where there is life we have to posit righteousness (Gal. 3:21). The Law promised life on the condition that a person *does the Law*, actually, according to the aorist participle, to the man "who has done it" (ο ποιησας). Strictly speaking, according to the Law of Moses, no one could know whether or not he had life until he was beyond the state of knowing, namely, death.

Due to the weakness of the flesh (8:3), no man ever did the Law; therefore, no man has acquired life by the Law (Gal. 3:11). In fact, instead of the Jews gaining life by their futile efforts to keep the Law, they came under the curse of the Law, namely, death (Gal. 3:10). This is why the Apostle Paul says that the main purpose of the Law was not to give men life and righteousness, but in their failure to obtain these, it was to make them conscious and aware of their sinful condition (3:19-20). The failure of men to obtain life by the Law was not the fault of the Law, which merely set forth God's standard for His people at that point in time, but it *made obvious the fault of men*, that they were sinners by nature who needed a Saviour (Matt.9:12-13).

In dealing with the issue of righteousness in the Pauline Epistles, we must acknowledge that there are two kinds of "righteousness" (δικαιοσυνη). First, there is the *conditional righteousness* which a person obtained if he meticulously observed every single aspect of the Law. Since the Law operated on the basis of the flesh, and the flesh is sinfully sick (8:3), no man has ever acquired law-righteousness.

The other kind of righteousness Paul mentions is *unconditional*. It is a righteousness which God freely gives to men in accordance with His mercy and calling of them (9:23-24). This righteousness and the faith by which it is personally acquired are provided by God's grace (Eph. 2:8-9).

6. ***"But the out of faith righteousness speaks thus,* Do not say in your heart, Who shall ascend into heaven? *that is to bring Christ down;"***

In the preceding verse we described Law-righteousness as conditional righteousness, and faith-righteousness as unconditional righteousness. Paul's description of them in verses 5 and 6 emphasizes the *source* from which each comes. Law righteousness is "out of the law" (εκ του νομου), whereas faith-righteousness is "out of faith" (εκ πιστεως). Law righteousness, due to its dependence upon sinful flesh, has never made anyone righteous. Faith-righteousness, which depends upon the substitutionary death of Jesus Christ, has made all of God's elect righteous (2 Tim. 2:10).

The first examples we have of this faith-righteousness in the Scriptures are from Abraham's relation to God. In Genesis 15:6 we read, "And Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him unto righteousness" (cf. 4:3). Following the period of time when God related to Abraham through faith, Israel voluntarily chose to relate to God through the Mosaic Law (Exodus 19:3-20:21). For some fourteen hundred years God's relation with His people Israel was via the Law. Speaking with reference to this time, Paul says to the Galatians, "Before faith came we were under the custody of the law, being locked up unto the about-to-be-revealed faith" (Gal. 3:23). The principle of faith-righteousness was in effect prior to the giving of the Law, and was *restored again* after the annulment of the Law (Gal. 3:24-25). God's method of saving and making sinners righteous in this Church age *is not something new*. The fact of it and the precedent for it was revealed to the Apostle Paul (Gal. 1:12). It is not to be confused with the Mystery truth, that which pertains to the Body of Christ, the Church, which was revealed for the first time to the Apostle Paul (Eph. 3:2-9).

Paul describes the out-of-faith righteousness as speaking "thus" (ουτως), *in this way,* or *in this manner*, namely, "Do not say in your heart, Who shall ascend into heaven?" The background for this quotation is in Deuteronomy 30:11-12, where God says through Moses, "For this commandment which I command you this day, it is not too hard for you neither is it far off. It is not in heaven, that you should say, Who shall go up for us to heaven, and bring it unto us. . ." Even as Moses was telling the Children of Israel that the covenant God was making with them was *not far off*, that it was *not something they had to go to heaven for*, likewise, Paul is telling the Romans that the message of out-of-faith righteousness *is not far off,* it is *not something they need to ascend into heaven for*, but it is present with them. In fact, to ascend into heaven would be to bring or lead Christ down. This is absurd, for Christ has already revealed the good news that sinners are made righteous out of faith (Gal. 1:12; 2:16). The Gospel of Grace is the fact that sinners are made righteous through faith. This message is near us, at our fingertips in the Word of God (Eph. 2:8).

7. ***"or* Who shall descend into the abyss? *that is to bring Christ out from the dead."***

The context surrounding this verse is dealing with out-of-faith righteousness, with reference to which Paul tells them, "don't say in your heart `Who shall descend into the abyss?' " Even though this quotation is not found in Deuteronomy 30:11-14, the thought it contains is obviously a projection from this passage. It is the opposite of trying to find out-of-faith righteousness in heaven. To contemplate a trip either to heaven or to the abyss to find the message of *faith righteousness* would be ridiculous, for this message is externally and internally impinging on those to whom God shows mercy. Jesus Christ has already revealed the truth that sinners are made righteous by faith; it is the essence of Paul's Gospel of salvation. Therefore, why look for it in the heights or depths (5:1; Eph. 1:13)?

8. ***"But what does it say?* The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart *that is, the word of faith which we preach."***

This quotation is taken from Deuteronomy 30:14, which reads, "The word is very near unto you, in your mouth and in your heart, that you may do it." As this passage was originally spoken by the Lord through Moses to Israel, the thought is that the message of the covenant was near them, in their mouth and heart, to the end that they might *do it.* The law functioned on a doing basis. In contrast, Paul uses this passage to illuminate the fact that the message of *faith righteousness* is very near, even within one's being, and they are *to believe it*. The dispensation of the Law was a time when Israel abortively attempted to keep the Law, but utterly failed due to the sinfulness and weakness of their flesh (8:3). In contrast, during this dispensation of Grace God is sovereignly imparting out-of-faith righteousness to whom He wills, and they *walk by faith* in obedience to His Word (2 Cor. 5:7; 1 Tim. 1:4).

Paul says that what was near them "is the word of faith which we preach." There is no doubt about it. Paul and his company were preaching that God's righteousness is obtained through faith. As we have already observed, the essence of this righteousness is Jesus Christ, the one who went through the cycle of death and resurrection on our behalf (4:22-25; 1 Cor. 5:21). The constant theme of Paul's epistles is the need to come into a right relationship with God *through faith, through believing* the Good News that Jesus Christ died and rose again for our sins according to the Scriptures (1 Cor. 15:3-4; Rom. 1:17; 3:24-26; 9:30; Gal. 2:16; 5:5).

There is no question about Paul and those associated with him proclaiming a message of salvation, hence, of righteousness, which was received on the basis of *believing the Gospel* of God's Grace. Now about Paul's friend, Peter? Did he proclaim faith instead of works as the means whereby men are made righteous? Even though the Greek words rendered *believe* (πιστευω) and *faith* (πιστις) are seemingly used several times in early Acts to depict faith unto the end of righteousness, the first clear evidence we have of Peter teaching that faith in Jesus Christ results in the forgiveness of sins is in Acts 10:43. On the basis of what Paul says in Galatians 2:16-21, the implication is that Peter knew that righteousness is by faith, but he had a temporary relapse. His epistles certainly affirm that our relationship to God is dependent upon faith (1 Peter 1:9).

9. ***"Because if you might confess with your mouth Lord Jesus, and might believe in your heart that God raised him out from the dead, you shall be saved;"***

Because (οτι), *on account of,* and *since* the word of faith was near them, Paul says, "if you might confess with your mouth Lord Jesus . . . you shall be saved." This is a *conditional statement* in the subjunctive mood. It is most properly translated, "if you *might confess"* (ομολογησης), *say the same thing* or *affirm what God has said* about the Lord Jesus with your mouth - then having met the second condition, you shall be saved.

The phrase "Lord Jesus" (κυριον Ιησουν) is open to two interpretations. First, we may add the article and translate it *the Lord Jesus* as the King James Version does. Second, we may interpret it as a confession or recognition that Jesus is

Lord, and translate it *Jesus as Lord* like the American Standard Version. In translating from the Greek it is a very common practice to add the article, so we consider it a literal rendering rather than an interpretation. Therefore, we prefer to translate this phrase either *Lord Jesus* or *the Lord Jesus*. To confess the Lord Jesus is to say *everything God says about Him*, not merely that He is Lord.

According to Deuteronomy 30:14 the emphasis is on the *nearness of the word,* and this is brought out by the fact that it is *in their mouth and heart.* It is the word which is in the mouth, in the sphere of the mouth, which is confessing to God all that He says Jesus Christ is. It is an acclamation to God that we accept everything He has said about His Son (cf. Heb. 13:15). There is no contextual reason for interpreting this as a confession before men, for such a confession has nothing to do with our salvation in this age of Grace. This must not be confused with Matthew 10:32, where confessing Jesus before men is a prerequisite to His confessing one before the Father. The Book of Matthew sets forth conditions pertaining to the Messianic Kingdom, and not regarding the Church, the Body of Christ.

The second aspect of the condition for salvation stipulated in this verse is also conditional, namely, if you "might believe in your heart that God raised him out from the dead'. 'Having observed that the message which Paul preached was also *in their hearts*, the rational and emotional center of their beings, we are not informed that this is the center from which their God-given faith is expressed. The specific truth they are to believe is that God raised Jesus out from the dead. Apparently the fact of Jesus Christ's resurrection is to be viewed as the final copestone, that which represents the total integrity of His Divine person, God's final affirmation of Him as His Son (Matt. 3:17; Acts 1:23; Rom. 4:25).

Summarizing, the message of faith which Paul preached was very near - both in their mouth and heart. This message entailed *saying the same thing about Christ which God Himself said* and believing in His resurrection which *confirmed His deity, that He is truly the Son of God* (1:4). This confession and faith are *directed toward God*, aspects of a single transaction, namely, *faith in the Christ set forth by God.*

10. "***for the heart believes unto righteousness, and the mouth confesses unto salvation."***

The heart, in conjunction with the Spirit, exercises Divine faith unto the end of righteousness. The mouth confesses to God, says the same thing God says, unto the end of salvation. This verse puts us squarely on the track of *faith righteousness* again, i.e., faith in Jesus Christ is counted for righteousness, *identifies us with Him who is the righteousness of God* (1 Cor. 1:30).

The mouth confesses unto the end of *receiving salvation*. This means that the mouth says the same thing back to God which He requires for salvation. The mouth *agrees with God* regarding the Gospel of salvation and exercises Divine faith in it. The combining of the faith in the message, Christ, results in righteousness/salvation.

11. ***"For the Scripture says,* Everyone believing on him will not be put to shame."**

The main subject of verses 6-10 is out-of-faith righteousness, the message of faith which Paul preached. It is a message that is *near*, both in their mouth and heart, and as such they *personally agree* that what God says about it is true, and they *believe it.* Verses 9 and 10 do not teach that a person must do two different things in order to be made righteous, hence, saved, but merely *two aspects* involved in faith righteousness. *Faith must be in the Truth which God has spoken,* namely, in the Gospel of His Grace (Acts 20:24; Gal. 1:8-9). These verses leave no room for ignorant, misplaced faith. There must be *agreement with* and *adherence to the faith message* (v. 8) which God revealed to the Apostle Paul (Gal. 1:12).

Having considered what is involved in the out-of-faith righteousness in verses 6-10, in this 11th verse Paul speaks of the *benefit* which accrues to those believing. Paul's Gospel, as it relates to salvation, was revealed unto him by Jesus Christ (Gal. 1:12), and he often corroborates it by citing passages from the Old Testament. In this verse he cites Isaiah 28:16 from the Septuagint, namely, that "everyone believing on him will not be put to shame." The phrase translated "everyone believing" (παρ ο πιστευων) literally means *every single person believing*, emphasizing that *no one* who believes will suffer shame. The Greek phrase translated "will not be put to shame" (ου καταισχυνθησεται) is in the passive voice and future tense, and it means that no one will be able to cause the one believing on the Lord to be *shamed, to blush, to be dishonored*, or *to be disappointed.*

We recognize that a good translation of this quotation from Isaiah 28:16, as we have it in the Hebrew text, is "he that believes will not be in haste." The reasons behind the Septuagint translators rendering this word "καταισχυνθησεται," which means with the negative "will not be put to shame," is beyond the scope of our current understanding of these words. The important thing to note is that the Septuagint translation is used to convey what the Holy Spirit wants to say through Paul. This is, obviously, that no person believing on the Lord will in the future be shamed, disgraced, or caused to regret it (5:5; 9:33; 1 Peter 2:6).

12. ***"For there is no distinction between Jew and Greek, for the same one is Lord of all, being rich unto all those calling upon him."***

Regardless of whether a person may be a Jew or Gentile, God manifests His riches unto all; therefore, there is no possibility of anyone who believes being put to shame or turned away. According to the Gospel of God's Grace it is utterly impossible for anyone to want to believe on Jesus Christ and not be able to believe. The very fact that a person wants to believe is an omen that he is a recipient of God's mercy and calling (9:23-24), and regardless of race and what he may have done, he will not be put to shame, rejected, or refused (John 6:37; 1 Tim. 2:4).

Having considered the contextual relation of this 12th verse to what has preceded it, let us more meticulously exegete its meaning. The Greek word Paul

uses to indicate that there is no "distinction" (διαστολη) between a Jew and a Greek is derived from the preposition "δια" prefixed to the verb "στελλω" and means that there is no *separation, difference, putting asunder,* or *severing* between Jews and Greeks (3:22). The Jews are the people whom God separated from the human race via Abraham to be His own special people (Gen. 12:1-3). The name Greeks is used here to denote all those who are not Jews, hence, it is comprehensively used of the *Gentiles*. In this present Church age God is equally interested in extending mercy to both Jews and Gentiles; He has no priority groups (11:30-32).

The Greek phrase is translated "for the same one is Lord of all" (ο γαρ αυτος κυριος παντων). This may also be rendered *for the same Lord belongs to all.* Formerly, the Jews had an inside track with God; they were His peculiar people. But, during this Church age they have lost this position (Acts 17:30; Eph. 2:13-22). True, historically speaking, before Israel was completely laid aside (11:11-12, 25), Paul did preach the Gospel first to Jews in the Synagogues (Acts 13:46; 18:6; 28:28). This was unique at that point in time and ended with the *final laying aside of Israel* (Acts 28:28).

Paul adds that God is one "being rich unto all those calling upon him." The present participle translated "being rich" (πλουτων) means that God continuously, out of His abundant wealth and resources, provides salvation to all those calling upon Him. The participle rendered "calling upon" (επικαλουμενους) conveys the idea of *calling on, appealing to,* and *summoning* for help. Generally speaking, it appears that the meaning of this word *presupposes the presence of faith.* Hebrews 11:6 throws further light on the faith implied in the meaning of this: "for it is necessary for the one coming to God to believe that he is and that he is a rewarder of those seeking him." In the light of the preceding and following contexts we would interpret this word to mean that God is rich unto all those calling upon Him *with faith unto salvation.*

13. **"For whoever might call upon the name of the Lord will be saved."**

This is an exact quotation from Joel 2:32 in the Septuagint. In its original setting it refers to those who are delivered from the terrible day of the Lord by calling on the name of the Lord. Paul uses it to depict those, who as a result of calling on the name of the Lord, will be saved from sin.

The verb translated "might call upon" (επικαλεσηται) is in the subjunctive mood and may also be rendered whoever *would call upon* the name of the Lord. The subjunctive mood denotes *probability*, i.e., *it is probable that some* might or would call on the name of the Lord. On the other hand, those who do call upon the name of the Lord "will be saved" (σωθησεται). This verb is in the future tense and indicative mood, and means that as night follows day, likewise, their salvation *will follow* their calling upon the Lord. The calling upon the name of the Lord implies the exercising of a Divinely implanted faith, which in turn *assures* one of eternal salvation in Jesus Christ (John 3:16; Titus 1:2-3; Heb. 5:9).

14. ***"How then should they call upon him in whom they have not believed? and how should they believe in him whom they have not heard? and how should they hear without a preacher?"***

We need to recognize that the verbs translated "should call upon" (επικαλεσωνται), "should believe" (επιστευσωσιν), and "should hear" (ακουσωσιν) are all in the *subjunctive mood*. They may also be rendered how *might they call upon, might they believe,* and *might they hear*. As we noted above, the subjunctive mood expresses probability, and this may be in either a positive or negative sense. First, it is not probable that anyone will call upon the Lord who has not first believed in Him. Second, it is not probable that anyone will believe in the Lord unless he has first heard about Him via the Gospel message. Third, it was not probable anyone would hear the good news about the Lord unless there was first someone to preach and proclaim it to them. This must be understood in the light of the sparsity of the written page.

15. ***"and how should they preach except they might be sent? even as it has been written,* How beautiful are the feet of those preaching a message of good things."**

The Majority Greek Text reads as follows: "Now beautiful are the feet of those preaching peace, those preaching good things." Basically, the only difference between the thought context of this and the United Bible Societies' text is the addition of the word *peace*. The Majority text conveys the thought of preaching both *peace* and *good things*.

This verse is a continuation of verse 14. The verb translated how "should they preach" (κηρυξωσιν) is likewise in the subjunctive mood, and may also be rendered how *might they preach*. The thought is that it is not probable they could preach unless they had been sent. This quotation, primarily taken from Nahum 1:15, is mainly used to corroborate what Paul is saying.

Looking at verses 14 and 15 as a single sentence, which they are, and considering the transactions in them in the order in which they take place, we have the following sequence. First, the preacher is *sent* with the Gospel of the Grace of God. Second, through the preacher they *hear* the Gospel of Grace. Third, as a result of hearing, some *believe*. Fourth, as those who have believed, they are in a position to *call upon the Lord*. The implication is that faith is a prerequisite to the desire and ability to call upon the Lord.

The Greek word translated "might be sent" (αποσταλωσιν) is derived from the preposition "απο" prefixed to the verb "στελλω" and means *to send from, hence, to send forth,* and *to dispatch.* This compound verb is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which indicates that at a given point in time *God is the one who sends forth messengers with the Gospel.* We can confidently affirm that those who go forth with the Gospel of God's Grace, God's message for this present Church age, have been sent by God. Just as positively, we can affirm that those who are not preaching the Gospel of God's Grace in this dispensation of Grace have not been sent by God, but are self-sent or sent by some man-made religious organization. Due to erroneous misconceptions of what the Bible

teaches about *God's sending and call,* many have and continue to misconstrue Satan's call to confuse and hinder the Gospel with God's call to preach it.

16. ***"But all did not obey the gospel; For Isaiah says,* Lord, who has believed our report?"**

This verse begins with the strong adversative "αλλα" translated *but*, to emphasize the contrast between what was preached and their *disobedience* to it. The Greek word translated "gospel" (ευαγγελιω) means *good news* or *a good message*. The context in which it is used determines what the good message or news is. In this case, Isaiah was giving a prophetic report regarding the Messiah particularly relating to His rejection and substitutionary death (Isa. 53:1-11). There is certainly much in common between the way the word gospel is used with reference to Isaiah's report, and the way Paul uses it pertaining to salvation, i.e., the gospel of salvation (Eph. 1:13). In fact, on the basis of what Paul says here we can affirm that he considered Isaiah 53 the antecedent of his Gospel as it relates to salvation.

The point Paul is making here is that *all did not obey* the good news proclaimed by Isaiah. The evidence he cites for this statement is Isaiah 53:1, "Lord, who has believed our report?" The implication is that few, if any, believed what Isaiah had to say. The Greek verb translated "obey" (υπηκουσαν) in the forepart of this verse is from the preposition "υπο" prefixed to "ακουω" and literally means to *hear under, hence, to do what is heard,* or *to obey.* Obedience ought to be the consequence of true faith.

17. ***"then faith is out of hearing, and the hearing is through the word of Christ."***

The Greek particle (αρα), with which this verse begins, indicates that what Paul says in this verse is a *consequence* of what he has previously said, particularly, in verse 14. The Greek phrase translated "out of hearing" (εξ ακοης) means that the *source of faith is that which is heard or the thing heard.* Faith is derived from the essence of what is heard, which means that the key to understanding this verse centers in that which is heard.

Fortunately, Paul describes what is heard as "through the word of Christ" (δια ρηματος χριστου). The Majority Greek Text prefers the rendering that what is heard is "through the word of God." This textual variation leaves the option open for the faith to be either through the *word of Christ* or *the word of God*. We see the faith as "through" (δια) the agency of *the word which God spoke*. Whether God did this while He was in the form of the Father or Son is not significant, for according to Paul's epistles He sometimes speaks as God the Father or the Son (Gal. 1:12; Col. 3:16; 1 Thess. 2:13).

All who believe that God's method of saving sinners today is entirely by grace, must, in order to be consistent, also believe that He gives sinners the necessary faith for appropriating salvation. It is feasible to think that the salvation process may begin when a sinner listens to or reads the Word of God. We know that God's Word is living and dynamic, and that just listening to it or reading it could

instil faith in sinners. But is this the only way God implants faith? Would a sinner, dead in trespasses and sins, be willing to listen to the Word long enough to have faith generated in him unless he first believed that God exists? What about sinners who have little or no exposure to the Word of God, but upon hearing John 3:16 they are saved? From where did they get their instant faith? There is no question about it, on the basis of this context, faith is obviously generated in sinful men, but we cannot affirm that this is the only way God imparts saving faith to those chosen in Christ before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4).

18. ***"But I say, have they not heard? yes indeed,* Their sound went out into all the land, and their words unto the ends of the inhabited earth."**

In this verse Paul raises the question: Didn't Israel hear the Word of God given to them? Didn't they know God's requirements of them under the Law and the prophets? The answer is emphatically *yes, indeed* (μενουνγε). It wasn't a matter of Israel ignorantly sinning against God, in which case there would be some basis for excusing them (1 Tim. 1:13), but in spite of knowing what the Law and the prophets said, they willfully persisted in that which they knew to be sin.

Paul cites Psalms 19:4 to support what he has said about the widespread dissemination of the message God had given to them. It had gone out into all the land, i.e., the land of Israel. His words extended far beyond the land of Israel, unto the farthest parts of the earth which was inhabited. The Israel of the Old Testament knew the will of God, but they rejected it. Likewise, the Israelites during Paul's day, for the most part, knew but rejected the Gospel of God's Grace (Acts 20:24).

19. ***"But I say, Did Israel not know? First Moses says,* I will provoke you to jealousy by that which is not a nation, and by a nation void of understanding I will anger you."**

In the preceding verse Paul raises the question as to whether Israel had really heard, which he answers with an emphatic yes. In this verse he raises the further question: Did Israel really *know*; i.e., did they have adequate information regarding the Law and the prophets? The quotation in this verse is from Deuteronomy 32:21. The surrounding context posits the fact that Israel was not living in accordance with the knowledge which she had. The implication of the quotation cited is that *Israel did have the knowledge of God and His will,* and it is against the background of this knowledge that God is going to stir them up by courting an ignoble nation without understanding of Himself. The principle is that God will use the uninformed and stupid to put to shame those having knowledge, the wise (1 Cor. 1:27-28).

20. ***"And Isaiah dared to speak out and say,* I was found by those not seeking me, I was made manifest to those not interrogating me."**

The thought here is that Isaiah "dared to speak out" (αποτολμα); i.e., *he took the risk* and *threw off restraints* in saying what he did. Again we observe that what Isaiah said was designed to provoke Israel to jealousy. The use of the passive voice indicates that God was the one who *initiated a courtship* with those not

seeking Him. He was the one who manifested Himself to those who were not interrogating Him or asking about Him. In all these citations the principle is the same; God is the one who is initiating a relationship with sinners and not sinners reaching out toward God. The very thing which made Israel jealous was the fact that God was leaving her in the shadow and eliciting the favor of her no-status neighbors.

21. ***"But to Israel he says,* All the day I have stretched forth my hands to a disobedient and speaking-against people."**

The quotations in verses 20 and 21 are from Isaiah 65:1-2. The purpose of the first one is to provoke them to jealousy, that they might realize what a Wonderful God they have. The second quotation calls their attention to God's relentless compassion toward them. Even though they are disobedient and speaking against God, He continues to "stretch forth" (εξεπετασα), *extend*, and *spread out* His hands toward them all day long. This reminds us of Jesus' compassion for Israel mentioned in Matthew 23:37, where He says, "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the one killing the prophets and stoning those sent to her, how often I have wanted to bring together your children in the same manner a hen gathers her young under the wings, and you would not."

Summarizing verses 18-21, we observe certain facts. First, all Israel in and beyond their land had an opportunity to *hear* God's message. Second, they also had occasion to *know* the basics of God's law, that by which they were to be governed during that dispensation. Third, God often used the principle of jealousy to stimulate Israel to appreciate His Majestic Person. Fourth, in spite of Israel's disobedience and obstinacy, God continued to woo her back compassionately to Himself. Fifth, even though Israel heard and did not respond, and knew and did not obey, God still has a remnant as we will see in the next chapter.

Chapter 11

1. ***"I say then, Has God cast away his people? May it never be! For I also am an Israelite, out of the seed of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin."***

As a consequence of what Paul said in the latter part of the preceding chapter, it would be possible to draw the conclusion that God has "cast away" (απωσατο), *thrust away,* and *repelled from Himself His people.* As he opens this chapter he raises this question, and then uses a Greek grammatical construction which clearly indicates that *God has not cast away His people*. In addition, Paul says "May it never be" (μη γενοιτο)! Since this statement is in the optative mood, the mood in which prayers are cast, some quite freely translate it *God forbid*. "May it never be" or "let it never be" are excellent translations - God has not shoved away His people. Observe, Israel, the descendants of Abraham and Sarah, are designated as *God's people* (λαον αυτου).

Paul presents himself as evidence to prove that God has not cast away His people. He is an Israelite who can trace his lineage back to Abraham. He is of the tribe of Benjamin, that most significant tribe which cast its lot with Judah when the Ten Tribes split off (Phil. 3:5). The fact that Paul was a child of God, a member of God's family (Eph. 2:19) in spite of his terrible past (1 Tim. 1:13), certainly proves that God has not cast away His people, Israel. If God was interested in saving a chief of sinners like him, as an example of His longsuffering, Paul was confident that the door was wide open for other believing Israelites (1 Tim. 1:14-16).

2. ***"God has not cast away his people whom he foreknew. Or do you not know what the Scripture says respecting Elijah? how he intercedes with God against Israel?"***

This verse opens with a positive declaration that God has not thrust away, repelled, or repulsed the very people whom He foreknew in Abraham. The Greek verb translated "foreknew" is in the aorist tense and goes back to the point in time when God *knew beforehand, in advance,* and *in prior time* that He would make Abraham the progenitor of a new nation - His people, Israel (8:29). We must keep in mind that when God foreknew Abraham and his descendants He knew everything that they would think and do in the future ages. He knew that they would not obey the Law, that they would speak against Him, and that they would clamor for the death of His Son. Why then would He cast away His people when they do that which He knew they would do before He foreknew them?

Paul now calls our attention to Elijah, a prophet who thought he was the only one left who was serving God in the northern kingdom of Israel. This man had fierce opposition, there was a price upon his head, and under the pressure he began to feel sorry for himself. This also led him to the erroneous conclusion that God had cast away all His people except himself.

The fact that Elijah "intercedes" (εντυγχανει), *pleads,* and *converses with* God against Israel is an unusual use of this verb. It is used of the Holy Spirit interceding on behalf of the saints (8:27, 34). It is used of Jesus Christ continually living to intercede on behalf of those coming to God through Him (Heb. 7:25). If Elijah was flowing in the current of the Spirit he would have been interceding *on behalf of Israel* instead of against Israel (10:1).

Summarizing, Paul proves that Israel has not been cast away by citing the fact that as an Israelite he has been saved. Also, Israel is constituted of God's people whom He foreknew, a decision based upon timeless perfect knowledge, therefore, *immutable*. God does not change His mind because all decisions and callings are based on complete and timeless knowledge.

3. ***"Lord,* they have killed your prophets, they have undermined your altars, and only I have been left, and they seek my life."**

These are the words which Elijah spoke to the Lord while he was in a cave at Mount Horeb. It was a time when he was in hiding from Jezebel, who had threatened to kill him (1 Kings 19:1-14).

The first two complaints Elijah made against Israel were true. They had killed the true prophets whom God had sent to them. They had undermined and destroyed the altars of the Lord God. However, Elijah's third statement was false, for there was no way he could know the relationship of every person in Israel to God. You and I should be aware of our tendency to be like Elijah, judging the relationship of others to the Lord when we don't have the Divine facts. This is particularly true during this present dispensation of Grace, when God is bringing men into a relationship with Himself *by grace through faith* apart from works.

God, who knows the hearts and minds of all men, corrected Elijah on this third point. He informed him that He still had seven thousand in Israel, the northern kingdom, who had not bowed their knees unto Baα1 nor kissed him (1 Kings 19:18). Furthermore, instead of sympathizing with Elijah's plight, God told him to get moving - to anoint kings for Syria and Israel, and to anoint Elisha to replace himself as a prophet (1 Kings 19:15-16).

4. ***"But what did the Divine communication say to him?* I have left to myself seven thousand men, who have not bowed the knee to Baal."**

The Greek word translated "Divine communication" is only used here in the New Testament. In the Classical Greek it conveys the idea of *doing business, negotiation,* and *listening to an ambassador*. In the light of the historical setting, as presented in 1 Kings 19:11-13, the thought seems to be that *God was communicating, negotiating*, and expressing a warning to Elijah. God must have been displeased with Elijah's erroneous, egotistical conception that he was the only one in Israel who was on the Lord's side. Since allied forms have the idea of warning, it is most logical to think that through the use of this word God may be warning and chiding Elijah for his egoism, self-pity, and moping in the Mount Horeb cave.

The Lord's response to Elijah is that He has "left" (κατελιπον) and *remaining* seven thousand men for Himself. This certainly aligns with what Paul says in Second Timothy 2:19, "The Lord knows those who are His" (Num. 16:5). He knows those who have not bowed a knee to Baal, i.e., who have not given him their allegiance. Keep in mind, the main reason Paul calls our attention to Elijah's negotiations with God revolves around the seven thousand men who remain faithful to God. They constitute a remnant.

5. ***"Likewise then also at the present time there exists a remnant according to the election of grace."***

Again we need to remind ourselves that it is not God's purpose to save all men, nor is it His purpose to save most men, but it is His purpose to save those whom He has chosen in Christ before the creation of the world (Acts 13:48; Rom. 8:28-30; 9:11; Eph. 1:11; 2 Tim. 1:9). Several different terms are used to designate those who are a part of God's remnant, such as *chosen, foreknew, foreordained, called, elect, vessel of mercy*, etc. Paul's thesis is that it is not God's purpose to save all the Jews, but to save selectively some of them (1 Cor. 9:22), and these are customarily referred to as *the elect* (τους εκλεκτους) according to 2 Tim. 2:10.

Paul is using the noun "remnant" (λειμμα) in this verse to depict that small number of Jews, when compared to the total number, who are being saved in this Church age. This word literally means those *remaining, left,* or *a small residue*. As Paul writes this verse he is not speaking of the Jews who are being saved or who are going to be saved, but he is speaking of those *who have been saved*. The leading verb in this verse is in the *perfect tense* (γεγονεν) and it means that this remnant *has been made, has been brought into being,* and *has been caused to exist* according to the election of grace. The implication is clear - if there was no election of grace there would be no remnant, and none of the Jews would be saved today.

What does the phrase "the election of grace" (εκλογην) mean? The noun rendered "election" is derived from the preposition "εκ" prefixed to the verb "λεγω" and literally means *to speak out, to pick out, to select,* or *to choose.* Since the word rendered "grace" (χαριτος) is in the genitive case, the case denoting *possession*, the thought is that this remnant has been *brought into being* according to the principle of election *which belongs to grace*.

Jesus Christ, all that He is and has done, is the epitome expression of the grace of God. Apart from Jesus Christ, and His finished work on Calvary, the concept of election would have an empty, hollow sound. In order for God to elect to bring sinners into a relationship with Himself, there had to be the predetermined purpose to give His Son as a sin-sacrifice, the Just on behalf of the unjust, in order that He, God, might simultaneously remain just and be the justifier of the ungodly (Acts 2:23; Rom. 3:24-26). Even as election depends upon grace to make it effectual, grace depends on election for recipients who will believe the Gospel. Apart from the marriage of election and grace there would be no remnant of the Jews nor Gentiles saved during this present Church age.

6. ***"And if by grace, it is no longer out of works, for then grace is no longer grace. "***

The Majority Greek Text adds the following to this verse: "And if out of works, no longer is it grace, for then the work is no longer work." It appears to us that this is unnecessary duplication, an added gloss, which goes beyond Paul's succinct definition of what grace is and is not.

Since this verse makes it clear that grace and works are at opposite ends of the spectrum, they are mutually exclusive, it is important that we consider the exact meaning of both of these words. The Greek noun translated "grace" (χαρις), as used in this verse, conveys the meaning of a *free gift, free favor, freely giving all that is necessary for salvation,* and *the free provision God has made for us in Christ* (John 1:17; 2 Cor. 8:9; 9:15). Grace focuses on *what God has done for us* in Christ, the benefits of which are freely proffered to us (2 Cor. 5:21). Finally, God's offer of salvation by grace includes both the *provision of it and the means by which it is appropriated, namely, faith* (Eph. 2:8-9).

The Greek noun rendered "works" (εργων), as used in this verse, refers to that which man endeavors to produce in his flesh to gain acceptance with God. This word is generally used in conjunction with the works of the Law. Salvation by grace is a free gift from God; whereas the effort to obtain salvation by the works of the Law is futile due to the weakness of the flesh (8:3). To mix grace and works *cancels both*.

Before we leave this 6th verse we need to be aware of the *deleterious results* which follow simultaneously holding to portions of the Bible which teach both law and grace. As we have already observed, law avers that man saves himself by his works; whereas grace avers that God in Christ has done the work necessary for salvation. Law makes salvation totally dependent upon what man does, therefore, there is no assurance that one is saved. Grace makes salvation totally dependent upon what God *has done*, it is an accomplished fact for a believer; therefore, he has assurance that he is saved. Law says that the person who has done its works will live (10:5); whereas grace says that believing (exercising one's God-given faith) identifies a person with the life which is in Christ (John 3:16; 1 John 5:11-12).

The above are only some of the basic differences between law/works and grace. These two systems operate according to *opposite principles,* which if mixed, cancel the effectiveness of each other. To confuse the law/works program of the Old Testament with the grace/faith program given to the Church destroys the effectiveness of both. To confuse the law/works program of the Messianic Kingdom, presented in the Synoptic Gospels and Acts, chapters 1-8, with the grace/faith program presented in the New Testament epistles, particularly those of Paul, is to be faced with many conflicting and contradictory statements.

The thinking person who recognizes these obvious contradictions, if he approaches the Bible in a literal manner, will be forced to acknowledge that these portions of the Bible deal with *different subjects, different economies,* some which are governed on the basis of law while others are governed on the basis of

grace. The thinking person with a more cynical frame of mind, who is too lazy to investigate just what the Bible really says, may in his slothful academics reject it as a trustworthy book due to these seeming contradictions.

The most subtle, and perhaps the most devastating result of mixing law/works with grace, is the subconscious effect it has on those who do so. Sorry to say, but it is a fact, most believers don't personally think their own way through the Scriptures. They commonly depend upon some person or persons to tell them what the Bible teaches. If their teachers do not adequately distinguish Mosaic and Kingdom laws, with their works, from the Grace Truth for the Church, inconsistent conflicting thoughts will be impinging upon their minds. As this insidious process goes on and on, at a conscious or subconscious level, without being resolved, it will tend to *dilute their attitude toward the Truth*.

Grace Truth given to the Church should be explicitly obeyed; however, when opposed by misapplied laws from Moses or the Kingdom, the internal mental struggle which pursues *robs believers of a keen appreciation for Grace Truth and the readiness to obey it.* Instead of enjoying spiritual buoyancy in the body of Christ, they often tend to drift into a state of spiritual indifference and coolness. This, as we see it, is the most widespread and devastating result of canceling out grace by mingling law with it. This is the reason why we take an uncompromising stand against injecting the Mosaic Law or Kingdom law into this Church age. The works of the law mitigate grace, in fact, Paul says that the result is, "grace is no longer grace."

7. ***"What then? that which Israel seeks, it did not obtain this, but the election obtained it, and the rest were hardened;"***

In the light of what Paul has said in the two preceding verses about grace and law, he begins this verse with the phrase "what then?" (τι ουτι), i.e., Israel did not obtain righteousness and salvation because they did not seek for it according to grace. That which Israel was seeking was *their own righteousness* via the Law (10:3). The Greek word translated "seeks" (επιζητει) in this verse has the preposition "επι" prefixed to the Greek verb "ζητεω" for the purpose of emphasis. It may well be translated that which Israel *diligently, fervently,* and *persistently* seeks they did not obtain. The reason Israel did not obtain it was not because they failed to diligently pursue it, for this they did, but it was because of the *weakness of their flesh* while they were under the Law (8:3), and it was because they were seeking it *from the wrong source,* works instead of grace, when Paul was writing this epistle.

Paul affirms that Israel, as a whole, did not obtain righteousness and salvation. The Greek verb translated "obtain" (επετυχεν) means that Israel *did not arrive at, reach,* or *attain unto* salvation. In other words, in his day, Paul looked at the vast majority of Israelites as being estranged from God, as having no real spiritual relationship with Him. They had a godly zeal, but it

was not according to knowledge, for they were ignorant of the righteousness of God in Christ (10:2-4).

The fact that Israel as a whole did not obtain salvation does not mean that the Gospel, the Word of God, had failed (9:6). Whether or not a thing fails or succeeds depends upon the extent to which it accomplishes the purpose for which it was given. If the purpose of the Gospel was to save all Israelites according to the flesh, then it has been a colossal failure. If, on the other hand, the purpose of the Gospel is to save a God-given remnant out of Israel, then it has been successful (9:6-8; 11:5).

Just as certainly as Israel did not obtain salvation by works, "the election obtained it." The same Greek verb is used for "obtain" (επετυχεν) in both of these clauses. Israel did not acquire it by Law/works, but the election acquired it by grace. The Greek noun translated "election" (εκλογη) refers to God's *speaking out, selecting,* and *choosing* certain individuals for salvation: those whom God has chosen before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4), those whom He foreknew and foreordained (8:29), those to whom He extends mercy and calls (9:23-24). All these will be made righteous via faith and saved. The faith which God implants in His elect, in conjunction with the Holy Spirit, irresistibly brings them into an eternal relationship with Christ in God. This means that the Gospel elicits a one hundred percent response from God's elect, and therefore is perfectly successful in accomplishing its purpose.

What about the Israelites who are not among the elect? With reference to them Paul says, "and the rest were hardened." The phrase translated "the rest" (οι λοιποι) means *the remaining ones* or *those left* were hardened. The Greek verb rendered "were hardened" (επωρωθησαν) is in the aorist tense and the passive voice, which means that at a given point of time in the past *they were made unimpressionable, insensible,* and *calloused*. The passive voice indicates that an outside person hardened them. The alternatives would be either *God* or *Satan*. According to Genesis 3:4-5, Satan in the form of a serpent, made Adam and Eve *insensible to God's words*. It is logical to think that when Adam and Eve's sin resulted in their spiritual and physical death as a result of their obedience to Satan, that in their association with him he hardened them against God (1:24, 26, 28; Eph. 2:1-3). In summary, Adam and Eve sinned against God, and He gave them up to Satan's sphere, who in turn hardened and petrified them against God.

8. ***"even as it has been written,* God gave to them a spirit of slumber, eyes that should not see, and ears that should not hear, until this very day."**

Paul is citing this verse from Deuteronomy 29:4 to verify the fact that the rest were hardened. He says that God "gave" (εδωκεν) to them, at a point in past time, a spirit of "slumber" (κατανυξεως), *stupor*, and *dullness*. This involved eyes that would not see and ears that would not hear. This statement was spoken by the Lord through Moses to the Children of Israel in Moab. It is

affirmed that this condition existed up until the day it was spoken. We hold that this stupor, lack of perception, and inability to hear are results of the Adamic Fall, a part of the curse resulting from it. It is not that God elected some and hardened some, but *He elected some out of all men who had been hardened*. If it weren't for Divine election all men would remain in a hardened, calloused, and petrified position against God (1:24-32; 3:9-18).

9. ***"And David says*, Let their table be unto a snare and a trap and a stumbling block and a recompense to them,"**

The forepart of this verse is quoted from Psalms 69:22, where David is speaking to God about his adversaries. Paul cites this verse as a description of those who are hardened and calloused against God. David invokes God to let their table become a ruinous snare, to let their peace become a trap, unto the end that the same may be a stumbling block and a proper retribution unto them. Paul seems to be saying with respect to those who have been hardened, let the manner in which they have treated others be returned unto them (cf. v. 7). On the one hand, Paul's petition was that his Jewish kinsmen might be saved (10:1). On the other hand, he does not plead mercy for those who are hardened, but justice, that they may be justly rewarded for their evil. Paul's ministry was *directed toward the elect,* who are scattered among all; therefore, it encompassed all men (2 Tim. 2:10).

10. **"let their eyes be darkened that they may not see, and their back continually bowed."**

The forepart of this quotation is from Psalm 69:23. In contrast to the statement of fact in verse 8, where it is said that they have eyes which are not able to see, this verse is an imprecation *that they may not be able to see.* He further imprecates that their backs may be continually bowed. As Paul identifies this passage with those who have been hardened, it portrays them as a *spiritually blind people who are bowed down under their burdens.*

Summarizing, verses 1-10 teach that God has not cast away His people, Israel. Even as God had a remnant in Elijah's time, likewise in this present time He has a remnant called out according to the election of grace. Paul emphasizes that if this election is by grace, which it is, then there is *absolutely no room for works*. He points out that Israel as a whole did not obtain the salvation which they sought via the works of the Law, but the elect Israelites did obtain it. He classifies Israel as a whole as being hardened, a fact which he verifies from the Old Testament.

11. ***"I say then, Did they stumble in order that they might fall? May it never be, but by their fall salvation is come to the Gentiles, unto the end to provoke them to jealousy."***

In view of the comparatively small number of Jews being saved in this Church age according to the election of grace, and the large number who were hardened, Paul speaks of Israel as having "stumbled" (επταισαν), *of having failed to reach its goal,* or *as having fallen.* James uses this same word to

depict the person who stumbles over one thing in the Mosaic Law; he is guilty of all the Law (James 2:10).

Paul asks the question: Did they stumble in order that (ινα) or for the purpose that they might fall? In other words, did God permit or cause Israel to stumble just so He could see her "fall" (πεσωσιν), *fall down,* or *fall short of obtaining salvation* by grace in Christ? Paul's answer to these questions is, may this never be God's purpose, or let it never be the reason for Israel's stumbling (2 Peter 1:10).

In contrast to the question, did Israel stumble that they might fall? Paul emphatically answers No, "but" (αλλα) by their fall salvation is come to the Gentiles. What was it about the fall of Israel that causes salvation to go to the Gentiles? It was their hardness,adamantness, and unyielding refusal to believe in Jesus Christ, the one who embodied the righteousness of God. According to Acts 13:46; 18:6; and 28:28, the Jewish rejection of the Gospel caused it to be preached to the Gentiles. Israel's rejection stimulated preaching to the Gentiles - their reception.

By means of Israel's fall, salvation reached out to the Gentiles. The very end of which was "to provoke them unto jealousy." Keep in mind that Paul's emphasis in this chapter is on Israel, not on the Gentiles, and the initial reason he turned to preaching to the Gentiles was in order to stir up jealousy in the midst of *Israel*, to motivate them to believe the Good News about Jesus Christ. The Greek infinitive translated "to provoke to jealousy" (παραζηλωσαι) conveys the idea in this verse of *exciting to emulate, to vie to surpass, to make them envious to believe on Christ* (10:19).

12. ***"But if their fall is the riches of the world, and their failure the riches of the Gentiles, how much more their fullness."***

The Greek noun translated "fall" (απαραπτωμα) is derived from the preposition "παρα " prefixed to the verb "πιπτω" and literally means *to fall by the side of, to fall away* with respect to the truth, hence *to trespass,* or *a transgression*. According to the breadth of meaning of this noun the fall of Israel may also be called *the trespass or transgression of Israel.* Since their fall involved their hardened, adamant and obdurate mind and heart, which was manifest in unbelief, it follows that *their unbelief could be equated with their trespass or transgression*. We must, however, bear in mind that unbelief is the symptom of a faulty mind/heart attitude toward God. To say that Israel's transgression is unbelief is not adequately comprehensive, for it should also include that which produced the unbelief, namely, their hardened condition.

Now let us compare the two "if" (ει) clauses: 1) if the fall of Israel is the riches of the world; 2) and if the failure of Israel is the riches of the Gentiles. It appears to us that these two clauses, even though worded differently for variety, say basically the same thing. The Greek words rendered "fall" (παραπτωμα) and "failure" (ηττημα) portray their *sinful condition*, their trespassing and defaulting. The Greek word for "world" (κοσμου) is

apparently used to depict *Gentiles*. This means that if their trespassing and defaulting has resulted in the riches of the Gentiles, then "how much more their fullness."

The Greek noun rendered "fullness" refers to the *completion and consummation* of Israel - God's receiving them in full fellowship with Himself (v. 15). It speaks of the time when all Israel shall be saved (v. 26), a time when God will pour out His mercy, not just on a remnant, but on all Israel (v. 31).

13. ***"But I speak to you who are Gentiles. Inasmuch then that I am the apostle of the Gentiles, I glorify my ministry,"***

In verses 11-12 Paul was primarily directing his remarks to the Gentiles. The Greek phrase translated "inasmuch" (εφ' οσον) may also be rendered *in as much as* or *as long as* I am the apostle of the Gentiles.

Here Paul refers to himself as the apostle "of the Gentiles" (εθνων), i.e., *belonging to the Gentiles*. When he was saved on the Damascus Road, the Lord told Ananias, "This one is an elect vessel for me, to bear my name before the Gentiles and kings and the Children of Israel" (Acts 9:15). In Romans 15:16 Paul refers to himself as a "minister of Christ Jesus unto the Gentiles." In Galatians 2:7-9 Peter, James, and John recognize that the Lord had made Paul the apostle of the Gentiles. Several other passages affirm that Paul had the message for the Gentiles committed unto him (Eph. 3:1; 1 Tim. 2:7; 2 Tim. 4:17).

With respect to his ministry unto the Gentiles, Paul says, "I glorify" (δοξαζω) it. This means that he *thought very highly of his ministry, he invested it with dignity,* and *magnified it.* There is no doubt about it, God bestowed a great honor on Paul when He selected him to be the apostle of the Gentiles, and as a result Paul did not take it lightly, but exalted and extolled it (2 Cor. 3:8-9).

14. ***"if somehow I may provoke to jealousy my flesh and save some out of them."***

The adverb translated "somehow" (πως) means if in *some manner* or *some way* Paul might provoke to jealousy his kinsmen. As previously noted, the verb rendered "provoke to jealousy" (παραζηλωσω) conveys the idea of *inciting to rivalry, agitating to compete,* and *rousing one to emulate*. Three out of the four times this word is used in the New Testament, it refers to God's saving Gentiles to provoke Jews, Paul's own "flesh" (σαρκα), kindred, and the seed of Abraham to be saved (10:19; 11:11).

It is important to observe that Paul *does not say* that he desires, somehow, to rouse up all Israel to be saved, but only "some out of them." The indefinite pronoun translated "some" (τινας) means *certain ones* or *some ones.* Paul uses this same pronoun in First Corinthians 9:22, where he says, "I have become all things to all men, in orαer that by all means I might save some." Paul has made it crystal clear in this and the two preceding chapters that

God's current purpose is to save *some, a remnant*, out of Israel. As Paul looks back to the *some* who have been saved, he calls then the *elect* (11:7; 2 Tim. 2:10).

15. ***"For if the casting away of them is the reconciliation of the world, what shall the receiving of them be except life out from the dead?"***

Previously, Paul spoke of their *fall* as being unto the end of the salvation of the Gentiles and the riches of the world (vv. 11-12). Now he speaks of the same thing as *the casting away* of them being unto the end of the reconciliation of the world. Here we have a duplication of the same ideas and thoughts expressed in different terminology. The point is that if the fall and "casting away" (αποβοκη) or *throwing away* of Israel results in the salvation and reconciliation of the "world" (κοσμου), i.e., of the Gentiles, "what shall the receiving of them [the Gentiles] be except life out from the dead?"

Paul looked forward to the time when God will take or receive unto Himself all Israel. He refers to this as "the receiving" (η ποισλημψις), *the taking,* or *the acquiring* of Israel unto Himself as His special people (cf. Titus 2:14). Paul describes this receiving of Israel as nothing short of raising them out of spiritual death into spiritual life, or it may be interpreted as raising them out from physical death unto spiritual life, or both could be true.

16. ***"And if the firstfruit is holy, also the lump; and if the root is holy, also the branches."***

Here we have a picture of the "firstfruit" (απαρχη), *the first grain* from a new crop which is kneaded into a lump of dough. The point is that the characteristics of the first grain threshed will carry over to the lump of dough made from it. If the firstfruit is holy, the election by grace, then the lump as a part of it will likewise be holy.

Furthermore, if the root is holy, also the branches. Again, the principle is that the qualities of the root will show in the branches. Holy roots will produce holy branches. From a holy remnant according to election God will ultimately produce holy branches.

17. ***"But if some of the branches were broken off, and you being a wild olive were grafted in among them, and you were made a joint-partaker of the riches of the root of the olive tree,"***

We need to approach this verse with a given perspective; namely, that Paul is looking at *Israel as an olive tree* (cf. v. 24). When he speaks of some of the branches being "broken off" (εξεκλασθησαν), removed through breaking off, he obviously is referring to the *nonelect Israelites* who were left in their hardened condition (v. 7). The Greek word rendered "some" (τινες) speaks of those who were *not vessels of mercy* (9:23).

Paul uses the noun translated "wild olive" (αψριελαιος) or *wild olive tree* to depict the Gentiles (cf. v. 24). As we have observed, when Israel, due to its hardness of heart, refused to believe the Gospel of Grace, Paul turned to

the Gentiles (Acts 13:46; 18:6; 28:28). The original intent seems to have been to provoke to jealously Israel to the end that they might believe. As a result of the Gospel being preached to the Gentiles many believed, and as *wild olive tree branches* they were "grafted" (ενεκεντρισθης), *ingrafted* among the remaining branches on the olive tree, Israel. This indicates that Israel, as the seed of Abraham, is the first fruit, the root, and the foundation for the Gospel of salvation in this age of Grace (3:1-2, 29-30; Gal. 4:4).

As Paul continues to address the individual Gentile in this verse, he says, "and you were made a joint-partaker of the riches of the root of the olive tree." The Greek participle translated "joint-partaker" (συγκοινωνος) denotes one who *shares with, who is a co-partner,* or *a co-participant* of the riches which emanate from the olive tree, Israel. In John 4:22, Jesus says, "Salvation is out of the Jews."

18. ***"do not be arrogant against the branches; and if you are arrogant, you do not support the root, but the root you."***

The Greek verb rendered "arrogant" (κατακαυχω) may mean *to boast* or *vaunt one's self.* It appears that Paul is warning the Gentile convert not to assume an arrogant attitude toward the *natural branches,* elect Israel. He must keep in mind that Israel is the root which "supports" (βασταζεις), bears, and holds him up rather than vice versa. As Gentile believers, we need to recognize that we are deeply *indebted* to Israel, the true root and olive tree, for our salvation in Jesus Christ!

19. ***"Therefore you say, The branches were broken off that I might be grafted in."***

Having declared that some of the branches were broken off of the olive tree, Israel, and that believing Gentiles were grafted in, Paul predicts the reaction of some of the more haughty Gentiles. Assuming an attitude of false superiority over the faithless Jews, certain ones will say that the *reason* some Jews were broken off was that "I" (εγω), a more important Gentile, might be grafted in. The insinuation is that some of the Gentiles, relishing in their relationship with Christ but blinded by conceit, might think that God chose them over the Jews.

20. ***"Well, by unbelief they were broken off, but you by faith have stood. Be not high-minded, but fear;"***

This verse opens with the Greek adverb translated "well" (καλως), which conveys the thought that *rightly, correctly* and *truly* the faithless Jews were broken off. The reason they were broken off, however, was not just to give the Gentiles room to be grafted in, but because of their unbelief. The Greek phrase translated "by unbelief" (τη απιστια) indicates that *by means of* or *in the sphere of* unbelief they were extricated. There is no suggestion in this verse that the Gentiles had anything to do with Jewish branches being broken off from God's program, the Church. The reason for this breaking off was totally due to the failure of some Jews *to believe on Jesus Christ* as the Messiah and the Head of the Body.

As far as the Gentile converts are concerned, Paul says, "But you by faith have stood." The Greek verb translated "have stood" (εστηκας) is in the perfect tense, which means that at a given point of time in the past they *began standing and continue to stand.* The Greek phrase rendered "by faith" (τη πιστει) indicates that *by means of* or *in the sphere of faith* they have their relationship with God in Christ (cf. 1:5; 16:26; Gal. 3:8).

In view of the fact that the Gentiles stand by faith, Paul says, "Be not high-minded, but fear." This statement must be understood in the light of God's sovereign love and mercy. Our relationship to God does not depend upon our own determining and running, but upon *God's mercy*, provision of faith, and the drawing of us to Himself through the Holy Spirit (9:16; John 6:44; Eph. 2:4). As Paul looks back and sees many Jews, the natural branches, void of faith in Jesus Christ, hence, not a part of God's Church program in Christ, he justly warns the believing Gentiles not to be high-minded, conceited, and haughty. Instead they are to have an attitude of *fear, awe* and *reverence* toward God, realizing that He has the prerogative both to give and withhold.

21. ***"for if God did not spare the natural branches, neither will He spare you."***

In one sense the corporate seed of Abraham, Issac and Jacob constitute Israel, God's chosen people. In another sense God is selecting individuals out of His chosen Israel during this present dispensation of Grace (Eph. 3:2), and making them members of the Body of Christ, the Church. While Israel is a corporate group based upon blood lines, the Church is a spiritual organism based upon the Divine election of certain individuals out of Israel and the Gentiles (cf. 4:23-24; 9:6-7; Gal. 3:29).

Now that we have looked at the corporate seed of Abraham according to the flesh, the olive tree with its natural branches, let us consider the statement "for if God did not spare the natural branches." The Greek word translated "spare" (εφεισατο) means that God *did not remove* deserved judgment from most of the natural branches of Abraham. On the other hand, through sovereign election, through making some vessels of mercy, *He spared, removed* and *delivered* some from eternal judgment by putting them in Christ who has been judged for them (9:23). God did not spare His own Son in order that He might spare His elect chosen before the creation of the world (8:32; Eph. 1:4).

As Paul looked back and observed that the majority of the Jews, those who were God's chosen people, were not being spared from coming judgment through faith in Jesus Christ, he certainly had no reason to think that God would spare the Gentiles. The time had come in God's dealing with Israel that He left them to themselves in a state of *partial hardness*. Likewise, he predicts that the time will come when the Gentiles will not be spared from their deserved judgment, a time when the fullness of the Gentiles will be consummated (v. 25).

22. ***"Behold then the kindness and severity of God. Upon those who had fallen severity, but upon you God's kindness, if you continue in the kindness, since you also shall be cut off."***

In this verse Paul exhorts us to "behold" (ιδε), look at, and consider "the kindness and severity of God." The Greek word translated "kindness" (χρηστοτητα) basically speaks of God's giving that which is *useful*, which involves His *kindness, goodness* and *beneficence.* The most useful thing God can do for any man is to bring him into a living relationship with Himself. Paul's emphasis here is on God's kindness as seen in His making certain individuals the *recipients of His mercy, faith,* and salvation in Christ. He has abundantly poured out His kindness toward us by making us alive together with Christ, raising us up with Christ, and seating us in the heavenlies with Him (9:23; Eph. 2:5-8).

Having observed the kindness of God, Paul also speaks of His "severity" (αποτομιαν). This word basically means *to cut off* or *cut from* hence, it indicates that God is also severe, sharp and unsparing in His dealings with those who justly deserve judgment. Apart from God's love and mercy, through which He calls out a people unto His Name, all men would experience his severity and wrath against sin (John 3:36; Eph. 5:6).

On the one hand, severity is upon those who have fallen, i.e., upon the Jews who have been cut off, left in their unbelief, and who reject the Person of Jesus Christ. On the other hand, *the Gentiles* whom Paul is addressing are the recipients of the kindness of God; i.e., they have been individually elected to occupy a place in the Body of Christ. As we look at all men in the light of the truth presented in this chapter, rhey fall in two categories: those who are obstinate unbelievers under the severity of God, and those who are genuine believers under the kindness of God.

Since Paul never vouches for any person's relation to sod, as to whether it was feigned or real, he adds the statement, "if you continue in the kindness." If Paul saw a believer honestly endeavoring to live in accordance with the Word of God, he assumed that he was one of the elect, enjoying the benefits of the kindness of God (cf. 1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23.) If the person did not "continue" (επιμενης), *remain in*, and *persevere* in that which God provided by His kindness, then he would be considered as a cut off one; i.e., he would be under the severity rather than the kindness of God.

23. ***"And also those, if they do not continue in unbelief, will be grafted in; for God is able to graft them in again."***

In this verse Paul is referring to the Jews, the natural branches, who have been broken off. He says that if they do not "continue" (επιμενωσιν), *remain in*, and *persist* in "unbelief" (τη απιστια), *being void and without faith*, then they will be grafted in again. Superficially looking at this statement it might appear that the Jews themselves are the ones determining their future destiny, i.e., whether or not they will be regrafted into a vital relationship with

God. In the light of the entire context, however, God is the one who is sovereignly determining Israel's future destiny (vv. 24-32). The use of the passive voice makes its clear, God is the one who broke them off; likewise, He is the one who will graft them in again.

We must keep in mind that the Jews continuation in unbelief is intertwined with God extending His mercy toward them (9:16, 23). As a part of the sinful Adamic race, left to be themselves, they were in a state of unbelief (Eph. 2:1-3), which resulted in God removing them from fellowship with Himself. In order for them not to continue in unbelief, not to be what they are in their sinful nature. God has to take the initiative and *give them the faith* by which they become identified with Himself. When God instills in them faith (10:17; 1 Tim. 1:14), which the Holy Spirit enables them to exercise, that will be the time when they are again grafted into a living relationship with God.

Now let us consider the statement "for God is able to graft them in again." First, this implies that at one time Israel did have a vital relationship with God. Since the Fall of Adam and Eve this relationship has depended upon God-given faith. Abraham had this relationship (4:9). Issac, Jacob, Moses, Joseph and the prophets all displayed this faith either by what they said or did. It is into this living relationship that God is going to restore unbelieving Israel. Second, this verse makes it crystal clear - *God is the one* who is able to graft them in again. Third, the implication is that partial hardness will rest upon Israel until the fullness of the Gentiles has come; therefore we do not anticipate that this grafting will take place until the establishment of the Messianic Kingdom. We can expect the majority of Jews to remain in unbelief during the rest of this Church age.

24. ***"For if you were cut out of the wild olive tree by nature, and contrary to nature were grafted into a good olive tree, how much more these of like nature will be grafted into their own olive tree."***

Keep in mind that Paul is primarily addressing the Gentiles in this section (v. 13). He is explaining to them that God has not given up Israel; they are not doomed to permanent unbelief, but the time will come when God will graft them into a relationship with Himself in the Kingdom.

He tells the Gentiles that if God saw fit to cut them, branches out of a wild olive tree, and "contrary" (παρα φυσιν) or *beyond nature* to graft them into a good olive tree, then it would be very simple for Him to regraft Jews into their own olive tree. God's decision to give the Gentiles faith to believe the Gospel was not because they were better than the Jews, contrariwise they were far worse (1:20-32), but His decision based on love prompted mercy (Eph. 2:4). Also, God's decision to save Gentiles was designed to provoke the Jews to emulate the faith of the Gentiles (v. 11).

Paul's point is that if God extended His love and mercy to the Gentiles, who were practicing every conceivable abominable act, a people void of the disciplinary influence of God, and as such designated a *wild olive tree*, how much more will He extend His mercy to Israel, a people who had been

disciplined and cultivated by His Word, hence, a *good* or *tame olive tree*. Furthermore, grafting the Gentiles into the good olive tree was an act contrary to nature, whereas grafting the Jews in again would be rejoining that which belonged together. What God has done for the Gentiles, a far off people, *assures us of what He will do for the Jews,* a near people (Eph. 2:13).

25. ***"For I do not want you to be ignorant of this mystery, brethren, in order that you might not be wise among yourselves, for Israel has been partially hardened until the fullness of the Gentiles may come in,"***

As we observed in verses 19-20 some of the believing Gentiles were assuming a haughty attitude toward the unbelieving Jews. The reason Paul is telling these Gentiles about the future God has in store for the Jews is to prevent them from becoming "wise" (φρονιμοι), *conceited*, and *intellectually proud* among themselves. In other words, Paul is trying to keep them *humble-minded*, and from thinking that they are better than the unbelieving Jews. In fact, some of them were probably thinking that they had replaced the Jews as God's chosen people. The thought seems to be that they were assuming this intelligentsia attitude "among themselves" (εν εαυτοις).

Paul's method of combating this unjustified conceit was to give them knowledge regarding God's future plan for Israel. He literally tells them not to think that they are better than the unbelieving Jews, for God has a bright future for them, for He is going to pour out His elective mercy upon them and graft them into a Kingdom relationship with Himself (Acts 3:17-25). He refers to the truth which he is sharing regarding Israel's future, as he looks at it from the vantage point of this Church age, as "this mystery" (το μυστηριον τουτο). Since nothing is revealed regarding the present Church age in the Old Testament, and what Paul is saying here pertains to Israel during this Church age, it was naturally a mystery or secret until revealed here by Paul.

At the present time "partial hardness" (πωρωσος απο μερους), *hardness from part* has come to Israel. This hardness will continue to blind the majority of Israelites "until the fullness of the Gentiles may come in." As we see it the fullness of the Gentiles corresponds with the consummation of this Church age. The fact that this hardness is partial means that *some Jews* will be receiving mercy and faith to believe today. As for the Jewish masses, Paul gives us no reason to think that they will be ready to believe the Gospel of God's Grace.

26. ***"and thus all Israel will be saved; even as it has been written,* The deliverer will come out of Zion, He will turn ungodliness from Jacob;"**

When the fullness of the Gentiles has arrived, when the Messianic Kingdom is ready to be established, then "all Israel will be saved." This is according to Old Testament prophecy, not the Mystery; therefore Paul corroborates it with a quotation from the Old Testament (Isa. 59:20-21; Jer. 31:34).

The Apostle Paul, in the context before us, leaves no room for believing Gentiles to think that they are superior to anbelieving Jews. For Gentile believers to assume a haughty attitude toward faithless Jews, and to think that they have replaced the Jews in God's eternal purpose is to display crass ignorance of the Scriptures. The Kingdom, which will consist of saved Israel, will be the core of Christ's Kingdom (Gen. 12:1-3).

27. ***"and this is my covenant with them, when I have taken away their sins."***

Since this is merely an Old Testament quotation to con•:rm the fact that in the future *all Israel* will be saved, it is not purpose to examine its ramifications. According to the Greek used here, an alternative translation might be, *And this is the covenant from me with them, whenever I may have taken away their sins*. The Greek text emphasizes the fact that God is the one who will make the covenant, and that it will be made in God's time *after* He has taken away their sins.

28. ***"With respect to the gospel they are enemies on account of you, but with respect to the election they are beloved on account of the fathers;"***

In view of the grammatical construction of this verse, and the obvious meaning of the particles "μεν" and "δε," we will also give an amplified translation. Paul says, *On the one hand, with respect to the gospel they are enemies on account of you, but on the other hand, with respect to the election they are beloved on account of the fathers.* The verse indicates that God has a dual purpose which He is accomplishing through Israel. At the present time they are unbelieving enemies of the Gospel of God's Grace. The reason is "on account of" (δι' υμας), *because of,* and *for the sake of* the Gentiles.

There are two ways in which the Gentiles have been blessed as a result of the majority of the Jews being enemies of the Gospel of the Kingdom and the Gospel of the Grace of God. First, their rejection of the Kingdom presented in the Synoptic Gospels and the first seven chapters in Acts resulted in the ushering in of the present Church age, the dispensation of Grace in which believing Gentiles are equally blessed with believing Jews in the family of God (Eph. 2:19). Second, when the majority of the Jews, particularly the leaders, rejected the Gospel of the Grace of God, Paul turned to the Gentiles (Acts 13:46; 18:6; 28:28). This in turn had the positive effect of provoking some of the Jews to emulate the Gentiles, to also believe.

Now let us look at God's elective purpose in relation to Israel. Paul says that when it comes to the issue of "election they are beloved on account of the fathers." The Greek word translated "election" (εκλογην) is derived from the preposition "εκ" prefixed to the verb "λεγω" and literally means *to speak out, to pick out,* or *the act of choosing or selecting people*. Paul's point here is that when it comes to God's determining whom He will choose and select, the Jews had an edge; they are "beloved" (αγαπητοι) on account of or

because of the Fathers, namely, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, etc. In the light of God's present intertwined purpose to bless the Gentiles through the enmity of the majority of the Jews toward the Gospel, there is not favoritism in election during this Church age; however, when the Messianic Kingdom is established, every true descendant of Abraham will be saved. God will keep His promises made unto the fathers, which involves esteeming their offspring as beloved ones, the recipients of ultimate mercy and election (Deut. 7 8; 9:5; 10:15).

29. ***"for the gifts and the calling of God are not repentable."***

The thought in this verse is that what God had given to the fathers, and the distinct calling which He had called them unto (Gen. 12:1-3), these are unrepentable; i.e., God is *not able* to repent for what He has given nor for whom He has called. The Greek word translated "not repentable" (αμεταμελητα) is derived from "α" and "μετα" and "μελομαι" and means that God does *not regret, rue* or *change his thoughts* regarding the promises and oaths He has given to the fathers. God being God, who has a panoramic view of eternity past and future, would have no reason to regret what He did at any point in time. Furthermore, the moral character of God would be violated if He did not fulfill His promises and oaths; therefore Paul could confidently affirm that the descendants of the fathers were beloved ones, with a top election priority.

Even though this verse has reference to the gifts and the calling of God given to the fathers of Israel, it sets forth an important principle relating to God's dealing with His elect. If a sinner exercises God-given faith in Jesus Christ, thereby verifying the fact that he is one of the elect, it follows that nothing can break his God-established relationship, not even God Himself. God's call to salvation, apart from which no one can be saved, is totally the work of God through the Holy Spirit. In bringing sinners to Himself God first selects (Eph. 1:4), next He *predetermines* (2 Tim. 1:9), then He *calls* (Rom. 8:30), *justifies*, and ultimately *glorifies*. All that is involved in making a sinner into a saint is the gift of God (Eph. 2:8). It is irrevocable, unalterable, and eternal!

30. ***"For even as you once were disobedient to God, but now you have been given mercy by the disobedience of these,"***

In addressing Gentile believers Paul reminds them that ` `once" (ποτε), *at one time, formerly* they were disobedient to God. The Greek verb translated "disobedient" (ηπειθησατε) is frequently used as a synonym of the Greek verb rendered *not to believe* or *to disbelieve* (απιστεω; cf. John 3:36). Also in the noun forms of these words there is an interchange between *unbelief* (απιστια) and *disobedience* (απειθεια). Likewise, the Jews who were in a state of unbelief were in a state of disobedience (vv. 20, 30). Unbelief in itself is both an act of disobedience and it *leads* to disobedience. To refuse to believe God is tantamount to refusing to obey Him; therefore these two words are used synonymously.

Once disobedience to God was the lot of the Gentiles, but Paul says, "Now you have been given mercy by the disobedience of these." The Greek verb translated "you have been given mercy" (ηλεηθητε) is in the passive voice and aorist tense. This means that at a point in past time *God gave and extended to them mercy*. He made them vessels of mercy, those who had believed, individually calling them *out of* (εκ) the Jews and Gentiles (9:23-24). The concepts of mercy and election are inextricably tied together. Because sinners are part of God's elect, they receive mercy with all it entails, as a result they exercise faith in Christ, and as such Paul speaks of them as the elect. Paul refers to those who *have believed* as the elect.

How did the once disobedient Gentiles receive saving mercy? Paul's answer is by the disobedience of the Jews. It is impossible for our finite minds to fully grasp how the disobedience of the Jews produced such a great outpouring of the mercy of God upon individual Gentiles, but it has. As we have already suggested, this disobedience ushered in the Church age, a time when "the fullness of the Gentiles" is taking place. Furthermore, in the process of proclaiming the Gospel to the Jews, their rejection of it resulted in a turning to the Gentiles (Acts 13:46; 18:6; 28:28). Of course, behind all this God was fulfilling His sovereign purpose - provoking Israel to believe (v. 11).

31. ***"as also these now have been disobedient for your mercy, in order that they themselves might now be given mercy;"***

There appears to be a difference of opinion as to the best way to translate this verse. Our translation is in accordance with the grammatical construction, flowing with the context, making good sense.

The statement "as also these now have been disobedient" is written to believing Gentiles pertaining to unbelieving Jews. The verb translated "have been disobedient" (ηπειθησαν) is in the aorist tense, which means that in the present dispensation of Grace they had manifested their disobedience to the Gospel.

Why were these Jews disobedient? Paul tells the Gentiles that it was "for your mercy" (τω υμετερω ελεει). We have translated the case used here as a dative, which means that the Jew's disobedience was *for, with reference* to the Gentiles being given mercy. Jewish disobedience directs Divine mercy toward the Gentiles.

We observe that the purpose or reason the Jews were disobedient was that the Gentiles might be given mercy, and this in turn, in order that they, the Jews, "might now be given mercy." In God's sovereign saving of Gentiles and Jews, first He uses the disobedience of the Jews to bring the Gentiles to Himself, and having accomplished this, He is now in a position to extend mercy to the Jews. This statement involves God giving mercy to individual Jews in this Church age as well as to every true descendant of Abraham when the Messianic Kingdom is established.

32. ***"for God has shut up all unto disobedience that he might extend mercy to all."***

The Greek verb translated "shut up" (συνεκλεισεν) means that He *shut up together* or *locked up* together all men, both the Jews and Gentiles, in the sphere of disobedience. This is an iteration of the truth set forth in the third chapter, verse 9, where Paul says, "For we before proved that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin." Likewise, in Ephesians 2:3 Paul speaks of both Jews and Gentiles; he says that we all once were "doing the will of the flesh and of the minds, and we were by nature children of wrath as also the rest." The reason God has shut all men in the category of disobedience is so not one can boast that he has saved himself by his works (3:27-28; Eph. 2:9).

The reason God locked all men under disobedience was "in order that [ινα] He might have mercy on all." From the foregoing context we know that God will have mercy on *all the Jews* who are Abraham's descendants after the close of this Church age (vv. 25-26). Paul speaks here about a glorious future for the Jews, but after the fullness of the Gentiles has arrived, we have no reason to expect a great outpouring of mercy upon them. There is no question about it, all men are shut up together unto disobedience, and hence are potential candidates for receiving mercy. But we have no basis for saying that Gentiles are the recipients of God's mercy until after we see the results of that mercy, namely, their salvation.

We need to keep very clearly in mind that God has *only one way* of saving sinners and that is by His mercy. His redemptive purpose operates according to election, initiated by love, and actuated by mercy. According to the ninth chapter, Divinely distributed mercy is the key ingredient in determining who will be saved (9:15-18, 23). According to Ephesians 2:4-6, love-prompted mercy made us alive with Christ; it raised and seated us in the heavenlies with Him. According to Titus 3:5 God saved us in accordance with His mercy. The mercy of God provides all that is necessary for the saving of God's elect.

33. ***"Oh, the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God; how unsearchable are his judgments and his ways cannot be tracked out."***

As the Apostle Paul reflects back on what he has written regarding God's sovereign method of bringing Jews and Gentiles into a living relationship with Himself, he pens the majestic words in this verse. He is struck with the "depth" (βαθος), *how deep*, and *how immeasurable* are the riches which belong to the wisdom and knowledge of God. The word translated "wisdom" (σοφιας) is used some 16 times in the New Testament pertaining to truth revealed for the Body of Christ. Paul says that this wisdom and knowledge (γνωσεως) *belong to God*, have their origin in God, and are a part of mystery truth (v. 25), Truth for the Church.

Continuing in the same vein, Paul says, "How unsearchable are the judgments" of God. The Greek word translated "unsearchable" (ανεξεραυωτα) is derived from three Greek words and literally speaks of

that which *cannot be searched out, cannot be interpreted,* and *cannot be scrutinized*. This is the only time this word is used in the New Testament. As far as all that was written is concerned, what Paul has said about God's "judgments" (τα κριματα), *determinations*, and *manner of executing* the salvation of Jews and Gentiles, it cannot be searched out in the Old Testament nor otherwise. Since this truth was a *secret* in the mind of God prior to the Apostle Paul, it is now called mystery truth, even though now revealed. In other words, truth which God formerly kept a secret and mystery is now *named by its former description.* Previously described as that which was a mystery, it is *now known as the mystery*.

Also, Paul says that it is impossible to follow the tracks of God's ways. The Greek word translated "cannot be tracked out" (ανεξιχνιαστοι) means that *the tracks of His ways cannot be followed* and *cannot be traced*. The only other time this word is used in the New Testament is in Ephesians 3:8, where Paul says that it was given unto him "to preach to the Gentiles the *untrackable riches* of Christ." The immediate context in this third chapter of Ephesians makes it crystal clear, Paul is declaring that the wisdom and knowledge of the Mystery cannot be tracked or traced out in the Old Testament nor any other body of literature. In this 33rd verse Paul is emphasizing God's sovereign purpose in soteriology, truth which had not been revealed in the Old Testament, namely, that Israel has been partially hardened until the fulness of the Gentiles may come in (cf. Gal. 1:12; 2 Tim. 1:9-13).

34. **"For who has known the mind of the Lord? or who has become his counselor?"**

After having affirmed that the particular truth he is talking about cannot be traced out in the Old Testament, Paul now quotes from the Old Testament to corroborate a universal truth about God. He has just gotten through pointing out how incomprehensible God's wisdom, knowledge, and ways are, and now he adds the weight of the Old Testament to his argument. He does this in the form of asking two questions: Who has known the mind of the Lord? and who has assumed the position of being His counselor? The obvious answer to both of these questions is: 1) no one has ever known the mind of the Lord apart from what God may have been pleased to reveal, and 2) no one has ever counseled and deliberated with Him as to what He should or should not do (cf. Isa. 40:13; Jer. 23:18).

35. **"Or who has first given to him, and it shall be repaid unto him again?"**

In emphasizing God's wisdom and knowledge, and His unsearchable judgments and untraceable ways, Paul quotes the first part of Job 41:11. His purpose is to emphasize that everything belongs to God. He is the one who initiates and gives all things, and He does not do this in response to what man has done. The manner in which God operates is beyond human comprehension; it cannot be searched or tracked out. That which He gives to

men is according to His sovereign will, and not as a repayment for something they may have done.

36. ***"Because out of him and through him and unto him are all things. To him be the glory forever. Amen."***

Speaking with reference to God, the possessor of unfathomable wisdom and knowledge, Paul affirms that He has said the foregoing, "Because out of him and through him and unto him are all things." This verse begins with the Greek conjunction "οτι," which we have translated *because*. It may also be rendered *for that*, expressing *why* or *the reason* he said what he did in the preceding verse.

The Greek phrase translated "out of him" (εξ αυτου) is in the ablative case, and means that God is the source of all things, the one from whom everything comes, the origin of all. According to Colossians 1:16, God the Father in conjunction with God the Son "created all things in the heavens and upon the earth" (cf. John 1:3; Eph. 3:9; Rev. 4:11).

The Greek phrase translated "through him" (δι' αυτου) declares that all things were brought into existence through the agency of God. Colossians 1:16, likewise, speaks of all things being created *through* (δια) Jesus Christ. These passages indicate that both the Father and Son were active agents in the creation of all things (cf. Heb. 1:2; 2:10).

The Greek phrase translated "unto him" (εις αυτον) means that the *end* or *object* of all things which have been created is God Himself. Again we observe that God the Son shares with God the Father as the end and object of creation according to Colossians 1:16 (cf. Heb. 2:10). All of creation, as originally created, had as its purpose the glorification of God the Father and Son!

As Paul closes his discourse regarding how God sovereignly brings sinners to Himself through His elective purpose (8:28; 9:11), recorded in chapters 8-11, he exclaims, "To him be the glory forever. Amen." These four chapters make it very clear that apart from God sovereignly choosing and imbuing sinners with faith, no one would believe, no one would be saved. As God is calling individual Jews and Gentiles unto Himself in this present Church age, apart from all human merit, He alone is to be glorified. As we look out in the future and recognize that the time is coming when all Israel will be saved, according to God's elective purpose, all the redeemed will glorify His Name for faithfully fulfilling His promise to the fathers (v. 28).

Chapter 12

1. ***"I exhort you therefore, brethren, through the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living, holy, and well pleasing sacrifice to God, your reasonable service."***

The Greek verb translated "exhort" (παρακαλω) means to *call upon, entreat* and *beseech.* The Greek particle rendered "therefore" (εουν) indicates that as a consequence of their election Paul beseeches them to yield their bodies to the Lord.

Paul appeals to them "through the mercies of God" (δια των οικτιρμων). In Second Corinthians 1:3 God is called "the Father of mercies." According to Ephesians 2:4 the love of God results in the mercy of God, for Paul says, "But God being rich in mercy, on account of the magnitude of his love with which he loved us." God's magnanimous love expresses itself in mercy toward sinners. The concept of God sovereignly extending mercy to sinners is inextricably related to His electing and calling sinners unto salvation. The central subject of chapters 9-11 is that God "gives mercy to whom he wills" among sinners (9:15-16, 18, 23; 11:30-32). It is obvious, Paul's entreating them "through the mercies of God" refers back to God's mercy mentioned in the previous chapters.

Now that they are the recipients of God's mercy and have been made alive in Christ, Paul exhorts them, "Present your bodies a living, holy, and well-pleasing sacrifice to God." According to the Greek word order Paul is exhorting them to present their bodies a sacrifice which is living, holy, and well-pleasing. In contrast to the dead sacrifices made under the Law their bodies are to be living, throbbing with Divine life sacrifices. The Greek infinitive translated "present" (παραστνσαι) means that believers are to *place their bodies beside God, at His disposal,* or *make them available to Him.*

Whereas the sacrifices offered in conjunction with the Mosaic law were to be without physical blemish, believers are to present *holy bodies* unto God. The Greek word translated "holy" (αγιαν) basically conveys the thought of *separation*. God's elect, those whom He has chosen in Christ, who are identified with Christ, *possess absolute holiness* (Eph. 1:4). Because Christ possesses Divine life, the elect possess it (John 6:57). Because Christ possesses holiness, the elect possess it (1 Cor. 1:2, 30; 2 Cor. 5:21).

As we believers stand before God, who provided His Son for us on the Cross that He might be just and at the same time justify sinners, *He looks at us as perfectly holy in Christ*. This is our forensic standing before God. Because we are holy in Christ before God, because we are totally separated unto God in Christ, our lifestyle in the body should, likewise, be holy and separated unto God. What we are in Christ forensically should be duplicated in our everyday living. If our living bodies, which are to be placed at God's disposal, lack Spiritproduced holiness, then it follows that God cannot use them for His glory.

Not only are believers to present their bodies unto God as a living and holy sacrifice, but also as a well-pleasing-to-God sacrifice. The Greek word translated "well-pleasing" (ευαρεστον) speaks of that which is *very delightful* and *very gratifying* to God, hence, that which is *highly acceptable* to Him. Basically, pleasing God entails *doing* what He tells us to do. As members of the Body of Christ, the Church, God has given to us some very specific instructions in the New Testament epistles written to and for the churches. If we are going to be a living, holy, and well-pleasing sacrifice, usable for His glory, we must diligently study these epistles and let them govern our thinking and acting (Phil. 4:9; 2 Tim. 2:2).

For believers to present their bodies to God as a living, holy, and well-pleasing sacrifice is their "reasonable service." The Greek phrase translated "reasonable service" (λογικην λατρειαν) means logical or rational service. The Greek word rendered "service" (λατρειαν) probably implies religious service or worship. Offering one's body to God in the above manner is reasonable service and worship.

2. ***"And do not be conformed to this age, but be transformed by the renewing of the mind, that you may prove what is the will of God, that is good and well-pleasing and perfect."***

The first clause in this verse explains what their relation to this present evil age is *not to be* (Gal. 1:4). They are not to be "conformed" (συσχηματιζεσθε), *fashioned*, and *shaped* by it and in accordance with it. The noun translated "age" (αιωνι) most literally speaks of a *period of time, an era*, hence, is most accurately rendered *age*. In Second Corinthians 4:4 Paul says that Satan is "the god of this age" (cf. Luke 4:5-6). Since "the whole world lies in the evil one" (1 John 5:19), believers are not to be formed, shaped, and molded according to it. During this present evil age, and the changing times it includes, believers are to *withstand* Satan's diverse schemes designed to entrap them into conforming to his immoral system.

Instead of believers fashioning their lives according to Satan's diabolical lifestyle, Paul says, "But be transformed by the renewing of the mind." To emphasize the *contrast* between what believers are *not to do* and what they *are to do* he uses the strong adversative "αλλα," which in English means an *emphatic but*, or that they are to do just the opposite. Instead of allowing their lives to be conformed to this Satan dominated age, they are to allow the Holy Spirit to transform them by the renewing of the mind.

The Greek verb translated "transformed" (μεταμορφουσθε) means to *change the form*, in this case, from what they were prior to being saved to a renewed spiritual mind-set. The Greek phrase translated "by the renewing of the mind" (τη ανακαινωσει του νοος) has the Greek article (του) before the noun "mind" (νοος), which specifically points to *the mind, the intellect*, as the part of believers which needs to be renewed. In as much as the Greek verb rendered "transformed" (μεταμορφουσθσ) is in the present tense, imperative mood, and passive voice, the implication is that believers are *commanded to continuously be*

submitted to God the Holy Spirit for this mind renewing and renovating to take place.

Since that which needs to be renewed is the mind, and it can only be renewed as the Truth for the Body of Christ, energized by the Holy Spirit, is fed into it, the conclusion is that for this renewing process to take place the mind must continually be bathed in the Church Truth in the New Testament. As believers we are impotent to effect this transformation ourselves, but are *commanded to meet the conditions* by which it can be effected, namely, by diligently endeavoring to understand the literal meaning of the Word of God for this present dispensation of Grace (Eph. 3:2; 2 Tim. 2:15). The core Truth which establishes is that proclaimed by Paul (16:25).

The spiritual transformation, the result of the renewing of the mind, is not an end in itself, according to what Paul says here. Rather, it was *unto the end* (εις το') that they might "prove what is the will of God that is good and well-pleasing and perfect." The Greek infinitive translated "prove" (δοκιμαζειν) suggests that with their renewed minds, through the process of testing, they will be able to *prove* and *discern* what is the will of God.

As we consider the will of God as it relates to that which is good, well-pleasing, and perfect, we need to keep in mind the background of the Roman believers to whom Paul is writing. Granting that the majority of them were Gentile converts, it follows that they were primarily saved out of heathenism and humanism. They did not have available the full orbit of Church Truth which we do today by which to determine God's will in the various phases of their lives. The principle Paul enunciates here would require them, to the extent that they have this and any other Church epistles available, to be thereby transformed by the renewing of their minds.

The key point Paul is dealing with here is how believers may know God's good, acceptable and perfect will. For them it involved bathing their minds in all the Truth regarding the Church available to them. For us it involves permeating our minds with all the Truth written in the New Testament for this present dispensation of Grace (Eph. 3:2; Phil. 4:8-9). As a result of saturating the mind, hence, renewing it in the Truth, believers are spiritually transformed. This equips them with the ability to determine, discern and prove what is God's "good" (αγαθον), *upright*, and *beneficent* will; to determine what is His "well-pleasing" (ευαρεστον), *delighting* and *acceptable* will; and to determine what is His "perfect" (τελεοιν), *flawless*, and *ultimate* will in every situation (cf. Eph. 5:17; Col. 1:9).

3. ***"For I say through the grace that was given to me to everyone being among you, not to think more highly than that which he ought to think, but to think unto the end to think soundly, as God has distributed to each one a measure of faith."***

In the previous chapter (11:20, 25) it is clear that some of the believers at Rome were conceited and high-minded. The main emphasis of this verse is that no one

should think more highly of himself than he ought. Paul took a hard line against puffed-up, haughty and arrogant believers (v. 16; 1 Tim. 6:17).

Paul opens this verse with the statement, "For I say through the grace that was given to me." He emphasizes the fact that what he is about to say is not his own opinion, but he is speaking as an apostle who has received grace from the Lord. In other words, he put the authority of his apostolic office behind what he is going to say. This suggests that he considered it a serious matter which needed to be backed up by Divine authority (1 Cor. 9:1; 2 Cor. 12:12; Gal. 1:1).

He addresses what he is saying "to everyone being among you." This is not necessarily to be interpreted to mean that everyone among them was assuming a haughty attitude, but they all needed to know God's standard on this issue, that He condemned all haughtiness and arrogance.

Paul tells them that one is "not to think more highly than that which he ought to think." The Greek infinitive translated "to think more highly" (υπερφρονειν) means that one is not to harbor super-thoughts about himself. Since this verb is followed by the preposition "παρα," it conveys the thought that they are not to have *super-thoughts* which are beyond what one "ought" (δει) or that it is *necessary* to think. The Greek word translated "ought" (δει) suggests that each one should properly evaluate his ability and gifts, not demeaning nor exalting himself.

Instead of thinking about themselves in an inflated manner, Paul says, "but [αλλα] think unto the end to think soundly." This means that each one is to have a *sound, sane* and *correct* mind-set regarding himself.

We note that our thinking soundly is qualified by the statement, "as God has distributed to each one a measure of faith." It is difficult to ascertain exactly what Paul means by the phrase "α measure of faith" (μετρον πιστεως). Perhaps it should be translated a measure of faithfulness.

4. ***"For even as we have many members in one body, and all the members do not have the same function,"***

The casual reader may feel that with this verse Paul is changing the subject, but not so; he is only beginning to set forth foundational truth essential for maintaining the unity of the Spirit. A proper understanding of how the Body of Christ should function is his answer to the high-mindedness and conceit which were breeding disunity in the previous verse.

In order to illustrate how the Body of Christ should harmoniously operate in unison, Paul uses the physical body as an example. He says that "even as we have many members in one body, and all the members do not have the same function," in the same manner we believers constitute one body in Christ. First, the physical body has many members, such as the head, eyes, nose, ears, arms, hands, torso, legs and feet. Second, these members do not have the same function but each member its own specific function.

Now let us look at these members and their interrelationship and interdependence. Through the eyes the body is able to visually maneuver in its

physical environment. Through the nose the body is able to detect aromas, odors, and scents which enable it to more meaningfully relate to its environment. Through the ears the body is able to audibly relate and communicate in the sphere of its environment. Through the use of the arms, hands, legs and feet the body has the ability to be dexterous and mobile. If any one of these members does not properly function in the physical body, the whole body suffers. If friction develops between any two members of a body, both members suffer as well as the entire body.

5. ***"so we, the many, are one body in Christ, and individually members of one another."***

The Greek word translated "so" (ουτως) means that as it is with the physical body, *thus, in the same manner*, it is with the Body of Christ. We believers, who are referred to as "the many" (οι πολλοι), constitute one body in Christ. Even as the individual members in the physical body synchronously work together to fulfill their specific functions, likewise, the individual members in the Body of Christ should harmoniously work together to fulfill their specific gifts for the good of the entire Body (1 Cor. 12:4-9).

The phrase translated "individually members of one another" (εις αλληλων μελη) may also be rendered "and accordingly each one members of one another." This statement depicts each person in the Body of Christ as involved in a reciprocal relationship with the other members. The language used portrays each one supplementing the needs of others as the Body functions as a whole. Each member in the Body is responsible for the spiritual welfare of other members in the orbit in which he moves, i.e., those with whom he has contact.

6. ***"And having gifts differing according to the grace which was given to us, whether prophecy according to the proportion of the faith;"***

The nominative participle translated "having" (εχοντες) indicates that all believers are given "gifts" (χαρισματα), *special abilities*, and *endowments*. These gifts differ (διαφορα) and vary from one another, i.e., that they may fulfill different needs in the Body of Christ. This difference in gifts is "according to the grace which was given" to members of the Body of Christ. The Greek verb translated "was given" (δοθεισαν) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that these gifts were given at a specific time in the past by God the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 12:4-11). This statement clearly indicates that God is the one who both determines and dispenses these gifts to individual believers as it pleases Him.

Paul Now proceeds to delineate seven of these gifts. First, he says, "Whether prophecy according to the proportion of the faith." The gift of prophecy was a very important gift in the early churches. As we examine its use in First Corinthians chapter fourteen, it primarily related to *teaching* the Word of God in the local assemblies (vv. 1-5, 24, 39). Through the gift of prophecy, men were enabled, by the Holy Spirit, to remember and recall the Truth of the Mystery proclaimed by the Apostle Paul (16:25-26; Eph. 3:5). It is reasonable to think that

this gift existed as long as it was necessary, namely, until the Truth for the local assemblies was available in written form (1 Cor. 13:8).

The fact that the gift of prophecy was to be exercised "according to the proportion of the faith" gives us further insight into the nature of this gift. The Greek word translated "proportion" (αναλογιαν) conveys the idea of *analogy* or that which *conforms to* or *is like*. The Greek phrase translated "the faith" (της πιστεως) refers to the *body of Truth* which is to be believed, the Truth of the Mystery, the Gospel of God's Grace revealed for the Church. The message of the New Testament prophet was to be analogous and like *the faith*, the Truth of the Mystery, which was revealed to the Apostle Paul and preached by him (16:25; Eph. 3:2-9; Col. 1:25-26). To speculate that the gift of prophecy was not analogous to Paul's Gospel is refuted by Paul himself, for he says in Galatians 1:8, "If we or an angel out of heaven preaches beyond that which we preached to you, let him be anathema."

7. ***"whether ministry, in the ministry; or the one teaching, in the teaching;"***

As Paul delineates these gifts he emphasizes the fact that those to whom they have been given should faithfully exercise them. If one has the gift of "ministry" (διακονιαν) and *serving* in making the Gospel of God's Grace known, he should be fully engrossed in the ministry and service given unto him (1 Cor. 12:5). The Greek word translated "ministry" (διακονια) is used in the New Testament to cover a broad gamut of services. It is used to describe the work of God (13:4), of Christ (13:15), of Phoebe (16:1), Paul and Apollos (1 Cor. 3:5), Tychicus (Eph. 6:21), Epaphras (Col. 1:7), and Timothy (2 Tim. 4:5).

The one who has the gift of "teaching" (διδασκων) and *instructing* should exercise the gift to the utmost. This involves *accurately teaching* God's Word given for the edification of the Body of Christ. It entails *effectively communicating* this message so that it captivates the interest and is understood by the hearers. The ultimate object of one who has the gift of teaching should be to *persuade* his audience, in the dynamic of the Holy Spirit, to accept and do what the Word of God says (Acts 13:43; 18:4; 19:8).

It appears to us that the gift of teaching, if not the most important gift, is one of the most important gifts. It is the primary gift God has ordained for communicating His word to His people. The purpose of the gift of teaching is to pass on to our hearers, in language which they can understand, God's Word for this present dispensation of Grace (Eph. 3:2). Jesus was primarily a teacher (Luke 4:15), Paul was primarily a teacher (1 Tim. 2:7), and Timothy was to major in teaching (1 Tim. 6:2).

8. ***"or the one exhorting, in the exhortation; the one giving, with liberality; the one ruling, with diligence; the one showing mercy, with cheerfulness."***

This verse concludes the list of the seven gifts which Paul mentions. The last five of these gifts are couched in nominative participles, which for example, we have translated "the one exhorting" (ο παρακαλων). This compound participle literally

speaks of the one called beside, hence the one *comforting, encouraging* and *exhorting* another person. In actual usage we see the basic meaning of this word that of exhorting via the Word, which results in giving encouragement and comfort (1 Thess. 4:18; Titus 1:9; 13:22).

The one who has the gift of exhorting is to enthusiastically and intelligently give himself to this ministry. In our judgment, unless the gift of exhortation is based upon the literal meaning and authority of the Word of God, it will be ineffectual (Acts 15:32; 20:2). While the key role of the teacher is to *dispense information*, the key role of the exhorter is to *appeal for obedience* to the Word. We must recognize that there will be a certain amount of overlapping of certain gifts, particularly, between the teacher and exhorter (1 Tim. 6:2; Titus 1:9).

Now let us consider the person who has the gift of "giving" (μεταδιδους). This compound Greek word means to *give part, to share,* and *to distribute.* This word is used in four other passages in the New Testament, and in each case it conveys the idea of sharing or giving such as a garment (Luke 3:11), a gift (Rom. 1:11), money (Eph. 4:28), and the gospel (1 Thess. 2:8).

The one who has the gift of giving is to carry it out with "liberality" (απλοτητι). The Greek word rendered "liberality" (απλοτητι) basically means that the one who has this gift is to share with *simplicity, singleness* and *sincerity.* In addition to this verse, three other times this word is used in the New Testament with the sense of *liberality* and *generosity* (2 Cor. 8:2; 9:11, 13). This gift would imply that God gives the ability to *accrue something to give* as well as *giving it in the right spirit* in singleness of mind and ungrudgingly. When we recognize that giving and sharing money and physical possessions with others is a spiritual gift, and as such has a significant bearing on our own spiritual relation to the Lord, then giving toward the ongoing of the Gospel can become a joyful experience.

As Paul continues to delineate the gifts, he refers to the one "ruling" (προισταμενος). This compound Greek word translated "ruling" basically means *to set before* or in a *prior position*, hence, *one who governs or presides over*. Out of the eight times this word is used in the New Testament, six times it has the idea of ruling or governing and twice of maintaining good works (1 Thess. 5:12; 1 Tim. 3:4; 5:17).

The person who has the gift of ruling and governing is to do it with "diligence" (σπουδη). This Greek word means that the one ruling is to do it with *readiness, zeal* and *earnestness*; i.e., he is to take great pains to do the best possible job. Since this word has quite a wide gamut of meanings, we prefer the thought that the one ruling should do it with *zealous-diligence.*

Finally, the one showing mercy should do it with *cheerfulness*. The Greek word translated "showing mercy" (ελεων) depicts one who manifests *pity and compassion* on the less fortunate, those often overlooked. Paul uses this word twelve times in his epistles, eleven times with reference to God showing mercy, and only here with reference to man being given the gift of showing mercy.

The person who is given the gift of mercy is to exercise it with cheerfulness. The Greek word rendered "cheerfulness" (ιλαροτητι) has the thought of *joyful* and *happy*. The cheerful and joyful person is the most effective conveyer of mercy (cf. Matt. 5:7).

9. ***"Let love be without hypocrisy. Abhor the evil, be glued to the good;"***

In this paragraph Paul delineates a series of random things for believers to do. First, they are to "let love be without hypocrisy." The Greek word translated "hypocrisy" (ανυποκριτος) means that love is *not to be feigned,* but *genuine* and *real*. In writing to the Corinthians, Paul says that his lifestyle was characterized by unhypocritical love (2 Cor. 6:6). Peter also desires believers to mature unto the end of unhypocritical brotherly love (1 Peter 1:22).

Second, believers are to "abhor the evil." The Greek participle translated "abhor" (αποστυγουντες) is in the present tense and means that we are to continuously *hate evil* and *shrink back from it.* The compound participle implies that we are to hate, detest and abhor evil and be separated from it.

Third, believers are to be "glued to the good." The Greek participle rendered "glued" (κολλωμενοι) means that they are to be *welded together, adhered to,* and *attached to* that which is good. The Greek noun translated "good" (αγαθω) means that they are to be joined to that which is upright, virtuous and morally beneficial.

10. ***"be lovingly affectionate in brotherly love unto one another, be leading before in honor one another,"***

The Greek word translated "lovingly affectionate" (φιλοστοργοι) is derived from the words "φιλος" and "στοργη," which respectively mean *love* and *natural affection*. Since this is a compound participle with a very strong emphasis on love and affection, we have concluded that the best translation is *lovingly affectionate*. This is the only time this word is used in the New Testament so we have no precedent in meaning on the basis of usage.

Fourth, believers are to be "lovingly affectionate in brotherly love unto one another." One might think that it would have been enough for Paul to tell them to have brotherly love, a love for the brethren, unto one another, but it wasn't. He emphasizes that he wants them to have something more than just brotherly love. He desires for them a *lovingly-affectionate brotherly love*. This would be a feeling of warm affection, the natural result when believers are flowing with the Spirit.

Fifth, believers are to be "leading before in honor one another." The participle translated "leading before" (προηγουμενοι) is a compound Greek word which basically means *to be leading before, to be leading prior*; hence, it can be thought of as a *prior leader* in time and a *before leader* in position. In this verse Paul is giving this participle a metaphorical meaning; i.e., believers are to look at other believers as leading before them, preceding them, or as having a preferred position in honor.

The meaning of this verse becomes clearer when we realize that the Greek word translated "honor" (τιμη) has the idea of *price, value* and *worth*. What Paul is saying here is that as a believer I am to look at other believers as leading before me, preceding me, and as having *preferred value* and *worth* beyond myself. We must keep in mind that all believers are bought with the price of Christ's Blood, and as such are very valuable, and from our point of view others are more valuable than us (1 Cor. 6:20; Eph. 1:18).

11. ***"not slothful in diligence, fervent in the Spirit, serving the Lord,"***

As Paul continues to stimulate believers to live for Jesus Christ, he says that they are not to be "slothful in diligence." The Greek noun translated "diligence" (σπουδη) has the basic idea of haste, but is primarily used by Paul with the idea of *diligence, earnestness* and *seriousness.* His main point is that they are not to be "slothful" (οκνηροι), i.e., *slow, idle* and *indolent* in diligently and earnestly living for Christ. Paul desired that the Hebrew believers might be *diligent* in having a fully assured hope (Heb. 6:11).

Next, Paul instructs them to be "fervent in the Spirit." This may be interpreted to mean that believers are to be *fervent in their human spirits,* or that they are to be fervent in the Spirit. The fact that the Greek word translated "Spirit" (πνευματο) has the article preceding it favors the idea that this refers to the Holy Spirit. Furthermore, since the Greek word for *spirit* (πνευμα) is never capitalized, the correct rendering depends upon the translator's interpretation. Also, since many translators tend to copy previous translations, and do not deviate unless dictated by their preferences, the number of translations with a given rendering is relatively insignificant.

The Greek participle translated "fervent" (ζεοντες) is in the present tense, and means that believers are to *continually be boiling, hot* and *zealous* in the Spirit. Believers who are boiling in the Divine heat of the Holy Spirit, as a consequence, will be fervent in their human spirits. A boiling and fervent human spirit, apart from the Holy Spirit, is merely a display of humanistically generated emotionalism. Paul makes it very clear, the lifestyle of believers is motivated, energized, and dynamatized by the Spirit of God (8:11-14; 15:13; 1 Cor. 2:4; Gal. 5:16, 18, 22-23). Summarizing, boiling in the Holy Spirit is an absolute prerequisite to boiling in our human spirits.

Finally, in this verse Paul instructs them to be "serving the Lord." The Greek participle translated "serving" (δουλευοντες) means that they are to *continually render service to the Lord* even as a slave subserviently serves his master. Looking at this verse as a whole, believers are not to be slothful in diligence but fervent in the Spirit, and as such, continuously rendering service to Jesus Christ.

12. ***"rejoicing in the hope, enduring in affliction, persevering in prayer,"***

Since the Greek noun translated "hope" (ελπιδι) has the article preceding it, we have rendered it *the hope* (τη ελπιδι), *the expectation,* or *that which is anticipated.* The present Greek participle translated "rejoicing" (χαιροντες) means that believers are to be *joyfully* and *happily* looking forward to the hope of

being glorified together with Christ (8:30; Col. 1:27). In Titus 2:13, Paul speaks of this as the "blessed hope" which has the idea of *the happy hope*.

While believers are rejoicing in the hope of glory with Christ, they are to be "enduring in affliction." The Greek participle translated "persevering" (προσκαρτερουντες), as used in this verse, means *to persist, continue* and *be engaged in prayer.* Paul uses this word only three times in his epistles, twice with reference to prayer and once with reference to rulers persisting in the collection of taxes (13:6).

A slavishly literal interpretation of the Greek word rendered "persevering" (προσκαρτερουντες) could lead one to the conclusion that he should spend most or all of his time in prayer. Paul uses the verb form of the same word in Colossians 4:2, where he commands believers to "persevere in prayer." He speaks commendably of true widows who "continue in supplications and prayers night and day." Also, in First Thessalonians 5:17, Paul says, "Pray unceasingly." These and other like verses, if misunderstood, could conceivably result in an imbalance between prayer and the study of the Word.

We need to grasp Paul's total perspective on the issue of prayer. First, he uses the most common noun for prayer (προσευχη) in the *plural number.* This means that he did not have a continuous, set-apart, and isolated prayer time, but that he prayed at given *intervals* according to the circumstances and needs (1:10; Phil. 1:9; 4:6). Second, he profoundly believed that in-the-Spirit prayer is effectual (8:26; Col. 1:3, 9; 4:3), but he never suggests that prayers are to be long, babbling, or repetitious (cf. Matt. 6:7). Third, in view of what Paul says and does, it appears that he knew the secret of *simultaneously praying and working*, of communing with God while he served Him (1 Thess. 5:17; 2 Thess. 1:11).

13. ***"communicating to the needs of the saints, pursuing hospitality."***

The Greek participle translated "communicating" (κοινωνουντες) basically means *sharing what we have with other believers*. It may also be rendered *contributing* or *distributing*. The phrase, the "needs of the saints," as used by Paul, refers to the bare necessities for sustaining life, such as food, clothing and shelter (1 Tim. 6:8). In sharing with others we must keep in mind that there is a distinct difference between actual needs and wants, and that the practicality of the latter may vary under different circumstances (Phil. 4:11-13).

As we interpret passages such as this, we need to consider the extent to which different civil governments become involved in the welfare of their citizens. When Paul wrote this epistle the Jewish custom of providing for the poor was also being practiced by the churches (Gal. 2:10; Rom. 15:26). This was a very important sphere in which they could express the spiritual gift of sharing. Under a welfare oriented government, where taxes are levied for this purpose, both the ability and necessity to exercise the gift of sharing is limited. This has its pros and cons, limiting the burden on churches but also limiting the exercise of the gift of giving (1 Tim. 5:16).

Also, believers are to be aggressively "pursuing hospitality." The Greek noun translated "hospitality" is derived from "φιλος" and "ξενος" and basically means to *love, be kind,* and *friendly toward strangers*. The participle rendered "pursuing" means to *chase after* or *endeavor to acquire*. If we are going to effectively do the work of evangelists, we must be friendly and hospitable to strangers. This is one of the requisites for overseers (1 Tim. 3:2) and for elders (Titus 1:8). Hebrews 13:2 says, "Do not forget the love of strangers," i.e., hospitality.

14. ***"Bless those persecuting you; bless and do not curse."***

The United Bible Societies Greek text does not have the pronoun *you* following the word *persecuting* whereas the Majority Text does. The thought-flow obviously necessitates it; therefore, we have included it in our translation.

The Greek verb translated "bless" (ευλοογειτε) is derived from the adverb "ευ" prefixed to the verb "λογεω" and basically means *to speak well or good* of someone. The Greek phrase translated "those persecuting" (τους διωκονας) refers to those who are *chasing, pursuing* and *endeavoring to apprehend* believers that they may evilly inflict them. This is a terse statement in which Paul sets forth a *general principle* telling us how we are to deal with our would-be persecutors. The basic thought is that we are not to respond to evil with evil; i.e., we are not to fight evil with evil, but our response to evil is to be with good.

The second part of this verse clarifies Paul's intended meaning. Believers are to "bless and do not curse." The world's method of dealing with evil persecutors is to "curse" (καταρασθε), *invoke a calamity upon,* or *to express an imprecation against.* As believers we are not to use the world's method, in fact, the very opposite. Instead of cursing we are to bless, to speak well of our persecutors.

Lest we misinterpret this verse, let us briefly examine what Paul did when he was persecuted even unto death. When he and Barnabas were illegally incarcerated at Philippi and then about to be secretly released, he maintained his rights as a Roman citizen (Acts 16:37). When the Jews began to resist the Gospel at Corinth, he said, "Your blood be upon your head" (Acts 18:6). When Paul had the opportunity to speak to his would-be murderers from the castle steps in Jerusalem, he recounts how the Lord had saved him and given him a ministry (Acts 21:1-21). As he defended himself before the Sanhedrin, and Ananias the high priest ordered him to be struck on the mouth, he responded by saying: "God will strike you, you white-washed wall" (Acts 23:3).

We have no instances in which Paul actually blessed or spoke well of those who persecuted him because of his stand for the Gospel. To have done so would have encouraged them in their evil. Neither did he curse anyone for persecuting him. He did, however, voice a curse against those who were perverting the Gospel by adding the works of the Law to it (Gal. 1:8).

15. ***"Rejoice with those rejoicing, weep with those weeping."***

The emphasis of this verse is that believers are to empathically identify with the feelings of fellow body members. Each one is to "rejoice" (χαιρειν), *be joyful and happy* with those who are rejoicing and joyful.

Each one is to "weep" (κλαιειν), *mourn*, and *lament* with those who are weeping and lamenting. The thought here is that believers are to sympathetically enter into the sorrowful feeling of others. In Philippians 2:17, Paul says, "I rejoice and I rejoice with all of you."

The extent to which a believer is able to enter into the feelings and moods of others will determine his emotional identification with them. The mutual sharing in the joys of others constitutes a bridge over which we can pass to help them. The mutual weeping with others, feeling the pain and grief they are experiencing, is a prerequisite to being a sympathetic comforter. Members of the Body of Christ need to develop this empathic ability if they are going to have an effective caring ministry for one another (1 Cor. 12:24-26).

16. ***"Have the same thinking toward one another, not thinking on the high things, but going along with the lowly. Do not esteem yourselves as being wise."***

First, let us consider the statement, "Have the same thinking toward one another." The Greek participle translated "thinking" (φρονουντες) is the *resultant of the brain in operation*. The brain is to be actively engaged in thinking the same thing regarding one another. The plural participle indicates that all believers are to esteem one another reciprocally as equal in value, worth and importance before God. Paul leaves no room for one believer to think that he is superior to another (Eph. 4:2; Phil. 2:2-8).

Second, Paul affirms that believers are not to be "thinking on high things." In this phrase he uses the same plural participle but in a negative context; i.e., believers are *not* to be thinking on "high things" (τα υψηλα), *lofty*, and *elevated* things. It appears that Paul does not want them to assume an air of superiority, arrogance, and haughtiness. This same word (ευψηλα) is used in the eleventh chapter, where he says, "Do not be haughty in thinking, but fear" (v. 20).

Third, in contrast to assuming a haughty and conceited mind-set, Paul says "but" (αλλα) be "going along with the lowly." The Greek participle translated "going along with" (συναπαγομενοι) is a combination of three words, and it literally means to *lead-away-with* or *to go along with.* Instead of becoming engulfed in their own self-importance, Paul instructs them to lead-away-with or to go along with those who are lowly, poor and depressed. Even as Barnabas was led away by those who came from James at Jerusalem to Antioch (Gal. 2:13), believers are to go along with the low and humble members in the Body of Christ.

Fourth, Paul tells them, "Do not esteem yourselves as being wise." Following the word order in the Greek, Paul is literally saying, "Do not be wise beside (beyond) yourselves." The thought is that they are not to consider themselves wiser, smarter, and more intelligent than they actually are. Their self-appraisal is not to exceed or go beyond their real ability. In the preceding chapter Paul sees this false estimate of their ability resulting from their ignorance of the mystery, that partial hardness now blinds Israel (11:25).

17. ***"Repaying evil for evil to no one; providing what is good in the sight of all men."***

The Greek participle translated "repaying" (αποδιδοντες) means *to give in return, to recompense* or *to render back.* The point Paul is making here is that when believers are treated evilly, they are not to react by returning evil. According to the standards of this Satan-dominated world, evil treatment is the proper repayment for the application of evil treatment. Our entire penal system is based on this premise; it does not have adequate provision for meaningful restitution to those who have been evilly treated nor a provision to cover prosecuting costs. Thus far in this context Paul has been speaking about interrelations between believers, which is confirmed by the use of the reciprocal pronoun "αλληλους" three times (vv. 10, 16). Believers are not to repay one another with evil; i.e., they are not to use that which is evil to fight evil.

Positively speaking, believers are to be "providing what is good in the sight of all men." At this point in the context Paul appears to be extending the principle of *providing what is good* to include all men. The Greek participle translated "providing" literally means *taking previous thought* for good to believers as well as to unbelievers. What is "good" (καλα), *right*, and *profitable* would depend upon the circumstances and need.

18. ***"If possible, to the extent that you can, be at peace with all men."***

In the preceding verse Paul emphasized the need for believers to give prior thought to that which is good in the sight of all men. As believers we determine what is good for both ourselves and unbelievers on the basis of the Word of God given to this Church age. In operating on the basis of God's standard for this present dispensation of Grace, our evaluation of what is good for unbelievers will often be diametrically opposed to what they conceive as good (1 Peter 4:4). This means that moral, educational, and political clashes are inevitable.

The Apostle Paul, as a Jew, was certainly aware of the clashes over ideals between the Jews and Gentiles. Also, as α Christian, he was constantly at odds with the Judaizers who were seeking to superimpose the Law on the Gospel of the Grace of God. On the one hand, he unswervingly held to that I which was good according to the Gospel, and he endeavored to do good unto all men according to this standard, even though most were living according to the base standard of the lusts of their flesh (Eph. 2:1-3). On the other hand, in spite of the conflict between the Truth and error, between Christian morality and heathen immorality, Paul tried to live at peace with all men. Where possible he avoided head-on clashes by *circumventing* the empty arguments of humanists (2 Tim. 2:16). He *stood aloof from* and *avoided* unprofitable fightings about the Law and genealogies (Titus 3:9). If a heretic refused to be corrected, he begged off from him, i.e., excused himself.

Having considered the problem of standing for the Truth of the Gospel and at the same time being at peace with all men, Now let us exegete more carefully what Paul says in this verse. Paul does not tell believers to live at peace with all men, but rather, "If possible" (ει δυνατον), *if you are able, if it is capable of being done*,

then do it. The Greek phrase translated "to the extent that you can" (το εξ υμων) may be very literally rendered *as much as is out of you*. Even though the meaning of this phrase is difficult to tersely express in English, the meaning is very clear, to the extent that believers are the *source of peace*, are in control of making peace, and have it in their power to maintain peace, they should do so. In this Satan dominated world (2 Cor. 4:4) it is often difficult to be faithful to the Truth and simultaneously be at peace with all men (Matt. 10:34).

19. ***"Beloved, do not avenge yourselves, but give place to the wrath, for it has been written,* Vengeance is mine, I will repay, says the Lord."**

The fact that Paul addresses them as "beloved" (αγαπητοι), a name expressing endearment, suggests that some of them may have been too aggressive in avenging themselves. The Greek phrase translated "do not avenge yourselves" (μη εαυτους εκδικουντες) means that they should not be taking in their own hands the execution of justice by becoming their own vindicators, and meting out retributive punishment.

Instead of believers avenging themselves, feeling that they have to punish those who have punished them, Paul says, "Give place to the wrath." Since the Greek phrase translated "the wrath" (τη οργη) has the article, we interpret it as referring to *the wrath of God* (Rom. 1:18; Eph. 5:6; 1 Thess. 1:10). When God judges the unbelievers according to their works, they will receive the vengeance and punishment due them. Believers must realize that God will perfectly equate all accounts in the day He pours out His wrath (Eph. 5:6).

The reason Paul tells believers to give place to wrath is because it has been written that the Lord has said: "Vengeance is mine, I will repay." This same passage is also quoted in Hebrews 10:30. In conclusion, if vengeance belongs to God, believers have no right to assume this role. Only God, who has all the facts at His disposal, is able to execute just vengeance.

20. **"But if your enemy might hunger, feed him, if he might thirst, give him a drink; for doing this you will heap coals of fire upon his head."**

This verse is an exact quotation of Proverbs 25:21-22, with the exception of the last line. Instead of avenging their enemy, they are to do that which is good toward him, namely, to satiate his hunger and quench his thirst. As a result of doing this good to an enemy, one heaps coals of fire upon his head. The intended meaning of the coals of fire upon the head is ambiguous; however, the next verse suggests that it signifies that by doing good victory can be accomplished. If an enemy cannot stand the heat produced by good doing, the result is that good begins to conquer evil. Paul's main point here is that when we leave vengeance to God and make provision to do good unto all men, we will see victory over evil.

21. ***"Do not be overcome by the evil, but overcome the evil by means of the good."***

The Greek verb translated do not "be overcome" (νικω) may also be rendered do not *be conquered* or *subdued* by the evil. Since this verb is in the passive voice and the noun "evil" (κακου) has the article preceding it, we can equally well

translate it *the evil one*, namely, Satan. The use of the passive voice requires that we either look at *the evil as personified* or *as the evil one*. We are either liable to be conquered by the evil inflicting us, or by the evil one inflicting us. In the final analysis the promulgator of evil and the evil itself merge into one, and believers are not to be overcome and conquered by Satan or the evil he produces (Eph. 4:27; 6:11; James 4:7; 1 Peter 5:8; 1 John 3:8).

To contrast what believers should do, Paul uses the strong adversative when he says, "but [αλλα] overcome the evil by means of the good." Observe, the force which is able to conquer the evil is the good. Again, the article which precedes the Greek word for good is very important. Paul is speaking about "the good" (τω αηαθω) set forth in the Word of God for this Church age. In reality, *the good is the word of God,* and it is by this that we are to overcome and conquer the evil. The Word of God, the essence and standard of the good, has latent in it the power to conquer all evil. According to Ephesians 6:17, the Word of God is the sword of the Spirit. According to Hebrews 4:12-13, the Word of God is far sharper than every double-cutting sword. Jesus used the Word of God to refute Satan in the arena of temptation (Luke 4:1-13).

Chapter 13

1. ***"Let every person be subject to higher authorities. For there is no authority except under God, and those being have been arranged under God."***

The first part of this chapter deals with the believer's relationship to civil authorities. As we endeavor to understand what Paul says here, we must keep in mind that he was living under a totalitarian form of government, and obviously what he says to those under this government must be interpreted in the light of its form. If he had been writing to believers under a democratic or republican form of government, where they had the power to change laws and leadership, Paul may have told them to exercise their franchise in favor of greater liberty to preach the Gospel.

Recognizing that the Apostle Paul was writing this epistle to believers in Rome living under a totalitarian government, and that he wanted them to avoid, as far as possible, conflicts with the government, we will cautiously apply what he says here to our own form of government. Furthermore, since the enemies of Christianity often unscrupulously accused early believers of treason, Paul is advising them to go an extra mile in their submission to the authorities over them (cf. Acts 17:7).

First, Paul tells the Roman believers to "Let every person be subject to higher authorities." The Greek verb translated "let be subject" (υποτασσεσθω) is in the imperative mood and middle voice, which means that Paul is *commanding* them to *subject themselves, to subordinate themselves,* and *to arrange themselves under* the authorities ruling over them. The Greek phrase translated "higher authorities" (εξουσιαις υπερεχουσαις) may also be rendered *powers holding above them* or *rulers above them.* Summarizing, every believer is to arrange himself under the civil authorities who are above him.

Second, Paul informs them that "there is no authority except under God." Many translations convey the thought that there is no authority except *of* or *from* God. The issue at stake is the Greek preposition "υπο" which basically means *under* as the following citations indicate. Romans 6:14 says, "you are not under (υπο) law but under grace." First Corinthians 15:25 says, "For it is necessary for him to reign until when he may place all the enemies under (υπο) his feet." Ephesians 1:22 says, "and all things he subjected under (υπο) his feet." Summarizing, this verse is not saying that the civil authorities of Paul's day were from or of God, but that they occupied a position *under God*, i.e., underneath Him.

Third, in speaking of authorities, Paul says, "and those being (existing) have been arranged under God." As Paul scanned the authorities on the Roman horizon, he says that those being, existing, and who are presently ruling have been arranged under God. The Greek proposition "under" (υπο) denotes the *rank* of these authorities, and not the source or origin of their power and authority.

Summarizing, if all the authorities in this world were assembled together, Paul affirms, *they would all be under God*.

2. ***"So then the one resisting the authority has resisted the arrangement of God, and those having resisted will receive to themselves judgment."***

The Greek conjunction translated "so then" (ωστε), when looked at as a particle, may also be rendered with the idea of *consequently* or *therefore*. The phrase "the one resisting" (ο αντιτασσομενος) speaks of *one who arranges himself in opposition* or *who is averse* to the authority.

Now let us consider the statement that "the one resisting the authority has resisted the arrangement of God." The verb translated "has resisted" (ανθεστηκεν) is in the perfect tense and means that *he has stood against and opposed* "the arrangement of God" (τη του θεου διαταγη), i.e., *God's injunction and order*. God's arrangement and injunction is for the authorities to be under Him, but, if one opposes those authorities, he is thereby making himself superior to them; hence, he has resisted God's arrangement.

Paul warns believers that "those having resisted will receive to themselves judgment." The people resisting God's order of authority, not only resist God, but also will receive judgment against themselves from the authorities. Summarizing, the two reasons for subjection to civil authorities are: 1) they are *under God* in the chain of command, and 2) they hold the fear of *judgment* over the people.

3. ***"For the rulers do not cause fear for good work but for evil. And do you want to not fear the authority? Do what is good, and you will have praise from it."***

As a consequence of what Paul had said in the previous two verses, he explains that the person doing that which is good does not fear judgment, but the person doing what is evil has reason to fear judgment. The principle is very simple, if one does not want to fear judgment from the authority, let him do what is good, i.e., let him be in subjection. On the other hand, if one wants the commendation of the authority, let him do that which is good. Summarizing, unsubjection results in fear of judgment, while subjection results in praise.

First Peter 2:13-14 affirms the same truth as this verse. "Be arranged under every human injunction because of the Lord; whether to a king as supreme, whether to governors as sent through him to avenge evil-doers and praise good--doers."

4. ***"For he is a minister of God to you for good. But if you do evil, fear; for he does not bear the sword in vain; for he is a minister of God, an avenger unto wrath to the one practicing evil."***

As Paul writes this epistle to the believers at Rome, the majority of them were probably a part of the original Roman Empire which had subdued the surrounding nations. Many of them undoubtedly considered themselves part of a victorious empire rather than captives of that empire. Whatever the situation of the various individuals who constituted the church at Rome, one thing is certain,

the attitude of the Roman government toward Christians was going to deteriorate increasingly.

The Apostle Paul must have had mixed feelings about this government. His people, Israel, were captives under it, grating under its harsh policies and heavy taxation. On the other hand, when a number of Jews vowed to put him to death, the Roman government protected him, and Roman prisons became a place of refuge for him.

In this verse Paul speaks of civil authorities in *ideal terms*; i.e., ideally speaking they are ministers of God for the good of the citizens under them. Also, they are ministers of God to avenge with the sword those practicing evil which is harmful to the citizens under them. Under the circumstances, a frank treatise on the Roman government written by Paul could have possibly resulted in the annihilation of the Gospel of God's Grace. There is often a vast gap between what governments and the Word of God designate as good and evil, an issue on which Paul is silent for a good reason.

5. ***"Wherefore it is necessary to be arranged under, not only because of the wrath, but also because of the conscience."***

The Greek word translated "wherefore" (δια) means that *on account of* what Paul previously said it is "necessary" (αναγκη), *imperative*, and *essential* that believers be in subjection to the Roman government. They are to do this not only on account of "the wrath" (την οργην), *judgment and possible death*, but also because of "the conscience" (την συνειδησιν), that aspect of a believer which senses what is *right and wrong* primarily on the basis of what is fed into it. The dual implication is: 1) that the truth of the Gospel would form a conscience submissive to civil government; and 2) that insubordination could bring persecution on other believers.

6. ***"For on account of this also pay taxes, for they are ministers of God persisting unto this very thing."***

The two main things an ideal government does is: 1) to provide an environment in which its citizens can do that which is good; and 2) to protect its citizens against internal and external evil and harm. To do these two things, with the many aspects associated with them, requires money; therefore Paul says, "For on account of this also pay taxes."

The Greek word translated "taxes" (φορον) may also be rendered *tribute*. Strictly speaking, it is used with reference to the *load* subject and dependent people are required to bear (Luke 20:22; 23:2). Considering the way Herod spent money on both his personal and public projects, to mention only one of the Roman authorities, the tax burden must have been excruciating.

After having instructed believers to pay taxes to the authorities, Paul adds, "For they are ministers of God persisting unto this very thing." It appears to us that this statement may be interpreted as having a double emphasis. First, that the authorities are ministers of God to enhance the good and deter the evil. Second, that they are ministers of God unto the end of collecting taxes and tribute. In an

ideal government they continuously persist and persevere in doing both of these things, for they mutually depend upon and support one another.

7. ***"Render to all what is due, tribute to whom tribute, custom to whom custom, fear to whom fear, honor to whom honor."***

The Greek verb translated "render" (αποδοτε) is in the aorist tense and imperative mood, which means that Paul is strongly commanding them *to give what is owed, to discharge their obligations,* and to pay their debts to the respective authorities. They should pay their tribute and taxes to the one collecting them. They should pay custom and tariffs levied against goods. They should above all render fear to the Lord (Eph. 5:21; Col. 3:22) and to those in authority (v. 3). They should honor God (1 Tim. 1:17) and honor kings (1 Peter 2:17).

Again we emphasize, in the foregoing verses Paul is asking believers to be subject to *ideal authorities*, those praising good doing and judging evil doing. His purpose is to keep believers from being targeted for unnecessary persecution.

8. ***"Owe nothing to no one except to love one another; for the one loving another has fulfilled the Law."***

In the preceding verse Paul told the Roman believers to take care of all their obligations, i.e., to pay all their debts. He said this with respect to their relation to civil government authorities and taxes. In this verse he affirms again that they are not to owe anyone anything, but adds, "except to love one another." The reciprocal pronoun translated "one another" (αλληλους) means that I am to love you and you are to love me. Each one is to take the initiative in loving the other, i.e., in starting the love-ball rolling. Seven times Paul indicates that believers are to love one another reciprocally. Five times John uses this same reciprocal pronoun to indicate that believers are to love one another.

After telling them that they are to love one another, Paul adds, "For the one loving another has fulfilled the law." Paul makes a similar statement in Galatians 5:14, where he says, "For all the law has been fulfilled in one word, in that 'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.'" These statements must not be interpreted to mean that Paul felt that he was obligated to fulfill the Law, for he makes a big issue of the fact that we are *not under the Law*, but totally under Grace (6:14-15; 7:4-6). The reason he indicates that the person who loves has fulfilled the Law is to show that love is a basic *universal principle*, and if it had been exercised as it should have been it would have produced better human relations among the Jews than the Law even advocates.

9. ***"For this,* You shall not commit adultery, You shall not murder, You shall not steal, You shall not covet, *and if there is any other commandment, it is summed up in this word, namely,* You shall love your neighbor as yourself."**

Having affirmed that the one loving has fulfilled the Law, Paul Now clarifies what he means. The one loving will not commit adultery, for this is not an act of love. The one loving will not murder another person, for murder is an act of hate, not of

love. The person loving will not steal, an act condemned by the Word of God (1 Cor. 6:10; Eph. 4:28). The one loving will not "covet" (επιθυμησεις), lust and desire that which belongs to another (Exod. 20:17; Col. 3:5).

After citing four commandments from the Law of Moses, which love would have fulfilled apart from the Law, Paul adds, "and if there is any other commandment, it is summed up in this word, namely, You shall love your neighbor as yourself." Having used four commandments to exemplify how love fulfills the Law, Paul says that all the rest of the commandments are fulfilled in the same manner, by proper love toward one's "neighbor" (πλησιον), *one who is near*. As one loves his neighbor and is concerned for him even as he loves and is concerned for himself, love will propel him to fulfill the precepts of the Law toward his neighbor.

10. ***"Love does not work evil to a neighbor, therefore love is the fulfillment of the Law."***

Love can only produce that which is good; therefore, it cannot work that which is "evil" (κακον), *bad* or *harmful* to its neighbor. Since the Law, as given by God to fulfill a given purpose, was holy, just and good (7:12), it logically follows that love which works only good is the fulfillment of the Law. The Law was given to Israel as God's standard of good for them at that point in time. Due to the weakness of the flesh, it was not fulfilled during the 1400 years it was in effect. However, during this present age of Grace, when the Holy Spirit is producing the *fruit of love*, believers are enabled to fulfill the universal principles of the Law which are applicable to this church age.

Summarizing verses 8-10. The emphasis in this paragraph is on believers mutually and reciprocally loving one another. Even though the Mosaic Law was laid aside, annulled and abrogated some 27 years before the writing of this epistle, Paul still uses it in the background to show the superiority of love. He points out that the principle of love is a dynamic force capable of conforming the thoughts and actions of believers to the will of God. Actually, if Israel had been living in a proper love relationship with God and one another, there would have been no reason for God to give them the Law. Due to Israel's failure to walk in love, God gave them the Law, which failed to make them righteous due to the weakness of the flesh (8:3). Today, however, as believers are energized by the Spirit to love one another reciprocally, the universal principles common to the Law and Church are capable of being fulfilled.

11. ***"And this, knowing the time, that it is already the hour for you to be raised out of sleep, for now our salvation is nearer than when we believed."***

Paul Now begins to deal with the spiritual lethargy of the believers at Rome. With the phrase "And this" (και τουτο) he calls their attention to the lateness of the time. They need to be "knowing the time" (ειδοτες τον καιρον). They need to be *perceiving* and *seeing* "the time" (τον καιρον), *the particular time, the point in time* that is on God's prophetic time clock.

As Paul looks at the time, in the light of God's eternal purpose, he says "that it is already the hour for you to be raised out of sleep." It appears that he is telling

them the time is "already" (ηδη) past, *it has come and gone,* when you should have been raised out of "sleep" (υπωου). In plain language, Paul is prodding them, "You are late, be raised out of your spiritual sleep and slumber."

It is important to note that the Greek verb translated "be raised" (εγερθηναι) is in the aorist tense and passive voice. The aorist tense reinforces our point, that they should have already been raised before Paul wrote this epistle to them. But even more significant, the passive voice indicates that one other than themselves is involved in *raising, arousing,* and *awakening* them from their spiritual stupor. As those who are in a state of spiritual hibernation, someone has to arouse them, namely, *God the Holy Spirit*.

Those to whom Paul is writing are believers; they are spiritually alive in Christ, and as such, their spirits need to be stimulated and aroused by the Holy Spirit. Instead of being in a state of spiritual slothfulness, they need to be boiling in the Spirit, energized by the Holy Spirit (12:11).

As the minutes, hours and days become history, Paul says, "for Now our salvation is nearer than when we believed." In Ephesians 5:16, Paul says that we are to be "redeeming the time," *buying up every opportunity to serve the Lord,* because the days are evil. In this eleventh verse he is trying to arouse believers to serve the Lord because *time is fleeting*, the time when Christ will return for His own is coming nearer each day. Paul says that when we believed we began looking forward to the great event, *the day of our salvation.* This points to the time when believers will meet the Lord in the air, will have their lowly bodies changed to conform to His glorious body, and will always be with the Lord (1 Thess. 4:15-17; Phil. 3:21).

12. ***"The night is almost gone, and the day is near. Therefore we should lay aside the works of darkness, and we should put on the armor of light."***

In this verse Paul continues to emphasize the short time believers have to serve the Lord. He graphically portrays this by saying that "The night is almost gone." Paul is apparently using the Greek word translated "night" (νυξ) to depict this present evil age as a time of *moral and spiritual darkness* (John 13:30; 1 Thess. 5:5). The Greek verb rendered "almost gone" (προεκοψεν) means that the night is *far advanced, far spent* and is almost over. The time Satan has to have authority and power over this world system is drawing to a close (Luke 4:5-6; 2 Cor. 4:4; 1 John 5:19). Paul's thrust is that in view of the short time left, he wants believers to live for Jesus Christ.

Following the thought that the night is almost gone, Paul says, "and the day is near." In contrast to the Greek word for "night" (νυξ) the word for "day" (ημερα) may also be used of believers who "are sons of light and sons of day" (1 Thess. 5:5; cf. v. 8). It appears that Paul's main point here is that a given day is near, already referred to as the time *of our salvation*, to be identified with what is commonly called the Rapture. With the consummation of the present night period, when Satan's power on this earth will have run its course, we expect that

the day which is near will also usher in *a day of spiritual light and righteousness* under the supreme rule of Jesus Christ Himself.

In view of the fact that the night is almost gone and the day is near, Paul says, "we should lay aside the works of darkness, and we should put on the armor of light." The Greek word translated "we should lay aside" (αποθωμεθα) is in the aorist tense, subjunctive mood and middle voice, which means that *we ourselves should lay aside* as a garment, *put off* and *renounce* works of darkness (John 12:46).

To put off the works of darkness and to put on the armor of light should be the goal of every believer. According to the sixth chapter believers are to present their members as "weapons of righteousness of God" (6:13). Furthermore, in Second Corinthians 6:4-7, Paul commended himself as a minister of God "through the armor of righteousness on the right and left hand." The emphasis in this verse is on the *responsibility* of believers to put off the works of darkness and to put on the armor of light. Keep in mind, the Greek noun *armor* (οπλα) may also be translated *weapons*.

13. ***"We should walk properly when in the day, not in revelings and drunkenness, not in sexual promiscuity and outrageous conduct, not in strife and jealousy."***

The Greek phrase translated "we should walk properly" (ευσχημονως περιπατησωμεν) means that we should live and conduct ourselves in a manner *becoming, befitting* and *in keeping with* the standards of the Gospel of God's Grace. The Greek phrase translated "when in the day" (ως εν ημερα) is commonly rendered "as in the day." We grant that the Greek adverb "ως" is generally translated *as*, but in this context we feel that the translation *when* more clearly expresses the intended meaning. When we believers are in the day, when we are called sons of light, we are to live in accordance with our *day status*.

As those who are spiritually of the day and light, we are not to be involved in "revelings" (κωμοις), *carousings* and *rioting*. They are to have no part in "drunkenness" (μεθαις), *becoming intoxicated* or *inebriated.* It is significant that the revelings and drunkenness are closely associated. As we see it, the drunkenness brings about an abandonment of the mental faculties which in turn results in uncontrolled behavior.

Believers are to have no part in "sexual promiscuity" (κοιταις), *improper sexual conduct* or *sexuality in an evil context*. Also, associated with this perverted sexuality is "outrageous conduct" (ασελγειαις), *sensuality, intemperance*, and licentiousness. The thought seems to be that uncontrolled sexual desires will result in many excesses, not the least of which are some of the awful incurable diseases which act as a stop sign against further indulgence.

Furthermore, we believers are to be free from "strife and jealousy." The Greek noun translated "strife" (εριδι), means *contentiousness, wrangling* and *quarreling.* The Greek noun rendered "jealousy" (ζηλω) conveys the idea of *envy* and malice. These two words constitute a single phrase, and they refer to faulty

attitudes between believers and others. These sins are most destructive to the unity of the Spirit. Paul has much to say about them and against them (1:29; 1 Cor. 3:3; 2 Cor. 12:20).

14. ***"But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and do not make provision for the flesh regarding its lusts."***

The following is an amplified translation which brings out more fully the implications of the Greek text. "But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and do not give previous thought to the things of the flesh, giving way to its lusts."

In verse 12 Paul told the Roman believers to put away the works of darkness, and to put on the armor of light. In verse 13 he names some of the works of darkness, such as revelings, drunkenness, sexual sins, strife and jealousy. In verse 14 he emphasizes that in contrast (αλλα) to these evil works, they are to "put on the Lord Jesus Christ."

The Greek verb translated "put on" (ενδυσασθε) means that believers are to *clothe, invest* and *array themselves* with the Lord Jesus Christ as with an enveloping garment. The apparent thought is that Jesus Christ is to be put on as their "Lord" (κυριον) and *Master, as their Sovereign Owner.*

Negatively speaking, Paul says "do not make provision for the flesh regarding its lusts." The Greek phrase translated "do not make" (μη ποιεισθε) means that they are *not to be engaged* in any "provision" (προνοιαν), *prior thinking* and *forethought* for the things which belong to and relate to the flesh. Believers must not allow their minds to be reflecting and deliberating on the satiating of the lusts and desires of their flesh. The grammatical construction in the Greek makes it clear that they are not to be premeditating on the lusts and desires of those things associated with the flesh.

Chapter 14

1. ***"You receive the one being weak in the faith, not unto the end of discerning reasonings."***

Paul opens this chapter pleading the case of the believer who is weak in the faith. The Greek phrase translated "the faith" (τη πιστει), as used in this context, obviously refers to *the truth of the Gospel*, the body of doctrine which was revealed unto the Apostle Paul. The Greek participle rendered "weak" speaks of one who is *infirm, sick* and *feeble* with respect to the Word of God given to the Church. This lack of comprehension of the faith may be due to the lack of time to become established, lack of mental ability to grasp the Truth, or slothfulness.

Whatever the reason may be for a person being weak in the faith, Paul says, "you receive" (προσλαμβανεσθε) him, i.e., *take him to yourselves, include him in your fellowship, welcome him.* Paul uses this same verb in the 15th chapter, where he says, "receive one another, even as also Christ received you unto the glory of God" (15:7). There is no room for discrimination in the body of Christ - all are one in Christ (Gal. 3:28).

Believers are not to receive those weak in the faith "unto the end of discerning reasonings." Other possible translations of this would be not unto discerning of disputations or scruples. In other words, our motive for receiving a weak believer should not be for "discerning" (διακρισεις), distinguishing and judging that which is involved in his "reasonings" (διαλογισμων), *disputings* and *scruples*. Since Paul always uses this word with evil connotations, the implication is that we are not to get involved with such reasonings and disputing because they are intrinsically evil (Rom. 1:21; 1 Cor. 3:20; Phil. 2:14; 1 Tim. 2:8).

2. ***"One believes to eat all things, and the weak one eats herbs."***

A more complete, alternative translation of this verse would be as follows: On the one hand, one believes he may eat all things, and on the other hand, the weak one eats herbs. The latter translation brings out the significance of the Greek particles "μεν" and "δε," thereby pointing out more clearly the difference between these two believers who are to receive each other.

Now let us look at the literal translation, "One believes to eat all things." The thought here is that the one who understands *the faith*, who is knowledgeable in the Grace Truth given to the Church, believes that he has the right to eat all things. Paul corroborates this truth in First Corinthians 8:8, where he says, "And food does not commend us to God; neither if we may not eat do we lack, neither if we may eat do we abound" (cf. 1 Cor. 10:25-26). The all-important thing in this dispensation of Grace is our spiritual relationship with God in Jesus Christ, which has nothing to do with food and drink (Col. 2:16-17).

The statement that "the weak one eats herbs" suggests that he was a vegetarian.

This person is referred to as being weak due to his lack of understanding of the Truth of the Mystery given to the Church. Did he misinterpret this Truth and as a result become α vegetarian, or did he carry his vegetarian lifestyle over into Christianity? Whatever the case, friction developed between the carnivorous and vegetarian believers, between the strong and weak believers, and Paul is endeavoring to resolve the issue in this chapter.

3. ***"Let not the one eating despise the one not eating, and let not the one not eating judge the one eating, for God has received him."***

First, Paul orders the one who believes that he can eat everything not to despise the one who does not eat everything, particularly, meat. The Greek verb translated "despise" (εξουθενειτω) means that he is *not to make light of* or *treat with contempt* or *scorn* the herb eating vegetarian. The implication is that the knowledgeable believer, who understands the freedom he has in Christ, may be prone to despise weak believers who are ignorant of their freedom in Christ (Gal. 5:1, 13).

Second, Paul commands the one not eating not to judge the one eating. The Greek verb translated "judge" (κρινετω) means that he is *not to censor, to call to account, nor to pass judgment* on the one eating all things. This judgment is often the expression of a critical, faultfinding and censorial frame of mind. Paul takes a hard line against this critical form of judging in his epistles. In First Corinthians 4:5 he says, "So then do not judge anything before the time, until when the Lord may come, who will bring to light the secret things of darkness and manifest the counsels of hearts" (Heb. 10:30).

The declaration that "God has received him," as used in this verse, specifically refers to the eating, knowledgeable believer, but it also readily applies to the noneating, weak believer. A believer's dietary habits, whether he is carnivorous or vegetarian, have nothing to do with his spiritual relation to God. The thing that really counts is the *elimination* of contempt for and judgment of one another. We should leave each believer with God who has received him.

4. ***"Who are you, the one judging another's servant? To his own master he stands or falls; and he will be made to stand, for the Lord is able to make him stand."***

With the question "Who are you?" Paul directly confronts the spiritually weak vegetarian. The thought is: who do you think that you are, you who have taken it upon yourself to judge God's servant? This is a strong, verbal slap at the critical, weak believer who is judging the knowledgeable believer for exercising his freedom in Christ (Heb. 5:11-13).

The Greek participle rendered "the one judging" (κρινων) is in the present tense, which implies that this weak believer persistently indulges in judging others. Paul refers to the one being judged as "another's servant" (αλλοτριον οικετην), i.e., as one *belonging to another, foreign* to the one doing the judging. The point Paul is making is that the weak believer has no business judging the servant (household servant) who belongs to another, i.e., to the Lord.

Paul says that the servant "to his own master he stands or falls." The Greek phrase translated "to his own" (τω ιδιω) emphasizes that the servant's responsibility is limited to his own master; with respect to him he is either doing a good or bad job; his master alone determines. No one has the right to stick his judgmental nose into the master/servant relationship. The weak believer, with this incessant judging, is entirely out of place.

The last half of this verse is a closely knit whole. It deals with the relationship between the Lord God and believers, i.e., His servants. The United Bible Societies' text has the name "Lord" (κυριος) in this sentence, whereas the Majority Text has the name "God" (θεος). We do not consider this difference significant, since the name "lord" (κυριος) is commonly used to denote God, to whom the context obviously refers. God, via His Spirit, is the one who fulfills that spoken in this verse (16:25; Eph. 6:10-13).

Speaking of the aforementioned believer, Paul says, "and he will be made to stand." The Greek verb translated "he will be made to stand" (σταθησεται) is in the future tense and passive voice. This means that in the future he will be enabled to stand by means of *a power outside of himself.* The Greek language, with its various voices, distinguishes between that which the believer does and what God does. The last part of this sentence clearly declares that God is the external power who will enable the believer to stand; hence, He is the one who establishes him.

Finally, Paul says with reference to the one being judged, that "the Lord is able to make him stand." The thought is that the Lord is "able" (δυνατει), *powerful* and *mighty* "to make him stand" (στησαι). The Greek infinitive "στησαι" emphasizes the fact that a *powerful and mighty God* is the one who will make to stand, shore up, and establish the needy believer (Col. 4:12).

5. ***"For one man judges a day above a day, and another judges even day alike. Let each one be fully convinced in his own mind."***

This verse suggests that the early Roman believers differed on the importance of various days. On the one hand, one man esteemed a given day above other days, and on the other hand, another man regarded every day alike. Even though the Greek text does not have an equivalent for the English word *alike*, this word apparently conveys the correct Greek thought over into the English language.

Having said that there are believers who have different attitudes toward days, some holding that there are special days and others saying that all days are the same, Paul's answer is, "Let each one be fully convinced in his own mind." The Greek verb translated "let (each one) be fully convinced" (πληροφορεισθω) is derived from combining the words "πληρης" and "φορεω." It is in the present tense, imperative mood, and the passive voice, and basically means *to be brought to full measure,* hence, to be brought to the place where one is *fully convinced, fully persuaded*, and *fully assured*. According to Colossians 4:12, Epaphras prayed that God would fully convince the Colossians in all His will.

The passive voice insists that *God is the one* who fully convinces the individual minds of believers (πτω ιδιω νοι) regarding His will. As believers have differences involving days, etc., which probably involved mixing stipulations of the Mosaic Law with Grace, Paul is commanding them to let God the Holy Spirit fully convince their minds on the issue. We need to keep in mind that when Paul wrote the Book of Romans there was no New Testament canon of Scripture to guide believers in various details. During this time God the Holy Spirit spoke through New Testament prophets, complementing and conforming to the Truth of the Mystery revealed to the Apostle Paul (1 Cor. 12:28; 14:29-32).

When the New Testament epistles were written, such as the encyclical Epistles of Ephesians and Colossians, which give a comprehensive understanding of Church Truth, the New Testament prophets were replaced by the written Word of God. Now God tells us through His Word that the Jewish Sabbath passed away with the Mosaic Law, and according to the custom of the early believers we assemble to study the Word and to worship God on the first day of the week, the Lord's day.

6. ***"The one regarding the day regards it to the Lord; and the one eating eats to the Lord, for he gives thanks to God; and the one not eating, his not eating is to the Lord, and he gives thanks to God."***

The Greek participle translated "regarding" (φρονων) conveys the idea of *thinking, considering* and *observing*. In the light of the preceding verse, the thought here is apparently that the one who has certain thoughts, considerations and observations about various days has these to the Lord; i.e., the Lord is the object of his frame of mind.

With reference to verses 2-3, Paul says that "the one eating eats to the Lord." Now does Paul know that he eats to the Lord? Because of the following statement, "for he gives thanks to God." If he was not eating to the Lord, and for the Lord's glory, he would not give thanks, but since he does give thanks it proves that he is eating to the Lord. Maybe the herb eating vegetarian judges him for what he is eating, but Paul says that the important thing is that he is eating to the Lord, for His glory.

Also, with reference to verses 2-3, Paul says that "the one not eating, he does not eat to the Lord." The vegetarian's not eating of meat is to the Lord; i.e., the reason he refuses to eat meat is because he believes it pleases the Lord. Now does Paul know that his not eating meat is to the Lord? Because "he gives thanks to God." Keep in mind, this noneating believer is designated as being *weak*; he does not understand the freedom he has in Christ under Grace.

7. ***"For none of us lives to himself, and no one dies to himself."***

In the context before us Paul is exclusively speaking of believers, some strong and some weak. He says that no one "of us" (ημων), including himself, "lives" (ζη) and *exists* to or for himself. In the preceding verse he pointed out that regardless of whether a believer is carnivorous or vegetarian, the intention of his eating habits is for the Lord's glory.

In this verse Paul projects far beyond the fact that our eating habits are to be to the Lord - He is to be the *object of our living*. None of us believers are to live for ourselves; i.e., the reason for our existence is not found in ourselves. Paul expresses the same thought in Galatians 2:21, where he says, "no longer I live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I Now live in the flesh, I live by faith in the Son of God who loved me and gave himself on behalf of me." We in ourselves do not have a sufficient reason for living unto ourselves, for, if any good may be found in us, it is the gift of God and He should be given credit and glory for it (3:9-18, 23; 7:14, 18; Eph. 2:8-9).

Furthermore, continuing to speak of believers, Paul says that "no one dies to himself." In view of the future resurrection, when believers die they are referred to as having been put to sleep, not as being dead. The Greek verb which expresses this is always in the *passive voice*, which means that someone other than themselves put them to sleep, namely, God (1 Thess. 4:13-15). This indicates that God is the one who determines our days in this flesh and blood body (John 21:18-19, 21-23). As those who belong to the Lord, He puts us to sleep *to* and *for Himself*, that we may be with Him Now (Phil. 1:23) and in the future in resurrection-body form (Phil. 4:20-21).

8. ***"For if we may live, we live for the Lord, and if we may die, we die for the Lord. Therefore if we may live or if we may die, we are the Lord's."***

In exegeting this verse let us first look at the last clause, namely, that "we are the Lord's." Paul uses the genitive of possession to indicate that we believers *belong to* and *are owned by the Lord*. Once we establish the premise that all believers are the Lord's property (1 Cor. 6:19-20), then it logically follows that He should be the object of both our living and dying. This was true in Paul's life - he did not count his own life valuable to himself as he fearlessly fulfilled the ministry which the Lord gave to him (Acts 20:24).

Since the Lord owns us, it follows that if we may be living, then we live unto or with the Lord. The Greek verb rendered "we live" (ζωμεν) may also be interpreted as being in the subjunctive mood, in which case Paul would be saying: for if we may live, we *should* live unto or for the Lord. In the light of the context we prefer to interpret this verb as being in the indicative mood, which emphasizes the *nature* of our relationship with the Lord, namely, that if we may be living believers it is a foregone conclusion that we will be living unto or with the Lord. This speaks of our inseparable identity with Christ in life and living (1 John 5:12).

Next, we observe that "if we may die, we die unto [with] the Lord." Again we are forced back to the basic premise that we believers are *owned* by the Lord. He owns us while we are living, and He owns us when we die, i.e., during the time our bodies sleep, waiting for their glorified form (1 Cor. 15:51-54). This is *not* a time of soul-sleeping but of body-sleeping, during which interlude we, as spiritual beings, will be with Christ in the heavenlies (2 Cor. 5:6-9; Phil. 1:23).

Paul briefly summarizes in the following words what he has said: "If we may live or if we may die, we are the Lord's." When Jesus Christ was made sin for us (2

Cor. 5:21) on Calvary's Cross, He redeemed and bought us for an *eternal possession*, which includes our present physical life plus our future existence beyond what is commonly called death (2 Cor. 5:21). Since He has purchased us with His own precious Blood for eternity, then we belong to Him and are in his custody forever, and neither life nor death can separate us from Him (8:38).

9. ***"For to this end Christ died and lived, that he might be Lord both of the dead and of the living."***

The Majority Text adds the phrase "and rose" between the words "died" and "lived" as follows: "For to this end Christ died and rose and lived, that he might be Lord of both the dead and living." The addition of the phrase "and rose" (και ανεστη) explains more fully how the Christ who died also lived again. The shorter text *implies* that the resurrection took place between Christ's death and living again; therefore, there is no difference between the ultimate meaning of the two texts.

The prepositional phrase translated "to this end" (εις τουτο) conveys the idea *that for this reason* or *that this is the object* for which Christ died and lived again. On one hand, His going through the cycle of death and life makes it possible for Him to be *identified* with both the dead and living. On the other hand, what He came to accomplish necessitated His going through this cycle.

The final purpose of Christ's death and resurrection unto life, as stated in this verse, is that "he might be Lord both of the dead and of the living." The Greek verb translated "might be Lord" (κυριευση) means that He might *have mastery over* or *reign over*. Since the death of Christ is the payment made for our sin, and as a result *He owns us,* it follows that as our owner He has the right to exercise lordship over us (1 Cor. 7:23; 2 Peter 2:1).

Our life is dependent upon the fact that Christ lives - this is the reason He had to live again. Even as apart from His death He would not own us, likewise, apart from His living He would have no life to share with us (John 6:57; 1 John 5:11-12). Both His death and life were imperative for total lordship over His own. First Thessalonians 5:10 says that Christ "died on behalf of us, that whether we watch or whether we sleep we shall live together with Him" (cf. Rom. 4:25).

10. ***"But you, why do you judge your brother? Or also you, why do you despise your brother? For we shall all stand beside the judgment-seat of God."***

These two questions refer back to what Paul said in verse 3. He asks the weak herb eating believer, "why do you judge your brother?" In the previous verses in this chapter Paul has pointed out that both the weak and strong believers *belong to the Lord*, which leads him to call them *brothers* in this verse. He asks the weak believer why he persists in judging his brother, for he will have to give account for what he is doing before the judgment seat of God.

Likewise, he asks the strong believer why he persists in despising the weak brother, for he also will have to give an account for his actions before the

judgment seat of God. The implication is that the thought of impending judgment would remove their faulty attitudes (2 Peter 3:11).

The Majority Greek Text contains the reading: "For we shall all stand beside the judgment seat of Christ." In view of the evidence and the following context we prefer the phrase *the judgment seat of God*. Also, the translation that we shall all stand *beside* instead of before the judgment seat is most accurate.

Before we leave this 10th verse we need to compare the phrase "the judgment-seat of God" (τω βηματι του θεου) with the phrase "the judgment-seat of Christ" (του βεματος του χριστου; 2 Cor. 5:10). In the light of our evaluation of the external evidence, i.e., manuscript readings, and the fact that the name of *God* appears in the quotation in the 11th verse, and that the 12th verse, dealing with the same subject, also has the name of God, the implication is that the original autographs contained the phrase *the judgment-seat of God.*

The Greek word translated "judgment-seat" (βηματι) is used twelve times in the Greek New Testament. The only other time it is used with reference to a Divine judgment-seat is in Second Corinthians 5:10, where Paul says that "it is necessary for us all to be manifest before the judgment-seat of Christ."

According to the verse before us, including the two following it, believers will be judged before the judgment-seat of God. On the surface, at least, there appears to be an inconsistency between these two passages.

In examining this subject we want to consider what the New Testament says about God's role and Christ's role in the area of judging. First, it is obvious that God the Father is one who will judge the world (3:6) and those outside (1 Cor. 5:13; cf. Rom. 2:16). Second, it is not always clear when the word "Lord" (κυριος) is used whether it refers to the Father or the Son, but we submit the following passages as referring to the fact that God judges His people: Hebrews 10:30-31; First Peter 1:17; Romans 2:16. Third, there is more clear evidence that Christ is active in judging the people of God, particular1γ, the members of His Body (1 Cor. 4:4-5; 11:32; 2 Tim. 4:1; John 5:22).

Summarizing, in the light of John 5:22: "For neither does the Father judge anyone, but he has given all judgment to the Son," we conclude that the *judgment-seat of God,* as used in this 10th verse, would be effected via the Person of Jesus Christ, hence, synonymous with the judgment-seat of Christ mentioned in Second Corinthians 5:10.

11. ***"For it has been written,* As I live, says the Lord, that every knee shall bow to me, and every tongue shall confess to God."**

Having affirmed that we all shall stand beside the judgment-seat of God, Paul corroborates this by quoting most of this verse from Isaiah 45:24. This passage refers to a future time when every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess to God. Paul also uses this same general thought in Philippians 2:10-11, to portray a future time when every knee will bow at the name of Jesus and every tongue will confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.

Paul's concept of the judgment-seat of Christ or of God is a *part of Mystery Truth* which was revealed unto him, and it is not to be found in the Old Testament (Eph. 3:2-5; Col. 1:24-26). He uses this Old Testament passage mainly to make what he is saying more palatable and acceptable. The fact that God holds men accountable is a universal principle.

12. ***"So then each one of us shall give account concerning himself to God."***

The two Greek particles translated "so then" (αρα ουν) may also be rendered *then therefore*, indicating that what follows is a *consequence of* what has just been said. In view of the fact that we shall all stand beside the judgment seat of God in Christ, bowing and confessing, Paul says that each one will have to give an account of himself to God.

There are four significant things in this verse: 1) *each and every* person who is a believer will have the responsibility of giving an account regarding himself; 2) this account will be "concerning" (περι), *about*, and *respecting* himself, i.e., it will focus on him as a person; 3) the Greek noun translated "account" (λογον) means a *record, report,* or *reckoning;* 4) this account will be given to *God* represented by Jesus Christ.

13. ***"Therefore let us no longer judge one another, but judge this rather, that you do not put a stumbling block or an obstacle in the way of the brother."***

This verse opens with the adverb translated "no longer" (μηκετι), i.e., *do not yet* or *still* continue to judge one another. The reciprocal pronoun translated "one another" (αλληλους) means that as brothers they are not to judge each other and vice versa. Each one has the responsibility to take the *initiative* - to stop judging the other regardless of what he may or may not do.

In contrast to judging one another, Paul says, "but judge this rather." The emphatic conjunction translated "but" (αλλα) *emphasizes the importance* of *what they should do* instead of judging one another. The Greek verb translated "judge" (κρινατε), as used in this context, may also be rendered *resolve* or *determine*. Rather than judging one another they should resolve and determine not to put a stumbling block or obstacle in the path of the brother.

Their resolution should be unto the end not to "put" (τιθεναι), *place*, *set* or *lay* a stumbling block or obstacle before a brother. The Greek noun translated "stumbling block" (προσκομμα), metaphorically speaking, refers to anything which causes a brother to morally *lose his balance, stumble,* and *fall* (1 Cor. 8:9). The Greek word translated "obstacle" (σκανδαλον), as used by Paul, means that we should not place that which is *offensive, repugnant* and *morally destructive* where a brother will be ruined by it.

14. ***"I know and am persuaded in the Lord Jesus that nothing is unclean in itself; except to the one counting anything to be unclean, to that one it is unclean."***

The Greek verb translated "persuaded" (πεπεισμαι) is in the perfect tense and passive voice which means that through Divine revelations Paul was and continued to be *persuaded, convinced* and *confident* in the Lord Jesus that nothing in itself is unclean. Interpreting the phrase "in the Lord Jesus" (εν κυριω Ιησου) as being in the locative case, the thought is that Paul had been persuaded *in the sphere of* the Lord Jesus, probably by truth revealed unto him by the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 2:10).

If we interpret the phrase "in the Lord Jesus" (εν κυριω Ιησου) as being in the instrumental case, the thought is that Paul had been persuaded *by the Lord Jesus* that nothing is unclean in itself. In this case the Lord Jesus would be the one who had persuaded Him (Gal. 1:12).

Paul emphasizes that, as far as *he himself* is concerned, that he both knows and has been persuaded that not a single thing (ουδεν) is "unclean" (κοινον), *common, defiled* and *impure* in its essence of self. Furthermore, he affirms that this is true for everyone "except to the one counting anything to be unclean, to that one it is unclean." This means that whether a thing is clean or unclean, ceremonially speaking, depends upon one's *attitude toward it*. If one's conscience dictates that something is unclean, to that person it is unclean, for we must not violate our conscience.

15. ***"For if through food your brother is grieved, you are no longer walking according to love. Do not destroy with your food that one on behalf of whom Christ died."***

The Greek phrase translated "for if through food" (ει γαρ δια βρωμα) conveys the idea, for if *through the agency of food*, if food is that which *causes* a brother to be grieved, then to eat it is to display a lack of love. The Greek verb translated "grieved" (λυπειται) is in the present tense and passive voice and means that if the food one is eating continues to have the effect of *grieving, distressing,* and *injuring* a brother in the Lord, then such eating is devoid of love.

The Greek adverb translated "no longer" (ουκετι) indicates that as long as a brother is being grieved by what another brother eats, even though there may be no Biblical justification for such grief, he is not walking according to the principle of love. The Greek verb translated "walking" (περιπατεις) literally means to *walk around*, hence, it is used of *how one lives, his lifestyle* and *conduct*. The believer who is causing mental pain and sorrow to his brother by what he is eating is not conducting himself in accordance with the standard of love (1 Cor. 13:4-7).

Paul goes on to warn the believer who is eating offensive foods not to destroy the weaker believer who is having a mental trauma resulting from his diet, i.e., from what the stronger believer eats. The Greek verb translated "destroy" (απολλυε) may be rendered *put to death, cause to perish,* or *to utterly destroy*. In using this strong language one thing is certain, Paul is not implying that a genuine brother may have his spiritual relationship with Christ destroyed (8:31-39).

In dealing with this issue we must keep in mind that Paul looked at those affiliating themselves with a local assembly as elect ones. In other words, he

considered that they were saved. But, although he refers to them as saints, he never went so far as to vouch for their salvation. Even though they manifested the outward sign of assembling together, of listening to the Word of God, etc., Paul always left room for the *if* clause (1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23).

Two possible interpretations of what Paul has in mind in this verse are: 1) some of the weaker ones may have been in the *if* category, and offensive eating could deter and hinder them; 2) as genuine weak believers their spiritual progress may have been subject to relative deterioration and destruction.

The statement "on behalf of whom Christ died" affirms the value of the substitutionary death of Jesus Christ. On the one hand, it provides deliverance from eternal death and destruction. On the other hand, it provides the means by which believers may continuously have a good-conscience relationship with God (1 John 1:9).

16. ***"Therefore do not let your good thing be spoken of as evil."***

According to verse 2 the strong believer understood that he had the authority to eat all things. In this respect he had the same mind-set as Paul (v. 14). The problem is that the weak believer, who lacked knowledge and understanding, harbored scruples against eating certain things. Instead of quietly endeavoring to learn what Paul was teaching, and to lay hold of the liberty which believers have in Christ (Gal. 5:1), he majored in judging and saying *evil things* (βλασφημεισθω), blasphemous and maligning things about the mature, liberated believer.

Since the weak believer was hopelessly stymied in his dietary scruples, and was spiritually impotent to adjust to the mature believer, Paul appeals to the latter to make the adjustment in order to avoid conflict and disunity. The point here is not whether the strong or weak believer was right, but which of the two had the *spiritual dynamic* to adjust to the other. I am sure that with the passing of time Paul hoped that the weak believer would come to appreciate his freedom in Christ, but this takes *time*. In the meantime the strong believer, who has learned to esteem others as better than himself (12:10), is to patiently *hold up* the weak believer even though he has been unjustly judged by him (Eph. 4:2).

17. ***"For the kingdom of God is not food and drink, but righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit."***

This is the only time the phrase "the kingdom of God" (η βασιλεια του θεου) is used in this epistle. It is used four times in the Book of Acts with apparently the same meaning - with reference to the Church (Acts 19:8; 20:25; 28:23; 28:31; cf. 1 Cor. 4:20; Col. 1:13; 4:11). Paul says that in its essence the kingdom of God is not food and drink. The Greek words for "food" (βρωσις) and "drink" (ποσις) mean that it is not *food, meat* and *eating* nor is it *drink* or *drinking*.

Paul is not speaking about a kingdom which operates on the physical plane, but on the spiritual plane. Its main characteristics are provided by God through the Holy Spirit, namely, righteousness, peace and joy. The strong adversative conjunction is used to emphasize the *spiritual nature* of the kingdom of which he

is speaking. This positively identifies it with the Body of Christ, the Church, God's only program through which He relates to men during this dispensation of Grace (Eph. 3:2).

Jesus Christ in His Person is the embodiment of the *righteousness* of God (1 Cor. 1:30; Phil. 3:9) which He shares with those believing on Him (10:4). God the Father is commonly credited with giving *peace* to men (Eph. 1:2), which He does in Jesus Christ (Eph. 2:14). Again we observe that God is the source of true *joy*, that which He imparts to believers via the Holy Spirit (15:13; Gal. 5:22).

18. ***"For the one serving Christ in this one is pleasing to God and approved by men."***

In contrast to one believer despising another for his ceremonial eating scruples, and the latter judging the other for exercising his freedom to eat all things, Paul says that God's program in this Church age involves *spiritual entities*, key to one's having righteousness, peace, and joy. Furthermore, in contrast to the old letter of the Law, the Holy Spirit is the prominent dispenser and effecter of Truth during this dispensation when God is exclusively relating to His people in a *spiritual manner* (2 Cor. 3:3-6; 1 Cor. 2:10; Eph. 5:18-20).

In the Greek this verse begins with the words "for the one in this." Paul's use of the singular pronoun "this" (τουτω) obviously refers to the *Holy Spirit* mentioned in the preceding verse. This means that Paul is saying: "for the one serving Christ in the Holy Spirit is pleasing to God and approved by men." The context is emphasizing that instead of squabbling about scruples associated with eating and drinking physical things, one should be engaged in serving Christ in energy of the Spirit. This is what really pleases God and has the approval of men.

The Greek phrase translated "pleasing to God" (ευαρεστος τω θεω) means that serving Christ in the Holy Spirit *pleases God well* and is *acceptable to Him* (12:11; Col. 1:9-11). The Greek phrase rendered "approved by men" (δοκιμος τοις ανθρωποις) speaks of one who, having been tested and tried, is judged worthy of *approval, approbation* and *certification* (1 Cor. 11:19) by men or it may be translated with men.

19. ***"Then therefore let us pursue the things of peace and the things of edification unto one another."***

The following is an amplified translation which brings out the thought more clearly: "Then therefore let us pursue the things that belong to peace and the things that belong to edification toward one another." The meaning of this verse is very clear, but in giving a literal translation of it, we are faced with a compromise between the grammatical construction and the clarity of thought content. Therefore, we use the above amplified translation.

The two Greek particles translated "then therefore" (αρα ουν) indicate that, as a consequence of what Paul said in verses 17-18, all believers are to do what he says in this verse. The exhortation "let us pursue" (διωκωμεν) is in the present tense and subjunctive mood, and may also be rendered we *should continuously pursue, chase after,* and *endeavor to acquire* peace and mutual edification. Even

as this verb is used in the classical Greek of a wild animal after its prey, likewise, we should be pursuing after peace and the building up of one another.

The first thing we are to endeavor to acquire are "the things of peace" (τα της ειρηνης); i.e., the things which *belong to and are associated with peace.* These are things which promote *tranquillity, concord* and *harmony*. One of the most essential ingredients for peace is "to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace" (Eph. 4:3-6). In order to do this we must have a *common denominator* of Church Truth, which includes all that has been written to and for the Body of Christ in the New Testament, and which excludes all that pertains to the Mosaic Law and the Kingdom laws. With a common denominator of Church Truth, which in itself is *consistent* and produces *oneness in thinking*, all believers are earnestly to endeavor to keep this spirit-produced unity in the bond of peace.

The second thing we are to pursue is "the things of edification unto one another," i.e., the things whereby believers mutually edify and build up one another. The Greek word translated "edification" (οικοδομης) basically means to build a house; hence, it has the metaphorical meaning of *building up, improving* and *advancing one another in an understanding of the Truth of God's Word given to us members of the Body of Christ.*

The concept of believers having the responsibility of mutually building up one another is clearly taught in the New Testament. The Greek phrase translated "unto one another" (εις αλληλους) means that they are to pursue edification unto the end of *each one building up the other*. This same reciprocal pronoun is commonly used in the New Testament to emphasize inter-believer responsibility to help one another better understand the Truth of the Mystery for the Church (15:14; 1 Thess. 4:18; 5:11; Heb. 10:24).

20. ***"Do not for the sake of food destroy the work of God. All things indeed are clean but evil for the man eating with offence."***

The Greek adverb translated "for the sake of" (ενεκεν) may also be rendered *on account of* or *by reason of.* The thought is that one should not allow food, particularly meat, to "destroy" (καταλυε), literally, *to loose down, tear down,* and *undo* the work of God. The phrase "the work of God" (το ετγον του θεου) in this context refers to the weak brother who is offended by the strong brother's carnivorous habits. Since God has sovereignly saved this weak brother, he is looked at as the work of God, but now his spiritual progress is in jeopardy due to the strong brother's lack of concern for his dietary scruples.

Paul affirms here that "all things indeed are clean." The Greek adjective translated "clean" (καθαρα) means that all things are *void of evil, unsoiled* and *pure*. This is a reaffirmation of what he said in verse 14, namely, "that nothing is unclean in itself." Looking at all things objectively in terms of their intrinsic nature, everything is clean. The issue of whether certain food is clean or unclean does not depend upon what it is, but upon what it does; i.e., does eating it offend the weak believer?

That which is pure in itself has the potential of becoming "evil for the man eating (it) with offence." The Greek word translated "offence" in this verse is the same as used in verse 13, namely, "προσκομματος" that which causes one *to lose his balance, stumble* and *fall*. The evil does not reside in eating certain food, but in the *result of eating certain food, which offends a brother.*

Summarizing, the weak brother as a new creation in Christ is the work of God. As the strong brother eats that which offends him, it may have a detrimental affect on him, the work of God. It is a sin to offend a brother; therefore, the one eating with offence sins against his brother.

21. ***"It is good not to eat flesh nor to drink wine nor to be in that which your brother stumbles."***

The Majority Greek Text adds the words "η σκανδαλιζεται η ασθενει," which may be translated "or is offended or is weak." This addition does not add anything significant to the meaning of this verse.

Paul's main thrust in this verse is that it is "good" (καλον), *right* and *proper* not to eat, drink or be involved in anything which causes your brother to stumble. This verse covers all the bases.

First, Paul affirms that it is good not to eat "flesh" (κρεα) or *meat* if it causes your brother to stumble. The only other time this Greek word for "flesh" (κρεα) is used in the New Testament is in First Corinthians 8:13, where Paul says, "Wherefore if food causes my brother to stumble, I will never eat flesh forever, that my brother may not stumble."

Second, Paul declares that it is good not to drink "wine" (οινον) if it is going to cause your brother to stumble. In the New Testament this word was used primarily, if not exclusive1γ, of wine made from grapes. It contained sufficient alcohol if enough was drunk to make a person intoxicated (John 2:10; Eph. 5:18). There were undoubtedly some who took a teetotal position in the New Testament churches (Lk. 1:15), and were offended at those who drank it for medicinal reasons (1 Tim. 5:23).

Third, Paul says that it is good not to be engaged in that which causes your brother to stumble. This is a literal translation of this verse and it includes everything apart from eating meat and drinking wine that a person might do to cause his brother to stumble.

22. ***"The faith which you have, with respect to yourself have it before God. Happy is the one not judging himself in that which he approves."***

The key word in the first part of this verse is translated "faith" (πιστιν). It basically means *firm persuasion, conviction* and *full assurance*. Paul is affirming here that a believer, before he does anything that might be offensive, should be fully persuaded, convinced and confident that it will not harm the believer who is weak in the truth of God's Word. He should have this conviction and confidence before God; i.e., it should be genuine.

Furthermore, Paul says that happy and blessed (μακαριος) is "the one not judging himself in that which he approves." This emphasizes the need to be fully persuaded that one's actions will not offend someone, and bring judgment upon one's self.

23. ***"But if the one doubting may eat he has been condemned, because it is not out of faith; and everything which is not out of faith is sin."***

The "one doubting" (ο διακρινομενος) is a person faced with an *unresolved decision, wavering between what is right and wrong,* or *who hesitates between two options.* The case before us involves the knowledgeable believer who recognizes that he is free to eat all things and the immature believer who feels that he should eat only herbs (cf. v. 2).

If the strong believer interacts with the weak believer in a manner which is detrimental to the latter's spiritual relationship with the Lord, then he is not living according to love (v. 15) but according to evil (v. 20). Paul is not speaking here of the mature believer who inadvertently offends an immature believer, but of the believer who *knows* that what he is about to do *may* detrimentally affect another member of the Body of Christ. If one is aware of the destructive potential his contemplated actions may have on another Christian and still goes through with his actions, Paul says that he has been condemned.

The Greek verb translated "has been condemned" (κατακεκριται) is in the perfect tense and means that at the moment the knowledgeable believer decided to eat meat, in spite of his doubts about how it might affect a weaker believer, he was *condemned*, i.e., *declared guilty*. The perfect tense suggests that this condemnation resulted from the decision to please himself rather than avoid offending a weak brother.

Paul goes on to say that the strong brother is condemned for his decision to eat "because it is not out of faith," i.e., because the *origin* of this decision is not faith. If he had faith in God and His Word and was faithful to God's instructions, (putting the other person's needs before his own; 12:10), then he would be acting according to faith/faithfulness.

Finally, Paul says that "everything which is not out of faith is sin." We must bear in mind that the Greek noun translated "faith" (πιστεως) basically means to be *firmly persuaded, convinced* and *assured*. In actual usage several times it must be translated faithfulness. Faith in God and *faithfulness* to God are necessary for pleasing Him (Heb. 11:6). The opposite, to doubt God and His Word, is sin.

Chapter 15

1. ***"But we who are strong ought to bear the infirmities of those without strength, and not to please ourselves."***

The Greek phrase translated "we who are strong" (ημεις οι δυνατοι) refers to believers who are *able, who have spiritual ability,* and *who are powerful* in their knowledge of God's Word. These would be the mature spiritual leaders in a local assembly (cf. Gal. 6:1).

The Greek phrase translated "those without strength" (των αδυνατων) has the alpha of negation prefixed to the same word used above; hence, it speaks of those who are *not strong, not able* and *who lack ability* in the Word of God. The two main reasons why some believers lack spiritual strength are: 1) because they try to synchronize their old lifestyle with the Gospel of Grace; 2) because they do not diligently study God's Word which has been given to them (Col. 1:25-26).

In this verse Paul explains the strong believer's responsibility toward the without-strength believer. First, the verb translated "ought" (οφειλομεν) means that we strong believers are *obligated, indebted,* and *owe something* to those who are strengthless. Second, he says that we owe it to them to bear their infirmities.

The Greek phrase translated "the infirmities" (τα ασθενηματα) speaks of their spiritual and physical *weaknesses, feebleness,* and *frailties*. As used in this verse it also included their scruples, hang-ups, and unfounded idiosyncrasies. Many of these infirmities must have seemed stupid to intelligent believers, trying their patience, but still Paul orders them to bear the same.

The Greek infinitive translated "to bear" (βασταζειν) means *to lift, carry*, and also *to bear with, put up with,* or *tolerate*. In view of what Paul says in the next verse, it appears that the primary way strong believers should bear the infirmities of the weak is by sympathetically endeavoring to understand why they have their scruples, and as the answer, share with them the Word of God. The manner in which one bears with should be in accordance with the particular need or infirmity.

Strong believers have two alternatives, either to bear the infirmities of those *not able* or to please themselves. Paul says that the second, pleasing of self, is *not* a viable alternative for mature believers. He commands them to fulfill their obligation to those spiritually weak, which in turn will increase their own spiritual maturity.

2. ***"Let each one of us please the neighbor unto the end of that which is good for edification."***

The preceding verse (15:1) consummated Paul's instructions regarding how strong and weak believers are to interact with one another. In this verse he begins dealing with how believers, similar in spiritual maturity, are to treat each other.

Paul directs what he is saying to *individual believers* who constitute the church at Rome. Each one is instructed to please "the neighbor" (τω πλησιον), literally, *the one near*. This may well be interpreted to mean each believer is to speak and live in a manner which will "please" (αρεσκετο), *gratify, delight*, and *be acceptable* to the one near him wherever he may be. This verse is certainly emphasizing the mutual responsibility which believers have toward one another.

The last half of this verse sets forth the ultimate object of their pleasing one another, namely, "unto the end of that which is good for edification." Here we see the reason why they are to please one another. This mutual pleasing of one another is not in itself Paul's goal for them, but it is an important psychological step which prepares their minds to be edified. There must be a pleasing relationship between believers before they can effectively share the Truth of God's Word with one another. Paul expresses this same thought when he says that we are to "speak the truth in love" (Eph. 4:15).

The truth which we are to share with one another is "that which is good for edification." Now do we determine *what* particular truth is "that which is good" for edification (οικοδομην) in this present Church age? The great bulk of the Old Testament contains God's Word for the Nation of Israel while they were under the Mosaic Law. If this is the truth which Paul has in mind when he speaks about that which is good for edification, why didn't he major in it himself instead of writing fourteen epistles to churches and individuals associated with churches?

The Apostle Paul makes it very clear, the truth which establishes and builds up believers during this present dispensation of Grace is the *Gospel of God's Grace* (Acts 20:24), the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the Mystery (Rom. 16:25), the Word of God, the Mystery (Col. 1:25-26), etc. In contrast to the Mosaic Law, the Mystery Gospel saves and edifies on the basis of Grace.

3. ***For also Christ pleased not himself, but even as it has been written,* the reproaches of those reproaching you fell upon me."**

Having said that each believer should please his neighbor, Paul cites Christ as the supreme example of this, *for He assumed* the reproaches which were being flung against God the Father.

The statement that "Christ pleased not himself" (χριστος ουχ εαυτω ηρεσεν) means that His objective was not to satisfy, gratify, and appease the desires and wants of His own person in the flesh. True, as one who had an apart-from-sin, flesh and blood body, He had needs, but the meeting of these needs was subordinate to pleasing God. In the Garden of Gethsemane, under the impending weight of the sin of the world, He said, "My Father, if it is possible, let this cup be taken from me; nevertheless not as I will but as you will" (Matt. 26:39; cf. 1 Cor. 10:33).

Paul's use of the strong adversative conjunction "αλλα," translated but, emphasizes the contrast between what Christ did not do, i.e., please Himself,

and what He did do, the very opposite, *He pleased God.* As an example of the fact that Christ did not please Himself, Paul quotes the last portion of Psalm 69:9.

First, the Holy Spirit via the Apostle Paul indicates that the truth in this Psalm refers to the Messiah, Christ. Second, this verse certainly pointed toward Christ's *substitutionary death* on behalf of sinners.

Now let us briefly exegete the fuller meaning of this quotation as cited by the Holy Spirit in the Greek. The Greek noun translated "reproaches" (ονειδισμοι) conveys the idea of *insults, revilings*, and *casting abuse in one's teeth*. As the present participle implies, they were continually directing these reproaches *against God*. Those who reject God, the creator and sustainer of all things, seem madly driven to savagely reproach God in their effort to defend their mindless hypothesis.

In the Adamic rebellion man severed himself from fellowship with God. Since that time it has been God's purpose to bring man back into fellowship with Himself, but in order to do this the consequences of the rebellion must be squarely faced. Now can God remain just and at the same time justify rebellious sinners (3:26)? It was impossible for God, the object of sinner's reproaches, to restore man into fellowship with Himself apart from the wages of sin being paid for by death (6:23). The reproaches, the sins of sinners, fell upon Jesus Christ on Calvary's Cross (2 Cor. 5:21).

4. ***"For as much as was previously written, it was written for our teaching, in order that through the patience and through the comfort of the scriptures we might have hope."***

First, let us consider the ramifications of the statement "For as much as was previously written." The Greek word translated "as much as" (οσα) speaks of the *quantity* not quality of what has been written. The Greek verb translated "was previously written" (προεγραπφη) refers to that which was written *prior to* or *before the time* when Paul wrote this epistle. Through the use of the phrase "the scriptures," Paul further limits that which was previously written to the Old Testament. Many other things had been written, but what he is saying here is limited to the Old Testament Scriptures.

Second, Paul says that the Scriptures were written for our teaching. Keep in mind that here Paul is writing to members of the Body of Christ, the Church, and informing them that the Old Testament was written *unto the end of our teaching* (εις ημετεραν διδασκαλιαν). The Greek noun translated "teaching" (διδασκαλιαν) means that it was recorded in written form for our *instruction and information*. We must keep in mind that God's *purpose* for revealing the truth in the Old Testament was to give specific messages to given individuals and people in different dispensational administrations. Since God is the same, even though He may not always relate to men in the same way, there are universal truths from past dispensations which significantly bolster our hope.

As far as we in this Church age are concerned, the Old Testament has come down to us in written form "in order that through the patience and through the

comfort of the Scriptures we might have hope." We emphasize, God's *primary purpose* was to give the truth contained in the Old Testament to those in past dispensations. It was God's specific message for them to know and obey. According to this verse, God has a *secondary purpose* for the Old Testament in written form, namely, that it might affirm our *hope*. Note, the primary purpose has obedience as its object; the secondary purpose has hope as its object.

Finally, the accomplishment of this secondary hope involves the patience and comfort of the Scriptures. The Greek noun translated "patience" (υπομονης) means *to remain under, endurance,* and *steadfastness.* The Greek word translated "comfort" (παρακλησεως) may also be rendered *exhortation* and *encouragement*. What Paul is saying here is that the Old Testament contains many examples of patience, endurance, and perseverance as well as of comfort, exhortation, and encouragement, and that to be *informed* regarding these strengthens our *hope*. The Blessed Hope is *Mystery Truth* revealed unto the Apostle Paul (Titus 2:13), which may be solidified by an understanding of God's faithfulness to His people as recorded in the Old Testament (cf. Heb. 11:1-40).

5. ***"And may the God of the patience and of the comfort grant to you to think the same with one another according to Christ Jesus: "***

In the Greek text the article precedes the words rendered patience and comfort. In view of the interchange of these two words between this and the preceding verse, we have translated these article phrases "the patience" (της υπομονης) and "the comfort" (της παρακλησεως). In other words, the patience and the comfort of the Scriptures, which are expressions of God, are likened to attributes of God in this verse. This implies that it is *God's patient endurance* and *comforting encouragement* of His people, recorded in the Old Testament, which gives hope to believers.

It is Paul's prayer that the God, who has manifested His remaining-under endurance and encouragement in the Old Testament, might "grant" (δωη) or *give* to you "to think the same with one another." The Greek phrase translated "to think the same" (το αυτο φρονειν) means that Paul wanted them to be *unified in their thinking, to have the same mindset,* or *to assume the same attitude* toward one another. In the light of the preceding context we feel that the emphasis here is primarily on believers assuming a proper attitude toward one another. They are to be more concerned with pleasing one another than themselves. Secondarily, it brings out the need for all believers to be one in their doctrinal thinking (Eph. 4:3-6).

Finally, their thinking is to be "according to Christ Jesus." This, of course, refers back to verse 3, where we observe that Christ assumed the death penalty of sinners reproaching God. His mind-set was not to please Himself, but to suffer the cruel death of the Cross on behalf of others (sinners). To have an "according to Christ" mind-set involves a readiness to follow Him in this same cycle (cf. Phil. 2:8).

6. ***"that with one accord with one mouth you may glorify God even the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ."***

This verse opens with the conjunction "ινα" used with the subjunctive mood, which expresses the *purpose* of the preceding verse. Paul's prayer is that God may unify their mutual thinking like unto that of Christ, "in order that" (ινα) they might glorify God. It is interesting to observe that God must *give them, impart to them*, the necessary ingredient, the unity of the Spirit, before they can fulfill the purpose of glorifying Him (Eph. 4:3). In other words, man is totally bankrupt spiritually, and apart from the provision God makes through His Spirit, he would be utterly incapable of glorifying God.

The preceding verse sets forth the necessary basis for glorifying God. This verse explains how God is to be glorified - "with one accord, with one mouth." The Greek word translated "with one accord" (ομοθυμαδον) is derived from the combining of two words (ομου and θυμος) and basically means *with one passion* or *with one soul,* hence, *with one accord, with one will,* or *unanimously*. This word does not emphasize unanimity in thinking, i.e., in the intellectual sphere, but rather *unanimity in feelings, passions,* and *longings*, i.e., in the emotional sphere. Paul has emphasized the unity in thinking in the preceding verse, the need for all believers to have the correct mind-set mutually. In this verse we have the expression of this mind-set in which the emotions play a significant part.

This one accord in feeling is closely tied to "one mouth" (ενι στοματι), the medium through which they express their oneness in mind which has resulted in their unanimity in feeling. It is important to observe that we have a triple emphasis on unity in these two verses: 1) to think the same thing; 2) to be one in feeling; and 3) to have one mouth. This means that their many mouths are to have *one message*, the Truth of the mystery, which they proclaim unitedly with one mouth, thereby glorifying God.

As a result of believers being unified in the Truth of God's Grace given to the Church and this Truth being compassionately proclaimed with one united voice, God will be glorified. This is the ideal for which Paul prays as indicated by the use of the optative mood (δωη) in verse 5. This should be the goal of every local assembly!

7. ***"Wherefore you receive one another, even as Christ also received you, unto the glory of God."***

In the light of the following context it appears that Paul is emphasizing the need for believing Jews and Gentiles to receive one another unto the glory of God. We know that the church at Rome was constituted of both Jewish and Gentile believers; therefore it is logical to assume that they did have their differences from time to time (1:13; 9:24; 11:13).

The Greek word translated "wherefore" (διο) suggests that *on account of* what Paul has said they are to receive one another. The compound Greek phrase translated "receive one another" (προσλαμβανεσθε αλληλους) literally means *to take to one's self, to receive as a close associate,* or to have a *nothing-between*

relationship. The reciprocal Greek pronoun "αλληλους" means that each one is to take the initiative in receiving the other.

Paul uses this same verse to describe how strong believers are to receive weak believers (14:2) and also how God receives or takes to Himself weak believers (14:3). Furthermore, Paul uses this same verb in writing to Philemon, he says, "If therefore you hold me as a partner, receive (προσλαβου) him as me" (v. 17). Paul desires that the close fellow-partner relationship which existed between himself and Philemon might also exist between believing Jews and Gentiles in the Body (1 Cor. 12:13).

The supreme example of how they are to receive one another is "even as Christ also received you." This same verb (προσελαβετο), in its appropriate form, is used to depict how Christ received us unto Himself, unto a nothing-between relationship. If we follow the pattern of Christ, there is no room for discrimination against any believer regardless of his race, environment, heritage, and ability (1 Cor. 1:26-28).

Finally, this mutual receiving of one another into a close caring relationship results in the glory of God. The reason believing Gentiles and Jews are to have a close reciprocal relationship with one another is not an end in itself, but for the spiritual benefits it produces, such as the maintaining of the unity of the Spirit, which *glorifies God* (Eph. 4:3-16). To glorify God is to magnify His *weightiness, majesty*, and *sovereign Person.*

8. ***"For I say that Christ has been made a minister of the circumcision on behalf of the truth of God, unto the end to confirm the promises of the fathers,"***

The main Greek verb in this verse is in the aorist tense and passive voice. It succinctly states the fact that God the Father *has made* (γεγενησθαι), *constituted*, and *established* Christ a minister of the circumcision. In other words, Christ did not assume this position Himself, but it was bestowed upon Him by God the Father.

Now let us examine the fact that Christ was made "α minister of the circumcision." The Greek noun translated "minister" (διακονον) basically means one who *serves, waits on*, or *attends others*. Paul commonly uses this word with reference to himself and those teaching and preaching the gospel with him. In the verse before us He uses it with this same general meaning; Christ was a *minister, teacher,* and *preacher* of the Gospel of the kingdom proclaimed to the Jews (Matt. 4:17, 23; 10:25).

Those to whom Christ ministered are called the "circumcision" (περιτομης). The covenant which God made with Abraham included the rite of circumcision (Genesis 17:10-11; Rom. 4:11). Since Abraham's seed, the Jews, practiced circumcision, in process of time this word became their proper name (Gal. 2:9).

The reason Christ was made a minister of the circumcision was "on behalf of the truth of God." The basic meaning of the preposition "υπερ" is *on behalf of, for the sake of,* and *concerning* the truth of God. What does the phrase "the truth of

God" (αληθειας θεου) mean as used in this context? The final statement in this verse makes it clear that what Paul has in mind is Old Testament truth which pertains to the prophesied Messianic Kingdom. Jesus proclaimed this truth in the Synoptic gospels (cf. Matt. 22:16; 3:2; 4:23; 9:25). This same truth is also the message of the first eight chapters in the Book of Acts (3:18-26).

The primary object of Jesus Christ's earthly ministry was not to bring into being a spiritual organism, the Church, but "to confirm the promises of the fathers." In Genesis 12:1-3 God promises Abraham that he will be the progenitor of a great nation and that in him all the families of the earth will be blessed. As the prophetic Old Testament unfolds, it is obvious that this blessing will come via the establishment of a righteous kingdom upon the earth over which one in the lineage of David will reign (Psa. 22:27-28; 145:11-13; Isa. 32:1; 33:17-22; Jer. 23:5-8).

9. ***"and the Gentiles on behalf of mercy to glorify God; even as it has been written,* On account of this I will confess you among the Gentiles, and I will sing to your name."**

Before we can accurately exegete the truth from this verse, we must recognize that it expands Christ's ministry to include the Gentiles. The flow of thought through these two verses seems to be as follows: Christ is a minister of the Jews on behalf of the truth of God to fulfill the promises, and He is a minister of the Gentiles on behalf of the mercy of God.

On the basis of the promises God had made to the forefathers of the Jews, He obligated Himself to send Christ as a special minister unto them, i.e., to establish the promised Kingdom, which has been temporarily rejected. Likewise, in the present Church age, on the basis of the fact that God predestined and foreordained individuals to be saved, He obligated Himself to also send Christ to minister to Gentiles.

Now that Christ's earthly ministry, including the Cross, was rejected by Israel in the first seven chapters of the Book of Acts, God in His grace saved Saul of Tarsus preparatory to revealing the Truth for the Church. Christ's Church ministry to individual Gentiles, as we have it in this verse, does not begin until after the climactic death of Stephen, and even then it gradually replaces the Kingdom message.

It is exceedingly important that we grasp the significance of the word "mercy" (ελεους) in this verse. First, it is inseparable from the love of God; in fact, love is its forerunner (Eph. 2:4). Second, it is the basis for God's redemptive program in this present dispensation of Grace. Sinners are not saved by their human wills nor by their human works, but as a result of the mercy of God (9:16). During this age of Grace God declares that all Jews and Gentiles are disobedient; they are sinners. But the good news is that He has mercy on all (11:32).

Whereas verse 8 pertains to the presentation and offer of the Messianic Kingdom to the nation of Israel, the truth in verse 9 is pertinent for both individual Jews and Gentiles. According to Titus 3:5 God "saved us according to his mercy." As a

result of God saving us by His mercy, we are *made capable* "to glorify" (δοξασαι) Him and *have something* for which to glorify Him, namely, our eternal salvation in Christ (cf. 9:23-24).

In the Book of Ephesians Paul says that the Gentiles are "fellow-citizens with the saints and the family of God." He cites the Mystery revealed unto him as his authority for saying that the Gentiles are on a par with the Jews in the Body of Christ (Eph. 2:19; 3:2-9). In the verse before us Paul quotes portions from the Old Testament which indicate that the Gentiles will share with the Lord's people, Israel. We suggest that he is using this evidence to *corroborate* truth revealed to him via the Mystery, particularly, to allay Jewish feeling against Gentile Body members.

The portion of the quotation which appears in this ninth verse conveys the thought that the name of the Lord will be openly confessed among the Gentiles, and His name will be the object of singing.

10. ***"And again He says,* You rejoice, Gentiles, with his people."**

The main reason for quoting this passage is because it depicts a happy union between the Gentiles and Jews. It would be hard for the Jewish believer, even though prejudiced, to refute this kind of corroborating evidence.

11. ***"And again,* Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles, and let all the people praise him."**

This quotation is apparently taken from Psalm 117:1. It is an exhortation for all Gentiles and all peoples to praise the Lord. Since God is the one ordering the Gentiles to praise the Lord, even a cynical Jew would be hard-pressed to refute it.

12. ***"And again Isaiah says,* There shall be the root of Jesse, even the one who rises up to rule the Gentiles; on him the Gentiles will hope."**

This quotation comes from Isaiah 11:10. The thought here is that one in David's lineage will rule the Gentiles, namely, Christ, in whom the Gentiles will place their hope. Let us remember, Paul began this series of quotations from the Old Testament to *confirm* Christ's ministry to the elect among the Gentiles (2 Tim. 2:10). He ends the series with the declaration that Christ will ultimately rule over the Gentiles and that He will be the object of their hope. Even though these quotations primarily refer to the part the Gentiles will have in Christ's world-wide earthly Kingdom, Paul also uses them in a secondary manner to affirm that the Gentiles are an important part of God's people, the Church, during this time of the "fullness of the Gentiles" (11:25).

13. ***"And may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace while believing, unto the end that you may abound in the hope in the power of the Holy Spirit."***

The concept of *hope* is introduced in the preceding verse, as it speaks of Christ being the hope of the Gentiles, and it becomes the central theme of this verse. The Greek noun translated "hope" (ελπιδος) is the *object* of that which we

anticipate, expect, and *hope for.* The word hope, when looked at as a noun, is not something which is elusive, but it has *essence* and *substance* (Heb. 11:1).

This verse speaks of God as "the God of hope," or if we translate the article which is before "hope" (της ελπιδος), we would have "the God of the hope." The basic thought is the hope that *belongs to God*; i.e., it is something which He owns and possesses. We raise the question: What is this substantive entity, described as *hope*, which belongs to God? We believe the answer is found in Titus 2:13, where Paul says, "Looking for the blessed hope and appearance of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ." Our God is the *God of the hope, the Blessed Hope*, which is the coming of Jesus Christ for His Church.

The verb translated "fill" (πληρωσαι) is in the optative mood. This means that Paul is uttering a *prayer*: May the God of the hope fill you with all joy and peace while believing. The implication is that joy and peace are not something which we acquire through our human efforts, but rather that which *God gives to us* through the agency of the Holy Spirit (Gal. 5:22).

Note how our translation picks up on the temporal meaning of the Greek phrase "εν τω πιστευειν." Paul's prayer is that *during the time* or *while* they continue believing, they may have joy and peace. The implication is that, even though true believers will always believe, they may not always enjoy the fullness of joy and peace while they believe.

Paul's prayer climaxes with the petition that they may "abound" (περισσευειν), *superabound,* and *go over the top* "in the hope" (εν τη ελπιδι), and that they may do this "in the power of the Holy Spirit" or "by means of the power of the Holy Spirit." This verse certainly emphasizes our need to have a Biblical, confident, and unwavering hope in Christ's imminent coming for His Church. We are to hold this hope as we serve and minister in the power of the Holy Spirit (cf. 1 Thess. 1:9-10).

14. ***"And I myself have been persuaded concerning you, my brethren, that also you yourselves are full of goodness, having been filled with all the knowledge, being able also to admonish one another."***

In the preceding context Paul has been instructing each believer to act in a manner which will not hinder the spiritual progress of other believers. He also tells Jewish and Gentile believers to mutually receive one another in a gracious manner which will glorify God (v. 7). In this verse he emphasizes their need to have a *positive influence* on one another through a mutual admonishing ministry.

Now let us examine Paul's statement: "I myself have been persuaded concerning you, my brethren, that also you yourselves are full of goodness." The Greek phrase translated "I myself" (αυτος εγω) emphasizes that the *Apostle Paul himself*, on the basis of what he knew about them, was persuaded that they had the essential qualities for admonishing one another.

The Greek verb translated "I have been persuaded" (πεπεισμαι) is in the perfect tense and passive voice. This means that Paul *had been and continued to be*

persuaded, convinced, and confident "concerning" (περι) or with respect to them. The passive voice indicates that this was not a self-incited persuasion, but that the Spirit of God had convinced Paul that they were competent to admonish themselves.

The thought presented here is that God had persuaded Paul that the Roman believers have the basic prerequisites for an effective admonishing ministry. First, with respect to their *moral standing*, they "are full of goodness" (μεστοι εστε αγαθωσυνης), *excellence*, and *beneficence*. This characteristic is listed as a fruit of the Spirit in Galatians 5:22. Second, with regard to their *understanding* of God's Word for this present Church age, they have been "filled with all the knowledge." The use of the perfect participle in the passive voice indicates that they were believers who *had* and *continued to be* filled with all "the knowledge" (της γνωσεως) given to the Church at that point in time. The use of the Greek article before the Greek noun translated *knowledge* implies that Paul has in mind a specific body of knowledge, the Mystery Truth deposited with him, which he calls "my gospel" (2:16; 16:25).

As believers who have been morally and intellectually equipped by the Spirit of God through the Word of God, Paul speaks of them as "being able also to admonish one another." The Greek participle translated "being able" (δυναμενοι) means that they are believers who have the *ability, strength*, and *dynamic* to admonish one another. The Greek infinitive translated "admonish" (νουθετειν) is in the present tense, which implies that they are continuously to *put the Word of God in the minds of each other, to exhort,* and *to warn one another.* According to Colossians 2:28, Paul himself majored in "admonishing every man and teaching every man in all wisdom," that he might present every man perfect in Christ (cf. Col. 3:16; 1 Thess. 5:12).

15. ***"I have written more boldly to you on some parts, as reminding you again, because of the grace given to me by God,"***

Let us closely examine this verse that we might grasp what Paul is saying in it. First, as indicated by the aorist tense, he is apparently speaking of that which he *has written* in the previous context. Second, the Greek adverb translated "more boldly" (τολμηποτερον) is a comparative form and means that he wrote unto them *more daringly* or possibly even *more freely*.

The Greek phrase translated "on some parts" (απο μερουσ) is used five times by Paul. Basically it means *a part from*, hence, *a part of something,* i.e., a part of what he has written. What Paul is saying is that he wrote *more boldly on some* points than he did on others. In other words, some things he wrote were informative, but in other parts he boldly and daringly demanded action.

The reason Paul was very bold when he wrote certain parts was because he had to *remind them again*, at least a second time, to carry out certain orders. The Greek participle translated "reminding again" (επαναμιμνησκων) is in the present tense and means that he was *mentioning again* and *calling to their*

attention again things which he had previously communicated to them. A second or third reminder naturally calls forth greater boldness.

The reason Paul was reminding them again was because of the grace of God given to him by God. As the key apostle of the Church, the Body of Christ, Paul had given to him, by grace, the dispensation of Grace (1 Cor. 9:17; Eph. 3:2). In the fulfilling of this ministry he had no choice but to speak and write boldly when the occasion demanded it. His heart's desire was to correct believers by the principle of love, but when this failed to get the proper response, he used a disciplinary rod (1 Cor. 4:21).

16. ***"unto the end to be a minister of Christ Jesus unto the Gentiles, ministering the gospel of God, that the offering of the Gentiles might be acceptable, having been sanctified by the Holy Spirit."***

This verse is a continuation of the preceding one. The grace which God gave to Paul was unto the end that he might be "a minister of Christ Jesus unto the Gentiles." Furthermore, James, Peter and John recognized that God had given to Paul a special ministry to the Gentiles (Gal. 2:7-9). The fact that Paul was given this Gentile ministry does not exclude him from having a ministry unto the Jews. In fact, his early ministry was primarily directed to the Jews (1:16; Acts 1:6; 13:46; 18:6).

As a minister of the Gentiles Paul was "ministering the gospel of God." The Greek participle translated "ministering" (ιερουργουντα) is a compound word which literally speaks of one involved in *sacred-work.* It is interesting that it is used *only* of Paul here, the sacred-worker through whom the Mystery Truth for the Church was dispensed to the Gentiles (cf. Gal. 1:16; Eph. 3:1, 6, 8).

As a sacred-worker Paul was ministering "the gospel of God" (το ευαγγελιον του θεου). This phrase is used a total of eight times in the New Testament. Paul uses it six times: three times in First Thessalonians, twice in Romans, and once in Second Corinthians. This means that the phrase "the gospel of God" is limited to Paul's earlier epistles. We suggest that it primarily refers to the gospel in its *salvation aspect* (Eph. 1:13) rather than to its message regarding the Church (Col. 1:24-26).

As a minister of Jesus Christ to the Gentiles, it was Paul's purpose to fulfill his ministry so that "the offering of the Gentiles might be acceptable, having been sanctified by the Holy Spirit." He is looking at the Gentiles as an "offering" (προσφορα), *sacrifice*, or *oblation* which he is bringing to God. There were times when he had to speak boldly, frankly, and unsparingly, correcting evil situations in order that the redeemed Gentiles might be an "acceptable" (ευπροσδεκτος) and pleasing offering to God. Of course, for the Gentiles to be a quality offering, they had to be "sanctified" (ηγιασμενη) and *set apart* unto God by the Holy Spirit. This sanctification is in Christ, based upon His Blood, and effected by the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 1:2).

17. ***"Therefore I have boasting in Christ Jesus in the things pertaining to God."***

Many in Gospel work boast about what they have done. They keep an inflated record of the numbers who have professed faith as a result of their ministries. They also glory in the elusive numbers who have experienced some kind of a spiritual rejuvenation under their mighty preaching.

Much of what is going on today is very foreign when compared to the humble spirit of the Apostle Paul. Even though he is *the minister* of Christ unto the Gentiles, and the only one designated as a sacred-worker of the gospel of God, he is very careful to give Jesus Christ all the credit for what is accomplished. In view of what he said in verses 15-16 about his ministry to the Gentiles, and his *responsibility* to present them to God as a well-pleasing offering, he says that with respect to such things his boast is in Christ Jesus.

In exegeting this verse we observe that Paul's "boasting" (καυχησιν), *glorying*, and *bragging* is in the sphere of Christ Jesus. He in himself was totally incapable of producing anything with spiritual value (Rom. 7:14, 18-19). On the other hand, he had the ability to do all things in Christ who strengthened him (Phi1. 4:13; cf. 2 Tim. 2:1). Paul received both his Gospel and the power to proclaim it from Jesus Christ (Gal. 1:12; 1 Tim. 1:12); therefore he *boasted in Christ* for the success he had in his Gentile ministry. He gave credit to the one to whom it was due.

We need to examine more carefully the fact that Paul's boasting in Christ was "in the things pertaining to God" (τα προς τον θεον). Since the article translated "things" (τα) is in the neuter gender, the same as for the word "Gentiles" (εθνων) in the preceding verse, he apparently has in mind the offering of the Gentiles *to* or *before* the face of God. Granting that this offering would be in accordance with God's elective purpose, hence, acceptable and pleasing, Paul's boast would be in Christ who empowered him (2 Tim. 4:17).

18. ***"For I will not dare to speak of anything which Christ has not accomplished through me for the obedience of the Gentiles, by word and deed,"***

As Paul looks into the future he affirms that he will not "dare" (τολμησω), *have the audacity*, nor *be so presumptuous* as to speak of anything except that which Christ has "accomplished" (κατειργασατο), *worked out*, and *produced* through him unto the end of the obedience of the Gentiles. According to this statement Paul had *nothing* to say about anything he may have done in the flesh. To speak of anything which Christ had not produced through him would be profitless and nonedifying.

The specific emphasis of this verse is on what Christ produced via Paul "unto the obedience of the Gentiles." The Greek phrase translated the "obedience of the Gentiles" (υπακοην εθνων) is used in a fuller form two other times in this same epistle. In chapter 1:5 Paul says that he "received grace and apostleship unto obedience of faith among all the Gentiles." In chapter 16:26 he says that the mystery was manifested "unto the obedience of faith unto all the Gentiles." According to these parallel verses the *obedience of the Gentiles* may be interpreted to mean that they *hearkened* and *obeyed* in that they *believed the*

Gospel. We favor the interpretation, however, that the Greek word translated "faith" (πιστεως) refers to the *truth which constitutes the Gospel,* which they *listened to and obeyed*. Obedience to the truth of the Gospel would necessitate saving faith in the Gospel (Eph. 2:8).

Finally, we observe that Christ worked through Paul by both "word and deed" (λογω και εργω). This means that Christ was using both Paul's *speaking* (his teaching ministry), and his *working* (his good works), to fashion the Gentiles into a well-pleasing offering to God. He accurately proclaimed the Gospel of God's Grace after which he patterned his lifestyle (1 Cor. 11:1).

19. ***"in the power of signs and wonders, in the power of the Spirit of God; so that from Jerusalem and round about until Illyricum I have fully preached the gospel of Christ."***

This verse deals with Paul's preaching of the Gospel to the Gentiles. On the one hand, his preaching had associated with it the power of signs, wonders, and of the Spirit of God. On the other hand, he explains how extensively he had preached the Gospel, i.e., to all the area included in a large circle from Jerusalem to Illyricum.

Not only did Christ energize through Paul via what he said and did, but also "in the power of signs and wonders." The two Greek nouns translated "signs" (σημειων) and "wonders" (τερατων) are commonly used to depict the miraculous sign gifts (cf. Matt. 24:24; Acts 2:43; 5:12). Christ's performance of signs and wonders through Paul's early ministry was the norm, not the exception (cf. Acts 14:3; 15:12; 2 Cor. 12:12). We would reasonably expect these sign gifts to be in vogue during Paul's *early ministry* recorded in the Book of Acts, when the regal rights of Jesus of Nazareth, the Messiah, were being confirmed to Israel (Acts 2:30-36; 3:19-25; 7:37, 52, 56; 13:23-39; 17:7).

For approximately 1800 years God had accustomed His people, Israel, to look for signs and wonders as evidence of His working in their midst (cf. Matt. 12:38; Mark 16:17-18; 1 Cor. 1:22). During the Acts period the Messianic Kingdom was *offered to Israel* with accompanying signs (Acts 1:1-7:60). Subsequent to Israel's rejection of the Kingdom, which reached its climax in the killing of Stephen, God continued to *confirm to Israel*, through signs and wonders, the fact that Jesus of Nazareth was indeed *the Prophet* of whom Moses wrote, *the prophesied King* in the lineage of David, and *the Messiah*, the Anointed One who was to reign.

On the one hand, this confirmatory ministry to Israel continued until the end of the Book of Acts, when Israel as a nation, through her leaders in Rome, completed her ultimate rejection of Jesus as the Messiah the Anointed King (Acts 28:26-28). On the other hand, after Israel refused to acknowledge Jesus as her Messiah/King, epitomized in the death of Stephen, God begins to usher in a *new way* of bringing men into a relationship with Himself. Truth pertaining to the Messianic Kingdom increasingly fades away in the Book of Acts, while truth pertaining to the Church, the Body of Christ, increasingly occupies the stage with Paul its chief actor.

With the nation of Israel passing off the scene along with her associated signs and wonders, *the sign gifts ceased to exist*. Paul's predictions in First Corinthians 13:8 were fulfilled with the laying aside of Israel and with the ultimate revelation of Mystery Truth for the Church, perfection truth, as found in Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, etc. (cf. 1 Cor. 13:10).

We note also that Christ was energizing through Paul "in the power of the Spirit of God." We have the noun for "power" (δυναμει) used twice; once regarding the power of God which produced the signs and wonders and once with respect to the Holy Spirit's ministry to and through him (Eph. 3:16, 20). This power of the Spirit propelled Paul on to preach the gospel of Christ from Jerusalem to a large circle as far west as Illyricum, i.e., to the east side of the Adriatic Sea, a country north of Macedonia (cf. 2 Tim. 4:10).

20. ***"And thus I am ambitious to preach the gospel not where Christ has been named, in order that I might not build upon another's foundation;"***

In the preceding two verses (18-19) Paul recounts the *kind* of a ministry Christ wrought through him and the territory it covered. In this verse he is speaking about his present objectives - to preach Christ in the unevangelized areas.

This verse opens with the Greek adverb translated "thus" (ουτως), which means that *in the same manner* and way as he previously strove to preach the gospel to the regions beyond, he is Now "ambitious" (φιλοτιμουμενον), *striving eagerly,* and *earnestly aspiring* to preach the gospel to those who have never had the opportunity to hear about Christ.

The Greek phrase translated "not where Christ has been named" (ουχ οπου ωνομασθη χριστος) means where Christ has *not been mentioned, made known,* or *proclaimed.* Paul's emphasis in this portion of his letter to the Roman believers is on *evangelistic outreach.* Even though there was already a church at Rome, or groups of believers who constituted a church, for several years he had longed to go there. He apparently looked at Rome, in comparison to Asia, Macedonia, and Greece, as a place where Christ needed to be named. In view of its importance - the capital of the Roman Empire and its size - Rome was tops in priority on Paul's missionary schedule.

The reason Paul gives for not wanting to preach the gospel where Christ has been named was, in his words, "in order that I might not build upon another's foundation." According to First Corinthians 3:10, Paul says, "According to the grace of God that has been given to me, as a wise masterbuilder I laid a foundation." Furthermore, he adds that "no one is able to lay another foundation beyond that laid" (v. 11). These verses make it clear that *God gave the foundation message to Paul,* and no one is able to 1αγ beside it or beyond it another foundation. This means that the foundation given to Paul, salvation by grace through faith in Jesus Christ, is exclusive and leaves no room for any other foundation (Eph. 2:8).

Why does Paul shun building upon another's foundation? Is it because he considered it needless duplication, or is it because in many instances he had

found such foundations unaligned and inadequate in the light of God's word for today?

We raise a further question: is the way this verse is commonly translated, to which we have acquiesced, correct? The two Greek words translated "another's foundation" (αλλοτριον θεμελιον) are both in the singular accusative case, and may logically be translated *another foundation* or *a foreign foundation*. The issue is whether we should interpret the Greek word "αλλοτριον" as a possessive pronoun, when it is not in the genitive case of possession, or as an adjective modifying the word translated foundation, i.e., as *another foundation.*

We must not forget that all who mentioned, made known, and proclaimed Christ's name did not do it sincerely, but some did it out of envy and strife, trying to stir up increased affliction against the Apostle Paul (Phil. 1:15, 17). Most of these were probably Judaizers or those infected by them, who were laying destructive foundations foreign to the grace/faith foundation given to Paul. As a man of peace Paul's mode of operation was to avoid and circumvent controversy when possible (cf. 2 Tim. 2:14, 16, 23; Titus 3:9). By the time he writes to the Romans, his strategy may have been to avoid areas where Christ was antagonistically named, where Judaistic/Messianic foundations were already laid (cf. Acts 15:1, 5, 24; Gal. 1:6-9).

At the beginning of Paul's ministry the Judaizers were *following* him, so he had to defend his converts against their grace-destroying error (Galatians). It is logical to think that with the passing of time these Judaistic zealots *pre-poisoned* certain areas against Paul's Grace message, which he avoided at that time, since there were many other areas open to the foundation he was laying - salvation by grace through faith in Jesus Christ.

In conclusion, in the light of the grammatical construction of this verse we have felt obligated to present the above interpretations. Regardless of which interpretation you may prefer, the central thrust of this verse is clear, Paul's ambition was to preach the Gospel *to those who had never heard the name of Christ.* Focusing on the evangelistic aspect of his ministry, where a good foundation of Grace through faith in Jesus Christ had been laid, it was not his purpose as an evangelist to build upon it. Furthermore, where the name of Christ was hostilely proclaimed and an erroneous Judaistic/Messianic foundation had been laid, at that point in time he preferred to avoid direct conflict, and desired to go where they had never heard of Christ.

21. ***"but even as it has been written,*** **To whom it was not announced concerning him, they shall see, and those who have not heard, shall understand."**

Paul's emphasis in the preceding verse was that he aspired to preach the Gospel where Christ was not yet named. This quotation, which he cites from the Old Testament, obviously refers primarily to the Gentiles. This suggests that his focus on areas where Christ was not named would be a focus on unreached Gentiles. This, of course, is in keeping with the main theme of this context, that he is a "minister of Christ Jesus unto the Gentiles" (vv. 16-18).

As Paul uses this quotation, the implication is not that apart from learning and hearing about Christ the Gentiles will see and understand. The thought that he is eagerly striving to preach the Gospel to them clearly indicates that their spiritual sight and understanding *comes through hearing the Gospel of God's Grace*. As he uses this quotation, his main point is that the Gentiles who have not had Christ announced to them or have not heard about Him will receive spiritual seeing and understanding having heard the Gospel. This quotation must not be interpreted to mean that God will sovereignly give the Gentiles spiritual sight and understanding apart from the Gospel. The Gospel is God's medium through which He gives this knowledge.

22. ***"Wherefore also I was hindered many times from coming to you."***

In the first chapter, verse 10, we first learn about Paul's strong desire to go to Rome. He says, "always in my prayers, petitioning if already somehow I may be given a prosperous journey in the will of God to come to you." In the 13th verse he adds, "and I do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, that many times I purposed to come to you, and was hindered until Now, that I might have some fruit also among you even as also among the rest of the Gentiles."

The Greek word translated "wherefore" (διο) indicates that as a consequence of what Paul has said he was "hindered" (ενεκοπτομην), something *cut in, impeded* and *interrupted* his plans to visit them. The Greek phrase translated "many times" (τα πολλα) suggests that on several occasions his plans to go to them were interrupted. It appears that for some time Paul had conveyed to them the thought that he would soon be visiting them, and they were eagerly looking forward to seeing him, but when he failed to arrive some were wondering how much he really cared about them. It appears that Paul becomes a little defensive on this issue.

23. ***"But now no longer having a place in these regions, and having an earnest desire for many years to come to you,"***

As Paul writes this epistle the time has come when he "no longer" (μηκετι), *not still*, and *not yet* has a *place* in the general area from which he is writing. It is probable that he was writing from Corinth; however, according to verse 19 the regions he speaks of most likely include the large circle from Jerusalem to Illyricum.

What does Paul mean by the statement that he no longer has a "place" (τοπον), *an opportunity*, or *viable population centers* to reach? Is he declaring that in approximately ten years he has adequately taught the Word of God to this vast area? No, of course not, but he is telling us something about the *kind of a ministry* the Lord had given unto him, the Apostle Paul. We must keep in mind that this ministry was given unto him as the chief apostle of the Church. He had a unique message to proclaim to as many as possible within a *very limited time*. As we observed above, in this context Paul portrays himself as an *evangelist*, one who is ambitious to preach the Gospel to those who have never heard it.

This must not be interpreted to mean that every city, village, and hamlet had been evangelized in the vast region including Samaria, Syria, Galatia, Asia, Macedonia, Achaia, etc., but rather that those who wanted to hear the Gospel had an opportunity to do so directly or indirectly. For example, as a result of Paul's ministry in Ephesus, "all those living in Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks" (Acts 19:10). Furthermore, the fact that Paul has a great deal to say about open doors implies that he did not consider closed-door places viable options; hence, he was ready to move on (1 Cor. 16:9; 2 Cor. 2:12; Col. 4:3).

Again, Paul recounts his "earnest desire" (επιποθιαν) and *strong longing* to see the Roman believers. He has had this longing "for many years" (απο πολλων ετων). The grammatical construction suggests that as Paul thought back many years, *from that time* he has harbored a very affectionate longing to visit them.

In conclusion, Paul was a *teaching evangelist*, ministering to those who had never heard the Gospel. As a result of his ministry, churches needed to be established to nurture the converts, a job which he left to others, giving help and direction as necessary. As an evangelist, he focuses on the unsaved, lost sinners. On the other hand, as Paul writes his epistles to the churches he assumes the role of a *teacher of believers.* Thus we see, Paul had two ministries: When on the front lines, he was a *persuasive teaching evangelist;* i.e., he used solid Biblical teaching to persuade the lost to acknowledge Jesus Christ as their Saviour (Acts 13:16-48). When writing, he was a *teacher* of teachers, of leaders, and of all believers (1 Cor. 1:2; Phil. 1:1; Col. 1:2; 1 Tim. 1:2).

24. ***"whenever I go unto Spain; for I hope while passing through to see you and by you to be sent forth there, if I may be partially filled by you first,"***

The only two times Paul expresses his purpose to go to Spain are in this verse and in verse 28. We have no evidence in the New Testament indicating that Paul went to Spain. Between the time he wrote this epistle and actually arrived in Rome, many uncalculated things took place. These certainly changed his plans. Even though he did finally arrive in Rome, it was as a prisoner, which made the carrying out of his original plan impossible. If he did get to Spain it would have been after he was released from his Roman imprisonment; however, these are enigmatical, silent years, not in the Book of Acts.

Paul's original plan was to go to Spain via Rome and stopover in Rome for a brief visit, trusting that they would be able to pay his expenses to Spain, i.e., if first he is partially filled and satisfied with them.

Now that we have given an overview of Paul's plans, let us more carefully exegete just what this verse says. Note that he does not say what he is going to do, but rather what he "hopes" (ελπιζω), *expects*, and *anticipates* doing. His original hope was that "while passing through" (διαπορευομενος), *going through,* and *passing* by, he expected to "see" (θεασασθαι), *gaze upon,* and *visit* them face to face. It is one thing to hear about fellow believers, but it is a much more

meaningful experience to be able to gaze empathetically and compassionately into their eyes, knowing that you are joint heirs of Christ (8:17).

In the Greek phrase rendered "by you to be sent forth" (υφ' υμων προπεμφθηναι), the use of the passive voice with the preposition "υφ" (by) clearly indicates that Paul expected them to send him forth to Spain. The translation "to be sent forth" (προπεμφθηναι) is the most accurate rendering of this aorist passive infinitive.

The last clause in this verse is difficult, which is seen in the varied translations of it. We believe our translation is a good compromise between slavish literalness and readability, namely, "if I may be partially filled by you first." Another translation, which follows the word order in the Greek, would be, *if of you first partially I may be filled*. It is difficult to pin down exactly what Paul means by the genitive pronoun translated "of you" (υμων). Does he mean that he will be sent forth to Spain by them: 1) if he is first partially filled of them, i.e., of *what they are,* of their fellowship; or 2) if he is first partially filled with *that which belongs to them,* i.e., of the things which they own? In other words, is Paul talking about them sharing with him *themselves*, or sharing with him their possessions? In the light of the context and his need for support to go to Spain, we prefer the latter interpretation.

25. ***"but now I go unto Jerusalem, ministering to the saints."***

Back in Acts 11:28-29 Agabas predicted that a famine was coming. As a result believers determined to send an offering unto the brethren in Judea. As Paul had contact with the various churches, he shared with them the physical needs of the saints in Judea. Many responded liberally and raised a sizeable offering for the famine stricken brethren (2 Cor. 8:1-8; 9:1-5). According to Second Corinthians 8:16-24, Paul and others approved by the churches will take this contribution to Jerusalem and Judea.

Paul did not look forward to this trip to Jerusalem as a happy reunion with the brethren there, for he says in Acts 20:22, "And behold Now having been bound in spirit I go unto Jerusalem, and the things which shall happen to me in it, I do not know." One of the reasons for Paul's concern is expressed in the next verse, namely, "Because the Holy Spirit testifies to me in every city, saying the bonds and afflictions await me" (v. 23).

Finally, Paul was going unto Jerusalem for the purpose of "ministering to the saints." The Greek participle translated "ministering" (διακονων) is in the present tense, and in this context, primarily refers to his serving the saints in helping meet their physical needs. But secondarily, I am sure that his greatest burden for them was in the spiritual sphere, sharing with them the Gospel of Grace (10:1-4).

26. ***"For Macedonia and Achaia were pleased to make a certain contribution unto the poor of the saints in Jerusalem."***

Macedonia is a relatively large country lying north of Greece. It included the key New Testament cities of Philippi, Thessalonica and Beroea. Achaia is Greece and included the New Testament cities of Athens, Corinth and Cenchreae. If all

the churches in Macedonia and Achaia, which are mentioned in the New Testament, shared in this offering, it would include the churches at Philippi, Thessalonica, Beroea, Corinth and Cenchreae. There may have also been churches at Nicopolis (Titus 3:12) and Athens (Acts 17:34) which contributed.

In this verse Paul says that the contribution from the churches was for "the poor" (τους πτωχους), *indigent*, and *impoverished* saints in Jerusalem. We have already suggested that famine conditions contributed to this poverty. There is another factor which also may have contributed toward this poverty, and that is the premature practicing of Kingdom conditions, having all things in common (Acts 2:44; 4:32). This certainly involved a magnanimous spirit on the part of the wealthy, sharing what they had with the poor, but it was devastating to private enterprise, depriving it of the capital needed to produce wealth. True, the poor will always be with us (Matt. 26:11), but this premature selling of properties and businesses must have greatly aggravated the situation (Acts 4:34-37).

27. ***"For they were pleased, and they are debtors of them; for if the Gentiles have shared in their spiritual things, they also are indebted to minister to them in carnal things."***

Paul opens this verse by reaffirming the fact that the Macedonian and Achaian believers "were pleased" (ηυδοκησαν), *delighted*, and *gratified* for the opportunity to contribute to the poor in Jerusalem. He immediately gives a reason for why they should be pleased, because "they are debtors of them," i.e., of the poor Jews to whom they have contributed. The Greek noun translated "debtors" (οφειλεται) means that the Gentiles *owe, are obligated*, and *have a debt to pay* to those who are now poor.

Paul now proceeds to explain how the Gentiles incurred this debt to the Jews. If they are Gentile believers, then it follows that they have "shared" (εκοινωνησαν) and *participated* in the "spiritual things" (τοις πνευματικοις), which are spiritual rather than carnal, which belong to the Jews. God has made the Jews the custodians of the Old Testament (3:2; 9:4). He has also made a Jew, the Apostle Paul, the central custodian of the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24; Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9). As Gentiles, we must keep in mind that the message of both the Old and New Testaments has come down to us through the Jews (John 4:22). Furthermore, the one in whom we have salvation is the Son of David, the Son of Abraham, and the Son of God (Matt. 1:1; Luke 3:31-38). Furthermore, we recognize that the same Truth deposited with Paul also comes down to us through the writings of Peter and John, two Jews.

In view of the spiritual heritage which God has passed on to us Gentiles through the Jews, we are "indebted" (οφειλουσιν), *obligated*, and *bound* to minister to their carnal needs. The Greek phrase translated "carnal things" (τοις σαρκικοις) refers to the things pertaining to the flesh, to the physical body, and to what is essential for earthly existence.

Summarizing, through the Jews God has given to us the essential ingredient, the Gospel of His Grace, for initiating and sustaining our spiritual-life relationship with

Himself. Through the saved Gentiles it is God's purpose to minister to the physical-life needs of the poor Jews, thus enabling the Gentiles to pay their debt owed to the Jews.

28. ***"Therefore having completed this, and having sealed to them this fruit, I shall go through you unto Spain."***

Keep in mind that the main subject of our context is the Gentile-believer offering which Paul and others are taking to Jerusalem to the poor saints. When they "have completed" (επιτελεσας), *brought to an end*, and *safely delivered* this offering, and when they "have sealed" (σφραγισαμενος), *received a mark of acceptance*, and *delivered safely* the offering to those responsible for it, then Paul says, "I shall go through you unto Spain." Putting it simply, when Paul and company have delivered the offering and received a proper receipt for the same, then he will get ready for his trip to Spain, which will take him "through" (δια with the genitive) Rome.

29. ***"I know that coming to you, I shall come in the fulness of the blessing of Christ.*** "

After having planned to go to Rome several times, but having been hindered hitherto, Paul is Now confident that his proposed coming will be in the "blessing" (ευλογιας); i.e., it will have the *approval* and *praise* of Christ. We recognize that he expressed this confidence in the midst of uncertainty, for he was fully aware of the fact that he had enemies in Jerusalem (vv. 30-31). As we look back, we know that the worst did happen; his enemies apprehended him in the temple and were bent on killing him (Acts 21:27-31; 23:12-15).

From the first attempt of the Jews to kill Paul until after he was released from prison in Rome, he was under the protection of the Roman government; prison was his asylum. The Roman government not only protected him from his own countrymen, but it also provided a free trip for him to Rome. We know that in Rome he had the freedom to rent his own dwelling and to receive all those coming to him (Acts 28:30). Furthermore, for two years he had the liberty to preach and teach the Gospel of Jesus Christ in an unhindered, bold manner (Acts 28:31). We assume that during this time he had the opportunity to meet most of the believers in Rome and undoubtedly spend more time with them than his original schedule would have permitted (vv. 24, 28).

30. ***"And I exhort you, brethren, through our Lord Jesus Christ and through the love of the Spirit, to strive together with me in your prayers to God for me,"***

Paul "exhorts" (παρακαλω), *beseeches, urges* and *encourages* them to pray for him. He makes this plea "through" (δια), *through the agency of* our Lord Jesus Christ. This is in keeping with the fact that all prayer is to be couched *through* (16:27) or *in* (Eph. 5:20) the name of Jesus Christ. Also, he makes this same plea *through the agency* of the love of the Spirit, i.e., the love which the Spirit produces (Gal. 5:22). It appears that Paul is urging believers, through the love which the Spirit has implanted in them, to strive in prayer to God for him.

The Greek infinitive translated "strive" (συναγωνισασθαι) means that Paul wants them to *agonize* and *struggle* with him in prayer to God on his behalf. Observe that this prayer is to be directed to God the Father, not to Jesus Christ, an important truth which is clearly taught in the Scriptures.

31. ***"that I may be delivered from those disobedient in Judea, and that my ministry for Jerusalem may be acceptable to the saints; "***

In the preceding verse Paul encouraged believers to strive with him in prayers to God on his behalf. This verse sets forth the reason he is soliciting prayer, that he "may be delivered from those disobedient in Judea." The Greek verb translated "delivered" (ρυσθω) means that he *may be dragged* and *rescued* away "from" (απο) "those disobedient" (των απειθουτων), *uncompliant* and *refusing to believe*. This word basically speaks of those who are unpersuaded, hence, disobedient. In some contexts its meaning may verge on the idea of unbelief; i.e., Paul wanted prayer that he might be delivered from the unbelieving in Jerusalem. Unbelief in God leads to disobedience to God (cf. John 3:36).

Furthermore, Paul urged believers to strive with him in their prayers that his "ministry for Jerusalem may be acceptable to the saints." After having knocked himself out to raise this offering, why wouldn't it be "acceptable" (ευποσδεκτος) and *pleasing* to the saints? Did he feel that some might be dissatisfied with the amount of the offering? Whatever his concern, it was a priority on his prayer list. We probably have a positive answer to this prayer in the statement: "We having come unto Jerusalem the brethren received us gladly" or joyfully (Acts 21:17). It would be exciting to have a record of all that was said at this meeting, but we don't, and I presume that the brevity served the Holy Spirit's purpose.

32. ***"that in joy having come to you through the will of God I may find rest with you. "***

In addition to the above, Paul encouraged believers to strive with him in their prayers that he may come to them in "joy" (χαρα), *gladness,* and *rejoicing.* Even though he was continuously persecuted and had a price on his head, he uses this word for joy some 23 times in his epistles. He looked at joy as that which primarily depended on a right relationship with God rather than upon physical circumstances. It is listed as the second fruit of the Spirit in Galatians 5:22. It is one of three things which characterize the kingdom of God, namely, "righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit" (14:17). Again we emphasize, joy is not something which we generate within ourselves, but that with which *God fills us* by His Spirit while we believe (15:13).

We observe further, Paul's prayer is that his coming to them with joy may be through the "will of God" (θεληματος), i.e., in accordance with what God *designs* and *resolves*. His being in the will of God would be a prerequisite to his being filled with the joy of God via the Spirit - the result of a harmonious relationship with God (cf. 1:10).

We have translated the main verbal phrase of this verse, as "I may find rest with you." This is a triple compound verb, and the parts which compose it mean to

rest-up-with; hence, it may be rendered to *rest-together-with.* Paul is looking forward to the time when God will grant him the privilege of having a refreshing rest-together-with the Roman believers (cf. 1:12). This is the only time this verb is used in the New Testament; however, it is used in the classical Greek with the idea of resting-with in sleep. The thought could well be that after his long trip to Rome he anticipated a time with them to get rested up before leaving for Spain.

33. ***"And the God of peace be with you all. Amen."***

The Apostle Paul refers to God as the "God of Peace" (θεος της ειρηνης) some seven times in his epistles (including Hebrews). This suggests that "peace" (ειρηνης), *harmony*, *concord* and *unity* are prime characteristics of God. He is the Creator and Sustainer of an unfathomable universe, the parts of which are perfectly synchronized and function in harmony with each other.

Twelve times peace is spoken of as coming *from God* (απο θεου) in the Pauline Epistles. In other words, He is the *source* from which peace emanates to all believers. Even as He is the God of peace, likewise, as His children, we are to be characterized by peace. Drawing upon the peace which God graciously makes available to us, we have the potential to be at peace *within ourselves* and *with one another.* Speaking of fellow members in the Colossian church, Paul says, "Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, unto which you were called in one body" (Col. 3:15).

We need to recognize that when Paul expressed his desire that the God of peace would be with the Roman believers, he himself was facing disbelieving, disobedient men who were bent on murdering him (Acts 21:31). On this side of the Adamic curse God provides peace for His elect, while Satan, on the other hand, continually attacks them (Eph. 6:11).

Chapter 16

1. ***"I commend unto you Phoebe our sister, also being a servant of the church in Cenchrea,"***

The Greek verb translated "commend" (συνιστημι) basically means *to stand with*, hence, *to commend* or *recommend*. Since this is the only time this name appears in the New Testament, all that we know about Phoebe is in this and the following verse. Paul refers to her as "our sister" (την αδελφην ημων). The plural pronoun *our* implies that she is the spiritual sister of all believers.

Paul uses the present participle "ουσαν," which we have translated *being*, to describe Phoebe's position in the church at Cenchrea. The thought is that she is existing as a "servant" (διακονον), *minister*, or *a deacon* of this church. Since this Greek noun translated servant is the same form for both men and women and the word *deacon* is a transliteration of it, we correctly designate Phoebe as a *deacon* or a *minister*.

Since there is a great deal of haziness regarding the meaning of " διακονον," commonly transliterated deacon, let us consider some of the persons it commonly designates in the New Testament. It is used to designate Jesus Christ (Rom. 15:8), the greatest of the Twelve Disciples (Mark 10:43), Paul (Eph. 3:7), Tychicus (Eph. 6:21), Epaphras (Col. 1:7), and Timothy (1 Thes. 3:2). As used with the above persons the best English equivalent is the noun *minister* primarily in the spiritual category.

What evidence is there to support the view that deacons (διακονοι) constitute a group who govern a local church or assembly? First, Acts 6:1-6 does not apply to a local church; second, Philippians 1:1 leaves it open for them to be merely ministers; third, First Timothy 3:8-13 specifies qualifications but says nothing about what they do. The evidence does not justify going beyond the fact that "διακονοι" were involved in ministries in conjunction with local assemblies or beyond them. Possibly they were teaching ministries such as home Bible classes, etc.

Since the elders and overseers appear to be the main ones ruling and instructing within the local churches (1 Tim. 3:1-6; 5:17; Titus 1:5-9), we logically ask the question: where do the "διακονοι" have a place? In the light of the evidence, Phoebe apparently served and ministered in conjunction with the church at Cenchrea, but not necessarily on some kind of deacon board.

2. ***"that you receive her in the Lord in a manner worthy of the saints, and you provide for her in whatever matter she may have need of you, for also she has been a helper of many and of me myself."***

The context implies that Phoebe was going to take a trip from Cenchrea, Greece, to the city of Rome. Paul does not give us any details regarding this trip, but he

indicates that she will be spending some time with the believers there, and that they should generously provide for all her needs.

Paul instructs them to "receive her in the Lord in a manner worthy of the saints." The Greek verb translated "receive" (προσδεξησθε) suggests that they are to *accept* and *entertain* her as a guest in the Lord. As a member of the Body of Christ, the Family of God (Eph. 2:19), she is their sister (v. 1).

We must keep in mind that when Paul was writing this epistle, women did not have the same privileges they have today. This may well be the reason he asks them to receive her "in a manner worthy of the saints." The Greek adverb translated "in a manner worthy" (αξιως) would normally be rendered *worthily*, but for the sake of clarity of this context, we prefer the above translation. Paul's point is that as a sister in the Lord she has *worth* (αξιος) and *equal value*; she deserves the same treatment from the saints as a man (Gal. 3:28).

They are not only to receive Phoebe, but beyond that, they are to "provide for her in what ever matter she may have need" of them. The Greek verb translated "provide" (παραστντε) means that they are to *place beside her* or *put at her disposal* anything which they might have which she needs. It appears to me that this may be interpreted to mean that they are to provide for her anything she might need in terms of either work or provisions.

Paul is only asking them to do something for Phoebe which she has already done for others. He says that "she has been a helper of many and of me myself." The Greek noun translated "helper" (προστατις) basically means *one who stands before*, hence, a *leader* or *protectress*. In a fragment of papyri it has the meaning of *to look after* or *to take care of*. It may be interpreted to mean that Phoebe was a helper in caring for and looking out for others, or that as a leader she protected other believers. She may have been one of the chief women mentioned in Acts, and as such, she may have occupied an important office in Cenchrea which enabled her to act as a protectress of early Christians (Acts 13:50; 17:4, 12).

In the light of what Paul says about Phoebe in this chapter (vv. 1-2), she was a *minister* (διακονον) of the church in Cenchrea. He highly recommends her to the Roman church and asks them to receive her on a par with her male counterparts. He encourages them to provide all that she needs, which may be for her ministry in their midst or for her ministry beyond them. The Greek noun he uses to describe her (προστατις) has the basic meaning of one who *stands before, first* or *a front-rank person.* She was a very important *patron* of many believers and also of Paul himself.

3. ***"Greet Prisca and Aquila my fellow-workers in Christ Jesus,"***

Prisca is Aquila's wife. The other two times she is mentioned in Paul's Epistles her name is also Prisca (πρισκαν; 1 Cor. 16:19; 2 Tim. 4:19). The three times Luke refers to her in Acts he calls her *Priscilla* (πρισκιλλαν; Acts 18:2, 18, 26). Aquila's name is associated with Prisca and Priscilla in the six above passages.

Paul first met Aquila and Prisca in Corinth (Acts 18:1-2). They were Jews; they had been born in Pontus and had been living in Rome until a decree by Claudius against the Jews forced them to leave. They were tent-makers by trade (Acts 18:3).

It appears that Aquila and Prisca, after being forced to leave Rome, first lived in Corinth (Acts 18:1-2). Following this they went to Ephesus (Acts 18:24-26). While there they explained the Gospel of the Grace of God to Apollos (Acts 18:24-26). They were still in Ephesus when Paul wrote First Corinthians. A church was meeting in their house, and Paul most likely stayed with them during his long ministry in that city (1 Cor. 16:19; Acts 19:8-10). They apparently left Ephesus with Paul or soon after and returned to Rome (Acts 20:1). When Paul wrote this epistle they were already in Rome with a church meeting in their house (v. 5).

Paul says that this husband-wife team are "my fellow-workers in Christ Jesus." Out of the thirteen times the Greek word for "fellow-workers" (συνεργους) is used in the New Testament, Paul uses it twelve times. It basically speaks of those who *work with* or *labor together with.* Since Paul's total life was committed to the propagation of the Gospel of the Grace of God, this meant that all who worked with him, either in the physical or spiritual sphere, were true fellow workers.

Paul and Aquila and Prisca labored together in the same occupation, tentmaking, their mutual trade, that they might freely proclaim the Gospel (Acts 18:3-4; 1 Cor. 9:15-18). We know that they were mutually engaged in tentmaking in Corinth, and we presume they did the same in Ephesus. Furthermore, as fellow-workers, Aquila and Prisca must have played a very important part in establishing the churches at Corinth, Ephesus, and probably by proxy and presence at Rome. They apparently had keen insight into the Gospel of God's Grace (Acts 18:26), realized that they had been bought with the price of Christ's Blood, and all that they did was as unto Him (Col. 3:23).

4. ***"who on behalf of my life laid down their own necks, for whom not only I give thanks but also all the churches of the Gentiles,"***

An even more literal translation of the first clause would be: "who on behalf of my life placed under [υπεθηκαν] their own necks." This suggests that there was a time when Paul's life was in jeopardy, and Aquila and Prisca offered to lay down their necks "on behalf of" (υπερ), *instead of* him; i.e., they were willing to bare their necks to the executioner's ax for his sake. We have no specific information on when Aquila and Prisca intervened on behalf of Paul's life, but it was probably either in Corinth (Acts 18:12-17) or Ephesus (Acts 19:28-34; 2 Tim. 4:14-15). According to Second Corinthians 11:16-28, Paul lived a dangerous, perilous life, the details of which we have no record; therefore, we can only suggest certain possibilities.

Speaking of Aquila and Prisca, and their readiness to die for him, Paul says, "for whom not only I give thanks but also all the churches of the Gentiles." After having examined the grammatical construction used in this verse, and observing how the Greek verb translated "give thanks" (ευχαριστω) is quite consistently

used in relation to God rather than men, Paul is here *giving thanks* to God for what He did through Aquila and Prisca.

Both Paul and all the churches express their gratitude to God for using Aquila and Prisca to save Paul's life. All believers, who recognize Paul's distinct ministry on behalf of the Church, the message of Grace which has been given to us through him, join in thanksgiving to God who rescued him via Aquila and Prisca.

5. ***"and the church in their house. Greet my beloved Epaenetus, who is the first convert to Christ of Asia."***

The sentence, of which the forepart of this verse is a part, began with verse 3. The flow of thought is as follows: "Greet Prisca and Aquila my fellow-workers in Christ Jesus . . . and the church in their house." Paul's main point in this long sentence is that those who receive this letter are to give his greetings to Prisca and Aquila and to the church which was meeting in their house in Rome.

Now let us look at the implications of the statement "the church in their house." This would seem to imply that they were already back in Rome with a church meeting in their house when Paul wrote this epistle. This does not imply that this was the only church in Rome, for there were probably several in-house church groups which collectively constituted the church at Rome. Whether or not they had a larger place where the in-house church groups could assemble is questionable, particularly, in view of impending persecution. The situation in Ephesus might throw some light on this, for apparently a church was meeting there in the house of Aquila and Prisca and also in the school of Tyrannus (1 Cor. 16:19).

Next, Paul says, "Greet my beloved Epaenetus." Since this is the only time this name appears in the New Testament, all the information we have about him is in this verse. Paul refers to him as "my beloved" (αγαπητον μου), which means that in a special way he was the *object of Paul's love*. Also, he is said to be the "first-fruits of Asia unto Christ." The Greek noun translated "first-fruits" (απαρχη) speaks of the *first offering, first portion* or *firstling.* In this context Paul is obviously referring to Epaenetus as the *first convert of Asia*, possibly of Ephesus. He has since moved to Rome and is working with the believers there.

6. ***"Greet Mary, who many times labored hard for you."***

This in the only time Paul refers to a person by the name of "Mary" (Μαριαμ). In view of the frequency of this name in the New Testament, we will not speculatively try to identify this woman. Whoever she was, one thing is certain, she had a working concern for the believers in Rome. Paul says that "Many times [she] labored hard for you." This may also be rendered, with respect to *many things* she *toiled until she was weary* for your benefit. Paul does not tell us the kind of work in which she was so deeply involved, but he does emphasize that they were the *objects of it*; she was doing it for them.

7. ***"Greet Andronicus and Junias, my kinsmen, and my fellow prisoners, who are eminent among the apostles, who also have been in Christ before me."***

This is the only time the names Andronicus and Junias appear in the New Testament; therefore, all the information available is in this verse. Both of these names are in the masculine gender, hence, refer to two men.

Paul says that Andronicus and Junias are his "kinsmen" (συγγενεις); they are *relatives* and have a *common lineage.* In Romans 9:3 Paul refers to all Jews as being his kinsmen according to the flesh. These two men were *definitely Jews*; in fact, they may have been even closer and were considered relatives of Paul.

Paul speaks of them as being his "fellow-prisoners" (συναιχμαλωτους). This compound Greek noun depicts them as being *captives with Paul*. Since Paul was not in custody when he wrote this epistle, they could not have been fellow--prisoners with him; therefore, he is apparently affirming that they together are *fellow-captives of Christ.* This is confirmed in Philemon 23, where Paul speaks of Epaphras as being his fellow-captive *in Christ Jesus*. As those who have been captured and made alive in Christ, they are serving Him.

Paul says that these two Jews occupy an eminent position among the apostles. The Greek word translated "eminent" (επισημοι) means that they are *distinguished, noted* and *prominent* individuals among the apostles. We must keep in mind that Paul specifically names nine other apostles who were associated with him. Andronicus and Junias are two of these. These Apostles have a Church related ministry. They must not be confused with the Twelve Apostles who have a Kingdom related ministry. It appears that Peter and John play a dual role as apostles - Now apostles of the Church; in the future, of the Kingdom.

Furthermore, Paul adds that these two Jewish apostles "have been in Christ before me." The Greek preposition translated "before" (προ), together with the perfect tense, strongly affirms that Andronicus and Junias had been put in Christ *before, in advance of,* and *prior to Paul.* This statement refutes the teaching that Paul was the first one to be saved by the Blood of Christ (α teaching which results from the wrong interpretation of the Greek word "πρωτω" in First Timothy 1:16).

8. ***"Greet Ampliatus, my beloved in the Lord."***

This is another name which is mentioned only here in the New Testament. Observe that in this list of those to be greeted, Paul generally mentions something which characterizes each person. In this verse, however, he says nothing about Ampliatus, who he is or what he has done. Instead, he expresses his heartfelt attachment to him, saying, he is "my beloved in the Lord" (αγαπητον μου εν κυριω), which means that he is the *object of my love* and *the recipient of my love* as a brother in the Lord. This reminds us of God the Father's consistent relationship with His Son recorded in the Synoptic Gospels (Matt. 3:17; Mark 9:7; Luke 9:35).

9. ***"Greet Urbanus, our fellow-worker in Christ, and Stachys my beloved."***

The name Urbanus appears only here in the New Testament. Paul refers to him as a "fellow-worker" (συνεργον), *one who labors together with him* in the work of Christ. This statement merely identifies Urbanus as a fellow-worker. We are not told whether he had been a member of Paul's evangelistic/teaching team, working personally with him, or whether he was at that time his fellow-worker in Rome. It would seem logical to think that he had received practical training under Paul, and that as Paul writes this epistle he was helping the believers in Rome.

Again we observe that the name Stachys is used only here. Paul also refers to him as his beloved. What we said in verse 8 about Ampliatus applies to Stachys. They are both the recipients of Paul's love.

10. ***"Greet Apelles, the approved in Christ. Greet those from the family of Aristobulus."***

These two names appear only in this verse. In case anyone might wonder, the name "Apelles" (Απελλην) is in the masculine gender, and speaks of a man. He is one who is "approved" (δοκιμον), *who has been tested, tried,* and *proved* as faithful and capable in Christ. We don't know who Aristobulus is, but Paul asks the Roman believers to greet those of his household or family. All these greetings emphasize the close personal relationship Paul maintained with fellow-believers.

11. ***"Greet Herodion, my kinsman. Greet those from the family of Narcissus, those being in the Lord."***

As we observed in verse 7, the Greek noun translated "kinsman" may be used here to refer to a fellow-Jew, fellow-children of Abraham, or it may be used with reference to one who is more closely related, commonly referred to as a relative. We can positively affirm that Herodion was a Jew, but we cannot establish how distant a relative he was to Paul. Since Herodion's name is used only in this verse, the only thing we can say for sure is that he was a Jew.

Paul also asks them to greet the household or family of Narcissus. The only information we have about Narcissus is in this verse. We cannot even positively affirm that he himself knew the Lord. Since Paul sends greetings to those in the family "being in the Lord," we interpret this to mean that he limits his greeting to those who know the Lord (cf. Eph. 6:24).

12. ***"Greet Tryphaena and Tryphosa, who are toiling in the Lord. Greet Persis the beloved, who in many things toiled in the Lord."***

All three names in this verse appear only here. All these names are in the feminine gender, which means that Paul is speaking of three women. He says that the first two "are toiling in the Lord" (κοπιωσας εν κυριω). This Greek word is a present participle, and it means that these two women were *continuously laboring until they were weary and faint.* Whether they were engaged in physical labor or in giving out the Word (Paul does not distinguish between the two) both are toiling and laboring in and for the Lord.

In speaking of the third woman, Persis, she is called beloved. Paul says that in many things, or many times, she "toiled" (εκοπιασεν) and *labored until weary*

and exhausted. Since Paul uses a different Greek word to describe how the women worked, a word which commonly means toil and work to the point of weariness and exhaustion, one wonders if it was because they worked harder or because they became weary sooner. It is also possible that the work the women were engaged in had more *drudgery*, wearisomeness, and tediousness associated with it; therefore, Paul switches to the Greek word "κοπιαω" in its participle and verbal forms.

13. ***"Greet Rufus, the elect in the Lord, and his mother and mine."***

The only other time the name Rufus is mentioned in the New Testament is in Mark 15:21. This verse says that Simon the Cyrenian, who was compelled to carry Jesus' cross, was the father of Alexander and Rufus. Considering the influence Jesus must have had on Simon, and via him on his son, this may be the same Rufus.

Furthermore, Paul describes Rufus as being "the elect in the Lord." He was one who had been *spoken-out, selected* and *chosen* to belong to the Lord. If he was the son of a Cyrenian farmer (Mark 15:21), probably a Gentile, it would be most logical for Paul to speak of him as the elect. His elect position is in the Lord. The only way God who is just can justify sinners is in Christ on the basis of His substitutionary death (Rom. 3:26).

In speaking of Rufus, what does Paul mean by the statement, "his mother and mine"? Is Paul implying that they both have the same physical mother? If this was true he probably would have referred to Rufus as being his brother. We prefer the explanation that the mother of Rufus had treated Paul like a son, very solicitous for his physical welfare, and as a result he responds to her motherly love by referring to her as his mother.

14. ***"Greet Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas, and the brethren with them."***

This is the only time the names in this verse appear in the New Testament. All these names are in the masculine gender and refer to men. Having named these five men, Paul adds, "and the brethren with them." We suggest that a group such as this may have been one of the in-house churches in the city of Rome.

15. ***"Greet Philologus and Julia, Nereus and his sister, and Olympas, and all the saints with them."***

In the first part of this verse we have four names listed and a sister. Three of the names are masculine, hence, refer to men. One of the names is feminine (Julia), and the unnamed sister, which makes two women. Associated with these five, Paul adds, "and all the saints with them." It appears to me that those mentioned in this verse may well represent another in-house church in Rome. It appears that possibly the two women mentioned may play a prominent part in the group.

16. ***"Greet one another with a holy kiss. All the churches of Christ greet you."***

Believers are to greet one another with a holy kiss. The reciprocal pronoun "αλληλους" indicates that each one is to take the initiative in greeting the other one in this manner.

The Greek word translated "kiss" (φιληματο) has this meaning in both the classical and koine Greek. Negatively speaking, it is to be a separated-from-the-common kiss, a non-flesh motivated kiss. Positively speaking, it is to be a "holy" (αγιω), separated-unto-God kiss, i.e., an expression which manifests spiritual concern for another believer (1 Cor. 16:20; 2 Cor. 13:12; 1 Thess. 5:26). It is interesting to note that this custom is not mentioned in Paul's post-Acts epistles.

In addition to himself sending the believers at Rome greetings, Paul says, "All the churches of Christ greet you." The Greek word for "church" (εκκλησια) is only used five times in this epistle, all in this chapter. This is the only time Paul uses the phrase "the churches of Christ" (αι εκκλησιαι του Χριστου) in his epistles. In his earlier epistles he generally uses the phrase *the churches* or *church of God,* an exception being First Timothy 3:5, 15, where he refers to the church of God. In his later epistles, post-Acts epistles, he quite consistently knits Christ and the Church together. This is particularly obvious in Ephesians and Colossians.

In summarizing, let us consider the significance of studying the greetings sent to the above individuals and groups of believers. It is my conviction that we can glean, through a list such as this, many important truths about both Paul and the early believers to whom he was writing, plus many historical tidbits.

What do we learn about the Apostle Paul? First, he remembered individual's names; they were personal friends. Second, he remembered each individual's strong points and commended him or her for the same. Third, he had a close relationship with families, and knew the spiritual needs of each one.

What do we learn about early believers? First, it amazes us how much these people moved from place to place, for many whom Paul knew were living in Rome when he wrote. Second, we get further insight in the number of believing Jews, and even relatives of Paul, who were involved in the church at Rome. Third, we are impressed with the role which some women played in the church at Rome.

17. ***"And I beseech you, brethren, to mark those causing the divisions and the offences contrary to the teaching which you learned, and turn aside from them."***

The Greek phrase translated "I beseech you" (παρακαλω υμας) may also be rendered *I exhort you and urge you*, brethren, "to mark" (σκοπειν), *note*, and *keep an eye on* those causing the divisions. This indicates that there were some individuals among the Roman believers who were "causing" (ποιουντας), *making*, and *producing* "divisions" (διχοστασιας), *dissensions*, and *separations* in the church. They are to also watch out for those causing "offences" (σκανδαλα), *stumbling*, and *tripping* of believers.

We recognize that often the Truth of the Gospel divides people, and the Cross of Christ offends them (9:33; 1 Cor. 1:23). This is inevitable, since sinners, left to themselves, have a natural antipathy toward the Gospel. On the other hand, in this verse, Paul is talking about false teaching which causes divisions and offences among those who have been taught the Truth. He urges them to be on guard against any person who may teach "contrary" (παρα) or *beyond* that which he had taught them (Gal. 1:8). One of the most common ways of teaching contrary to the Gospel of God's Grace, is *by adding beyond it the Mosaic Law.*

What attitude should believers take toward those who teach contrary to and beyond the Gospel of Grace? Paul's answer is clear - "turn aside from them." The Greek verb translated "turn aside" (εκκλινετε) is in the present tense and imperative mood, which means that Paul is commanding them to continuously *lean away, decline,* and *don't listen to them.* This word does not necessarily mean that believers are to break all relations with those who teach contrary, for how could they correct them, but it does mean that they are *to turn away from their false teaching.*

18. ***"For such ones do not serve our Lord Christ, but their own belly, and through kind speech and fair speech they deceive the hearts of the innocent."***

Speaking with reference to those who teach contrary to the Gospel of Grace, Paul says, "For such ones do not serve our Lord Christ." The Greek phrase translated "such ones" (οι τοιουτοι) means that men who have *such qualities* as described above, who are teaching contrary to and beyond what Paul taught, do not render service to our Lord, the Person of Christ. Observe, Paul says that they do not serve *our Lord,* rather than saying they do not serve *their Lord*, for he obviously felt that they did not know Christ as their Lord.

Instead of rendering service to Christ, they serve "their own belly." When Paul says that they serve their own "belly" (κοιλια) or *stomach*, he may have reference to their Epicurean-like philosophy, of which the stomach was a very important part. On the other hand, they may have been greedy humanists, who were preying on these believers as a way of gain, a way to fill their bellies.

These men were psychological masters at deceiving, for Paul says, "Through kind-speech and fair-speech they deceive the hearts of the innocent." The compound Greek words translated "kind speech" (χρηστολογιας) and "fair speech" (ευλογιας) mean that through *good, gracious* and *benign speech and words* plus through *flattery*, they deceive the innocent.

The Greek verb translated "deceive" (εξαπατωσιν) is an emphatic compound word which means *to deceive thoroughly* or *completely.* Paul is not saying that these men are trying to deceive the innocent, but that *they do thoroughly deceive and delude* the hearts of the "innocent" (ακακων), *simple, artless,* and *ignorant*. It is not enough to just explain to new converts the issues pertaining to salvation. We must establish them in the Truth of the Gospel preached by the Apostle Paul, which he calls the Mystery (v. 25).

19. ***"For your obedience has reached unto all; therefore I rejoice over you, but I want you to be wise unto the good, and uninvolved unto the evil."***

Even though the naive and ignorant have been deceived by smooth-mouthed language manipulators, the obedience of most of the Roman believers "has reached unto all." The Greek word translated "obedience" (υπακοη) is a compound word which literally means *to obey what is heard,* hence, *submissiveness* and *compliance to the Word of God*. Paul, even though he was separated from them by the Adriatic Sea, knew that their obedience to the Gospel had "reached" (αφικετο), *arrived*, and *come to* all men. This may be interpreted in two ways: 1) their Godly lifestyle was affecting all men; or 2) the report of their obedience to God was heard by all men (1 Thess. 1:8-10).

Because of their widespread obedience, Paul says, "therefore I rejoice over you." Unlike a translation, which must be short and to the point, in a commentary we have room to expand and explain. This is true in bringing out the basic meaning of the clause before us. Paul's thought here is that he rejoices *on the basis of* (εφ') them. The fact that they have been obedient to the Word of God, and that this obedience has positively affected many, is the basis for his rejoicing. We rejoice in our privilege to teach the Gospel of God's Grace, but we rejoice much more when we see believers obeying what they have been taught (2 John 4).

In contrast to the naive and ignorant portrayed in the preceding verse, Paul says "I want you to be wise unto the good." The Greek verb translated "want" (θελω) means that he *willed* and *wished* that they would be "wise" (πσοφους), *intelligent*, and *learned* unto the good. The Greek phrase translated "unto the good" (εις το αγαθον) literally means *unto the end of that which is good*. God's will for the Roman believers, via Paul, was that they might be learned in the gospel of His Grace, unto the end that they might do that which is good, namely, not be deceived by false teachers, and maintain good works (2 Thess. 2:3; Titus 3:14).

Furthermore, Paul wants them to be "uninvolved unto the evil." The Greek phrase rendered "uninvolved unto the evil" (ακεραιους εις τον κακον) literally means that they are to be *unmixed, not to have evil mixed with good;* hence, they are not to be involved in that which has evil associated with it. This is in accord with Paul's statement: "Abhor that which is evil; cleave to that which is good" (12:9).

20. ***"And the God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet. The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you."***

Five times in his epistles Paul refers to God as *the God of peace*. Much more frequently he refers to peace as being from God. It is interesting that in this context, in which Paul desires God to declare war against Satan, that he should call Him the God of peace. We must keep in mind that God is the God of peace *to His own people*. On the other hand, Satan is the arch-enemy of this peace. If God's people are going to enjoy God's peace in this present age of Grace, God Himself must, on behalf of them, "bruise" (συντριψει), *crush*, and *break* Satan under their feet.

21. ***"Timothy my fellow-worker greets you, and Lucius and Jason and Sosipater, my kinsmen."***

Since this is the first and only time Timothy is mentioned in this Epistle to the Romans, we will give a brief profile of him. First, he was *from Lystra* in Cilicia. Second, he was of *mixed parents*, a Jewish mother and Gentile father (Acts 16:2). Third, *Paul chose him* on his second missionary journey (Acts 16:3). Fourth, he had a *unique love* for both the Lord and fellow-believers (Phil. 2:20-22). Fifth, Paul sent him as a *special envoy* to various churches (1 Cor. 4:17; Phil. 2:19; 1 Thess. 3:1-2; 1 Tim. 1:3). Sixth, he faithfully served with Paul until the end (2 Tim. 4:21).

Timothy, who was with Paul when he wrote this epistle, sends his greetings to the Roman believers. Since he was with Paul most of the time he apparently knew many of those whom Paul knew in Rome.

Lucius also sends his greetings to the Roman believers. His name is mentioned only one other time in the New Testament. We are first introduced to him at Antioch of Syria. He and Paul and three others were ministering in the church which was there (Acts 13:1). We assume that these two names belong to the same person.

Another person who sends his greetings to the Roman believers is *Jason*. His name is mentioned four times in Acts 17:5-9. He was a protector of the Apostle Paul while he was in Thessalonica. Again, we assume that these two Jasons represent the same person. He may be with Paul as he writes this epistle, or he may have seen Paul as he went south through Thessalonica. Jason may have asked him to greet the Romans for him (Acts 20:1-2).

Sosipater likewise sends his greetings to the Roman believers. Since this is the only time his name is mentioned in the New Testament, all that we know about him is in this verse.

Speaking of Lucius, Jason, and Sosipater, Paul says that they are "my kinsmen." We have observed that for Paul a kinsman could be anyone from a close relative to one who was a descendant of Abraham. Since he uses this word three times in this chapter (vv. 7, 11, 21), he is undoubtedly referring to Jews in general; however, some may have been closer relatives. One gets the impression that many Jews were associated with Paul and affiliated with the church at Rome.

22. ***"I Tertius, who wrote this epistle, greet you in the Lord."***

This is the only time the name Tertius appears in the New Testament. We cannot say whether he was traveling with Paul, or whether he resided in the city from which Paul was dictating this epistle. In view of Paul's high standard for accuracy, and the grammatical construction of this epistle, he may have been a believer who was a professional amanuensis. The fact that he identifies himself as the one who wrote the epistle suggests that he may not have been known to the Roman believers.

23. ***"Gaius, the host of me and all the church greets you. Erastus, the treasurer of the city and Quartus the brother, greet you."***

Paul speaks of one by the name of Gaius three other times in his epistles. John refers to a Gaius once (2 John 1). During the riot in Ephesus, Gaius and Aristarchus were seized. They are described as fellow-travelers with Paul, and also as Macedonians.

According to Acts 20:4, we have information about a Gaius who is a *Derbian* (πδερβαιος), apparently from the city of Derbe, who is traveling with Paul.

According to First Corinthians 1:14, one by the name of Gaius was baptized by Paul, apparently one of the early and important converts in Corinth.

Finally, in Third John 1, John speaks of the beloved Gaius who is an elder. We know that John writes to many of the churches which Paul was instrumental in establishing either directly or indirectly (Acts 19:10).

Summarizing, as we consider the above citations, are we to conclude that there were several persons named Gaius? We know that there was a Gaius at Corinth, one whom Paul baptized. Could this same Gaius have traveled with Paul? Could he have moved to Macedonia and lived there long enough to have been called a Macedonian? Could he also have moved to Derbe in Cilicia and remained there long enough to have been called a Derbian?

Our answer to the last two questions above is no. We believe, according to Paul's record, that there were probably three different person's named Gaius. First, there is Gaius of Corinth. Second, there is Gaius who is distinguished as a Macedonian. Third, there is another Gaius who is distinguished as a Derbian. It appears that both the latter two did some traveling with Paul (Acts 19:29; 20:4-6).

Granting that the above conclusions are correct, and that Paul's host was the Gaius in Corinth, also the host of "all" (οληις), *the whole*, and *entire* church there, which implies that it was a sizable church, it *follows that Paul wrote this Epistle to the Romans from Corinth.*

According to Acts 20:1-3, after Paul left riot-torn Ephesus he crossed over to Macedonia, moved on south to Greece, and spent three months in that country. Since the best known church in Greece was in Corinth, which previously had many problems, we surmise that he spent most or all the three months teaching them. During this time he apparently wrote the epistle to the Roman believers. This would have been approximately one or two years after he had written the Corinthians from Ephesus (Acts 19:8-10).

Next, Paul says that "Erastus, the treasurer of the city and Quartus the brother, greet you." In Acts 19:22 we learn that Erastus had been with Paul in Ephesus. He, together with Timothy, ministered unto Paul. In Second Timothy 4:20, we are informed that Erastus remained in Corinth.

Paul says that Erastus is the "treasurer" (οικονομος), *manager*, or a *steward* of the city. Presumably he held this position in the city of Corinth. The status of Erastus, together with the apparent affluency of Gaius, with a house large enough for the church to meet in, suggests that there were some influential people associated with the church in Corinth.

The name Quartus appears only here in the New Testament. ALL that Paul says about him is that he is a brother, apparently a believer in the Corinthian church.

Due to lack of manuscript evidence verse 24 does not apppear in the United Bible Societies' Greek text. Generally speaking, it is a duplication of the last brief sentence in verse 20, and reads, "The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen." In the light of the content, Paul's warning against those who teach contrary and beyond what he taught, it is logical that verse 20 should end with the words: "The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you."

25. ***"To the one who is able to establish you according to my gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery which has been kept silent in times eternal, "***

It is most amazing that the so-called Majority Greek Text, in spite of all the evidence, does not include verses 25-27! All the recent versions, which we have examined, recognize these verses as a genuine part of the original manuscript. They emphasize the distinct Gospel which Paul proclaimed, which he calls "my gospel" in the second chapter (v. 16).

These verses are couched in the form of a prayer. Paul is addressing God the Father in the name of Jesus Christ (v. 27). His desire is that God might establish them in accordance with the truth revealed in the Gospel committed unto him, which truth has been manifested in the current prophetic writings, i.e., particularly through his writings and those of others associated with him (Eph. 3:5).

Paul opens this closing prayer with the words: "To the one who is able to establish you." First, keep in mind that all prayer is always addressed *to God the Father*. He alone is "able" (δυναμενω), has *the ability,* and *the power* to establish believers. The consistent testimony of the New Testament is that God the Father, in the process of establishing believers, transmits this ability and power through His Holy Spirit, i.e., via God the Holy Spirit.

What does Paul mean by the phrase "establish you"? The Greek infinitive translated "establish" (στηριξαι) means that Paul is committing them to one who is able to make them *stand fast, be steadfast* and *unmovable* in their spiritual relationship with Himself. In the light of those who were teaching that which was contrary to the Gospel of Grace (vv. 17-18), there was certainly a real need for Paul to emphasize prayer that they might be made *solid* and *firm* in the Truth (1:11; 2 Thess. 2:17; 3:3).

Since it is very important that one be established in the right truth, Paul specifies, I want you established "according to my gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ." This means that their steadfastness and solidness must be "according to" (κατα), *in keeping with*, and *conforming* to the Gospel which Paul preached. He uses the pronoun "my" (μου) three times to depict his relation to the Gospel (2:16; 16:25; 2 Tim. 2:8). He uses the pronoun "our" (ημων) three times (2 Cor. 4:3; 1 Thess. 1:5; 2 Thess. 2:14). Also, three times he speaks of the gospel preached "by me" (υπ' εμου; 1 Cor. 15:1; Gal. 1:11; 2:2).

Having told them that they are to be established according to his gospel, Paul adds, "and the preaching of Jesus Christ." The conjunction translated "and" (και) may also be translated even; i.e., they are to be established in his gospel, *even the preaching of Jesus Christ.* In this case the phrase "the preaching of Jesus Christ" would have adjectival significance. The preaching of Jesus Christ *defines* and *explains* what Paul's *"my gospel"* really is - concentration on the Person of Jesus Christ.

We recognize that Jesus Christ may be preached as set forth in Old Testament prophecy, or as presented in the Synoptic Gospels, but Paul says that he is preaching Him "according to the revelation of the mystery which has been kept silent in times eternal." In contrast to the manner in which Jesus Christ was proclaimed in the Old Testament and the Synoptic Gospels, as God incarnate in the form of human flesh, Paul says that Now, according to his gospel, "we know no one according to the flesh; even if we have known Christ according to the flesh, but Now we no longer know" Him (2 Cor. 5:16).

Jesus Christ is now seated at the right hand of God the Father in the heavenlies in resurrection-body form (8:34; Col. 3:1). In this position He is the *Spiritual Head* of the spiritual organism, the Church, which is designated as His Body (Eph. 1:22-23). In other words, the Jesus Christ Paul was preaching gives to Him a *new role* in God's present manner of bringing men into a relationship with Himself.

If Paul is not following the truth in the Old Testament and in the Synoptic Gospels, what is he following? His answer is: my Gospel is "according to the revelation of the mystery." The Greek noun translated "mystery" (μυστηριου) means *that which is hidden, concealed* or *secret.* The Greek word rendered "revelation" (αποκαλυψιν) speaks of *an uncovering, revealing* and *disclosing* of something which has been concealed. In the light of these definitions, the phrase the "revelation of the mystery" speaks of *truth which has been hidden and concealed and now is in a revealed and disclosed state.*

Paul says that this truth "has been kept silent in times eternal." The Greek verb translated "has been kept silent" is a perfect, passive participle. As such it means that God has *kept silent, quiet* and *said nothing* about the Mystery. Now long had God kept it a Secret? Paul's answer is: "in times eternal," literally, in times/ages. Multiply or add these two words, anyway you interpret them, God had kept the Mystery Truth hidden during the past eternities.

26. ***"but has been manifested now through the prophetic writings, according to a commandment of the eternal God, having been made known unto obedience of the faith unto all the Gentiles,"***

Now that the Mystery has been exposed, and consists of *revealed Truth* for this present time, Paul explains the agency through which God had manifested it. First, he says that it "has been manifested" (φανερωθεντος), *brought to light, openly displayed,* and *made obvious* "Now" (νυν), i.e., *at the time when Paul was writing*. The implication is that prior to Paul it was eternally hidden, but Now God has broken His silence: *He has manifested it* as the passive voice indicates. It is

not a matter of Paul discovering it, but it rests totally on the fact that *God brought it to light* at that point of time in history.

The method God chose through which to make the hidden mystery known was the "prophetic writings" (γραφων προφητικον). Note, the noun translated *writings* may also be rendered *scriptures*. The Greek word translated "prophetic" is an *adjective*. It tells us *what kind* of writings Paul is speaking about in this verse. They are writings which have been written by prophets or that are prophetic in nature.

Many, in translating this verse, get what Paul is saying here mixed up with the Old Testament prophets. Now can the Old Testament prophets be brought into the picture here when Paul has made it plain that what he is talking about had been kept silent? To attribute what Paul says here to Old Testament prophets is a contradiction (cf. Eph. 3:5; Col. 1:26).

The phrase "prophetic writings" (γραφων προφητικων), as used by Paul in this verse, obviously refers to what Paul and those associated with him were writing. Since Paul is the only one who specifically claims that the Mystery was revealed unto him, he was the basic disseminator of this Church Truth unto the apostles and prophets working together with him. The main emphasis of this verse is not on the one to whom the Mystery was revealed, but on *how it was manifested*, displayed and made known among men.

In the light of what John writes in his Gospel and epistles and what Peter writes in his epistles, and the alignment of the same with Mystery Truth, we are forced to conclude that what they wrote, particularly in their epistles, would fall into the category of the "prophetic writings." We recognize that the Gospel of John was written in the light of the Mystery Truth, by the Holy Spirit through John, and that it contains many truths which are common to both the Messianic Kingdom and the Church. Truths in this Gospel which are in accordance with what Paul has written in his epistles, and which are in accordance with the principle of progressive revelation, are applicable to this present Church age. This means that in the final analysis these writings must be evaluated in the light of the post-Acts Pauline Epistles.

Furthermore, Paul affirms that this Mystery Truth was manifested through the "prophetic writings" according to a "commandment" (επιταγην), *arrangement*, and *charge* of the eternal God. Since Paul was the key one to whom the Mystery was revealed (1 Cor. 2:7-10; Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9; 1 Tim. 1:11-14; et α1.), it appears that what he says in First Corinthians 9:17 corroborates the truth in this verse, namely, that he has had a dispensation entrusted unto him. In other words, Paul did not choose his prophetic position in the Church, but the eternal God *arranged* him for it and *charged* him with it (1 Tim. 1:12-16).

One of the best examples of how the Mystery Truth revealed unto Paul was dispersed via others is seen in his relation with Timothy. According to Second Timothy 1:13-14 the sound words which Timothy had heard from Paul, referred to as a "deposit" (παραθηκην), are to be guarded by him through the Holy Spirit; i.e., he is not to allow them to be perverted (1 Tim. 6:20). Also Paul gives

Timothy the following instructions: "What you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses, commit these things to faithful men, who shall be qualified to teach others (2 Tim. 2:2; cf. Phil. 4:9).

Finally, we observe that the manifestation of the Mystery through the prophetic writings was made known "unto the obedience of the faith unto all the Gentiles." The Truth of the Mystery, as it relates to the Gentiles obeying the Gospel, closely identifies Paul as the writer of the prophetic writings (cf. 1:5; 15:18). Also, Ephesians 3:5-6 is dealing with the same subject, for we see the Spirit of God disseminating the same Mystery Truth which had been revealed to Paul and then via the apostles and prophets associated with him. Part of the Truth of the Mystery is that God is sovereignly saving Gentiles as well as Jews in this present Church age. Paul speaks of the total Truth of the Mystery as the "manifold" (πολυποικιλος) and *exceedingly variegated* wisdom of God. It is all the Truth which God has given to the church.

27. ***"to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory unto the ages. Amen."***

In verse 25 Paul commits them to God with the words, "to the one who is able to establish you according to my gospel, even the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery." Having said this, Paul explains that the Mystery had previously been kept a secret, but Now it had been manifested, particularly, the aspect of it which gives the Gentiles the privilege of becoming fellow-members of the Body of Christ.

Again in this final short paragraph, Paul prayerfully commits them "to the only wise God." He was confident that God, in His infinite wisdom, could establish them according to the Truth of the Mystery revealed in his gospel. Observe, he was not depending upon his own persuasiveness to establish them, but on the message which he had given to them, the Mystery Gospel, from an infinitely wise God. We need to acknowledge that God's elect are very special to Him, and that in His omniscience He will always provide that which is best for them.

Note, Paul commits them to God in prayer through Jesus Christ. We find a clear prayer formula in the Pauline Epistles. Prayer is always addressed to God the Father "through" (δια with the genitive case), *the agency of Jesus Christ* (1:8; 7:25; Col. 3:17). Apart from Jesus Christ and His substitutionary death on Calvary's Cross, we would have no access to God the Father; hence, we could not approach Him in prayer.

As Paul closes this epistle, he says with respect to God the Father, "to whom be the glory unto the ages." The concept of glory in the Hebrew language is *weightiness*. To extend glory to God is to attribute to Him the *most magnificent splendor we can imagine*. As Paul reflected on all that the Holy Spirit had said to and through him about the greatness of God as he wrote this epistle, he must have been overcome by the unfathomable, majestic magnificence of our eternal God!

SUMMARY

In this summary we want to give a brief resume of some of the most significant facts presented in this epistle.

First, all men are sinners, both Jews and Gentiles (3:9). Second, God has revealed a righteousness based on *the faithfulness of Jesus Christ,* which includes His absolute obedience to the Father in life and death (3:21-22). Third, this righteousness is obtained through *faith* (5:3). Fourth, believers are *identified* with both the death and postresurrection life of Jesus Christ (6:1-11).

Fifth, Jews who have died with Christ have *died to the Mosaic Law* (7:4-6). Sixth, the real purpose of the Law was to impress upon the conscience the exceeding *sinfulness of sin* (7:13). Seventh, the believer has *two natures*, one which wills to do good, and one in which evil resides (7:15-23). Eighth, the *Holy Spirit* provides the necessary dynamic to put to death the practices of the old nature (8:12-14).

Ninth, God is *sovereignly* calling and justifying individual Jews and Gentiles who are inseparably related to Him (8:28-39). Tenth, God's soteriological purpose in the Church age operates on the basis of *election* (9:11). Eleventh, behind God's elective purpose is His *mercy* to both Jews and Gentiles (9:15-16, 23). Twelfth, in view of God's mercy and compassion, believers are to live for God (12:1-2).